Chapter 5

5.1 Introduction

Each of us is unique. We all have characteristics that make us who we are. Some individuals might be more outgoing and carefree, while others might be more introverted and serious. These differences can be attributed to the differences in our personalities. Your personality, together with your values, interests and skills, is ultimately what makes you who you are. It is essential that you know who you are and how to manage yourself appropriately in various situations before entering the working world. This will aid you in choosing a career path, understanding your strengths and weaknesses, and allowing you to excel in your chosen career.

Knowing one's self is key to effective communication. How you see yourself can have a major influence on the way in which you communicate with others. The idea of 'self' comprises multiple dimensions. This unit is dedicated to developing an understanding of these multiple dimensions of the self. We will begin by developing an understanding of personality, world view, values, interests, skills, personal goals and professional goals. We then investigate how we manage the self at work by analysing our strengths and weaknesses, time management, stress management and management of professional goals. This unit will conclude by identifying ways in which to achieve work-life balance.

After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- reflect on your personality, world view, values, interests and skills;
- demonstrate adaptability, persistence, dependability and resilience;
- set personal goals;
- set professional goals;
- explore and articulate the values and principles involved in personal decision-making;
- analyse your strengths and weaknesses; and
- explain how you can differentiate yourself from the workplace crowd in terms of:

    - being aware of your strengths and weaknesses;
    - managing time, stress, attitude, priorities and goals;
    - behaving ethically at work;

- achieving work-life balance; and
- being a lifelong learner.

5.2 Key terms and definitions

The following terms and definitions are applicable to this unit:

- *Allport trait theory of personality:* This theory posited that personality was shaped by both internal and external forces acting on the individual.
- *Analytical psychology:* Established by Carl Jung, this theory broadly classifies people as either introverted or extroverted, based on their attitude toward the world. Factors taken into consideration include whether an individual relies more on thinking or feeling, or is led by sensation or intuition in their everyday life.
- *Distress:* A negative form of stress that can lead to physical and mental health problems for an individual in the long term.
- *Emotional intelligence:* Being sensitive to the feelings of others and having a good understanding of one's own emotions.
- *Eustress:* A positive form of stress that motivates an individual to complete tasks.
- *Humanist approach:* Established by Carl Rogers, this theory advanced the idea that personality develops from an individual's self-concept, which is how each person views themselves.
- *Instrumental values:* Also known as terminal values, these are the beliefs or ideas that an individual holds to be important, and assist with achieving one's desirable end state.
- *Myer-Briggs Type Indicator:* A well-known personality test that classifies people as having one of sixteen personality types. This index is based on the work of Carl Jung.
- *Neustress:* The feeling of stress experienced when one is not directly affected by events that are stressful for others.
- *Personality:* An individual's recurring emotions, interactions with others and patterns of behaviour.
- *Terminal values:* These are beliefs or ideas that an individual deems important and sees as the goal they hope to achieve before the end of their life.

- *World view:* The broad collection of values, beliefs, opinions, ideas and attitudes an individual has that will influence their outlook on how the world works.

5.3 Knowing your 'self'

People have always been interested in the concept of self. Since we first began writing, humankind has reflected on what it means to be a person. Each of us has a sense of who we are, and what our likes and dislikes are; but how well do we really understand our personality? There are many different factors that influence how we think, our values and the actions we take as a result. By identifying these factors and learning about the various theories of the self, we will come to understand more about what makes you 'you'. It is important for you to know yourself, because such self-awareness can help you to make yourself better understood and to understand others. Such an understanding can improve your personal and professional relationships, and prepare you for interacting with others in various social settings.

Some of the earliest writings about how the body and mind are connected come from ancient Greece. Medical scholars – such as Hippocrates and Galen – tried to explain human nature based on what they knew about the body. They thought that people were comprised of four 'humours' or bodily substances – i.e. blood, yellow bile, black bile and phlegm. These substances were said to impact health and personality as they moved through the body. Changes in personality were attributed to the change in balance between these fluids. In ancient Greece, the following four words were often used to describe one's temperament or emotional state (*Kheper*, n.d.):

1. *Sanguine:* From blood – happy, generous, optimistic, irresponsible.
2. *Choleric:* From yellow bile – violent, short-tempered, ambitious.
3. *Melancholic:* From black bile – depressed, introspective, sentimental.
4. *Phlegmatic:* From phlegm – calm, sluggish, cowardly.

In this way, the ancient Greeks thought that our personality or temperament was determined by the movement and balance of these substances in our bodies. If one was feeling sentimental, for example, the ancient Greeks would attribute the feeling to an individual's body producing too much black bile. If someone felt generous and somewhat irresponsible, the cause would have been thought to be an excess of blood. This led to strange practices like bloodletting, where patients would have some of their blood drained to 'balance their humours'.

Other prominent figures, such as Socrates, were concerned with ideas of 'selfhood' and 'self-knowledge', which entails 'making oneself able to be known and to know' (Moore, 2015). Another ancient Greek philosopher, Plato, is credited with saying that knowing

oneself leads to becoming *sôphrôn* (sound-minded or balanced) and *dikaios* (just or righteous), and that it also develops virtue and wisdom (Moore, 2015). The ancient Chinese philosopher Lao Tzu is attributed with saying: 'knowing others is intelligence; knowing yourself is true wisdom. Mastering others is strength; mastering yourself is true power' (Mapes, 2008). These ideas are the origins of what became an exciting field of study within psychology.

A great revival of interest in the concept of the self and existence occurred during the enlightenment movement of the 17th century. It was during this time that philosopher René Descartes first made the philosophical statement cogito ergo sum (I think; therefore, I am). Descartes claimed that each person knows this because they recognise it 'as something self-evident by a simple intuition of the mind' (*Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, 2019).

This statement, and Descartes' many works surrounding the idea, proposed that it was not just the body that made us who we are. It posited that we must consider our mind as a separate thing altogether. In fact, it was this distinction that Descartes used to separate humans from animals. In this view, animals did not think or suffer, but act only on what their bodies demanded. As humans, we have experiences and thoughts that are not part of our bodily experiences and these, in Descartes' view, are what set us apart from animals and other living things.

In the 19th century, nearly 200 years later, the work of Austrian psychologist Sigmund Freud emphasised the role of the unconscious in determining personality and behaviour (*University of Minnesota*, n.d.). Freud developed the psychoanalytic theory that refers to three personality constructs. He theorised that the 'id', or unconscious, consists of our instinctual desires and impulses that require instant fulfilment – e.g. hunger, thirst and sex. The 'superego' deals with how we perceive the societal norms and ethical codes of conduct that act on exhibited behaviours. The 'ego', or preconscious mind, serves to rationalise and act as a buffer between reality and the id as your personality changes (Schiffman and Kanuk, 2004: 123).

Today, the common belief is that the concept of the self is influenced by many different factors. It can be comprised of *physical, social, intellectual, emotional* and *spiritual aspects*. The idea that there are aspects of the self in both the conscious and unconscious aspects of our lives is also a modern one.

The 'self-concept', which is what we think of ourselves (in contrast to what others think of us), is a relatively new idea. Our self-concept is dynamic; it can change over time and with circumstances. It is influenced by our biological make-up, the environment, culture and social interaction (Ackerman, 2018). According to Rosenberg (in Ackerman, 2018), self-concept is 'the totality of an individual's thoughts and feelings having reference to [them]self as an object'.

Our self-concept affects our relationships, interpersonal communication, academic achievement and career development (Ackerman, 2018). For example, if we are always wanting people to congratulate us for our work or tell us we look good, it is possible that some of our personal relationships will become problematic as a result.

The following key aspects have been strongly linked to the self (Engler, 2013):

- Personality
- Values
- Attitudes
- Abilities
- Emotions
- Ego
- Identity

Note that one of these aspects could be more dominant than another in forming the self. For example, you may come across someone who lives in a very deep and emotional world, and therefore only ever seeks out meaningful, personal connections with other people. This can be difficult as these kinds of people may impose on others who want to spend time alone or who find it difficult to share their emotions. You may also come across someone who has fantastic sporting abilities, but does not have a good handle on their ego, because they are constantly in the public eye. If this sportsperson was constantly concerned with the public's opinion of them, it could affect their sporting performance or career.

The following sections will explore some of the elements of the self, starting with personality.

5.3.1 Knowing your personality

This section looks at the concept of personality, as suggested by various contemporary psychologists. You will come across some theories that deal with strict categories and others that talk about unique expressions of the self. Each of these theories are useful to think about where our own personalities are concerned.

Defining personality

Defining personality is a rather complex thing to do. The *American Psychological Association* (n.d.) believes that 'personality refers to individual differences in characteristic patterns of thinking, feeling and behaving'. This refers to the different traits a person has, as well as how these characteristics interact to make up a whole person. Personality is thought to be partly determined by our genetics and partly

acquired. It distinguishes people from one another and can be observed in how people interact, both with others and the environment (Holzman, 2019). There are diverging opinions among personality theorists regarding the word 'personality'. Let us take a look at these differing opinions.

Gordon Allport proposed a trait theory of personality. He asserted that there are both internal and external forces that influence personality. He used adjectives to describe personality characteristics that were observable over a long period of time. From this, he created the following three categories of personality traits:

- *Cardinal traits:* These dominate and control an individual's behaviour, such as greed or selflessness. A person has multiple cardinal traits that act together to influence his or her behaviour.
- *Central traits:* These are universal characteristics found, to varying degrees, in everyone (e.g. loyalty and kindness).
- *Secondary traits:* These are only seen under certain circumstances, such as where preferences and attitudes are concerned.

Carl Rogers adopted a different approach, the humanist approach, which stressed that each person is unique. Rogers argued that personality is developed based on one's self-concept. This self-concept is thought to stem from our perception of self-worth, self-image and our ideal self (*Journal Psyche*, n.d.). Self-worth, also known as self-esteem, refers to how we think about ourselves. A person who has high self-worth is positive about themselves and is confident and open with others. This person is able to face challenges and accept failure. Low self-worth results in a defensive attitude, avoiding challenges and denying that life can be difficult at times. These people would often be socially guarded and not want to interact with others as a result.

Rogers believed that we need to be seen positively, respected and valued by others to develop self-worth. The self-image that we then take on includes our perception of our body and personality. Our 'ideal self' is what we would like to be, and encompasses our changing goals and ambitions (McLeod, 2014). Rogers maintained that people seek balance, and overlap in these three areas to achieve self-actualisation – i.e. fulfilment of one's potential (*Journal Psyche*, n.d.).

Swiss psychologist Carl Jung is known for founding analytic psychology. He classified people according to their attitude: either *extroverted* (outward-looking) or *introverted* (inward-looking). He also distinguished between the mental functions of thinking, feeling, sensation and intuition. He noted that one or more functions are dominant in a personality (Fordham and Fordham, 2019). Katharine Cook Briggs and her daughter, Isabel Briggs Myers, developed one of the most famous personality inventories, the

Myers-Briggs Type Indicator (MBTI), which is based on Jung's theories of personality types.

According to *The Myers & Briggs Foundation* (n.d.), knowing your personality type helps with decisions about which subjects to study and which career might suit you best. An introverted person may enjoy doing research, while an extrovert may be happier as an event manager. Knowing our strengths and weaknesses helps us in dealing with our workload – particularly when the job or task does not match our personality type. The following table looks at each of the Myers-Briggs personality types.

World focus	Extroversion (E) You prefer to focus on your outer world. You tend to be socially confident, you like to know how others are doing, and you are quick to volunteer and offer opinions.	Introversion (I) You prefer to focus on your internal world. You favour observing before doing, working alone in a quiet space and setting your own standards.
Information	Sensing (S) You mainly perceive and believe the information received from the external world. You focus on basic information. You tend to be realistic and practical, and use your common sense. You like routine and order. You live in the here and now.	Intuition (N) You mainly believe information received from the internal or imaginative world. You prefer to interpret information, add meaning and think abstractly and imaginatively. You like new challenges, dislike routine, work in spurts and your focus is on the vision of the future.
Decision	Thinking (T) You process information logically and make decisions based on rational thought. You tend to be cool-headed and impartial in conflict situations.	Feeling (F) You process information that is based on emotion, and make decisions based on what you feel you should do. You are likely to consider other people and the circumstances. You focus on

		interpersonal relationships. You dislike conflict.
Structure	Judging (J) You like your environment to be ordered and structured. You utilise information to draft plans and then stick to them, but may make decisions too quickly. You are decisive, self-disciplined, have set opinions and enjoy a sense of fulfilment when things are completed.	Perceiving (P) You are open to new or different information, and like to explore alternatives. You may even improvise, as you operate unplanned. You tend to be indecisive, curious, spontaneous, flexible and tolerant.

(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Humanmetrics Inc, n.d.; Cal State LA, n.d.; and The Myers & Briggs Foundation, n.d.)

Table 5.1: Personality dimensions

There are 16 possible combinations that can be formed by using the personality dimensions in the MBTI. These combinations are as follows:

1. ESTJ (Extroverted, Sensing, Thinking, Judging)
2. ESTP (Extroverted, Sensing, Thinking, Perceiving)
3. ESFJ (Extroverted, Sensing, Feeling, Judging)
4. ESFP (Extroverted, Sensing, Feeling, Perceiving)
5. ENTJ (Extroverted, Intuitive, Thinking, Judging)
6. ENTP (Extroverted, Intuitive, Thinking, Perceiving)
7. ENFJ (Extroverted, Intuitive, Feeling, Judging)
8. ENFP (Extroverted, Intuitive, Feeling, Perceiving)
9. ISTJ (Introverted, Sensing, Thinking, Judging)
10. ISTP (Introverted, Sensing, Thinking, Perceiving)
11. ISFJ (Introverted, Sensing, Feeling, Judging)
12. ISFP (Introverted, Sensing, Feeling, Perceiving)
13. INTJ (Introverted, Intuitive, Thinking, Judging)
14. INTP (Introverted, Intuitive, Thinking, Perceiving)

15. INFJ (Introverted, Intuitive, Feeling, Judging)
16. INFP (Introverted, Intuitive, Feeling, Perceiving)

You can take a free online personality test at the following websites, both of which use personality types described by Jung and Myers-Briggs:

- https://psychcentral.com/quizzes/personality/start
- http://www.humanmetrics.com/cgi-win/jtypes2.asp

It is possible to get different results for each of these tests. This can be because questions are phrased differently or the totals are calculated in different ways. The full Myers-Briggs test is made up of over 90 two-factor questions, which means you choose one of the two available answers per question.

5.3.2 Knowing your world view

We each see the world slightly differently. Our view of the world will never be exactly the same as someone else's, even if we agree on most points. Think about a friend or family member with whom you have a lot in common, and consider whether there is something you do not agree on. This could be as common as one not liking coffee, or as contentious as your views on whether churches should pay taxes. Each of these ideas, whether conscious or not, make up what we call our world view. We will now take a more in-depth look at how we define a world view, as well as what its role is in our life.

World view defined

A world view can be described as the collection of the values, beliefs and attitudes that we hold (Shadle and Meyer, 2011: 55). De Witt (n.d.) explains the concept of world views as 'the inescapable, overarching systems of meaning that inform how we interpret, enact and co-create reality'. In other words, world views are the lenses through which we view the world. Your world view tends to shape how you perceive particular issues that you face, and what solutions you choose to solve these issues.

Just as we saw with theories of personalities, there are many philosophies of world view. Our world view has a religious aspect. This deals with issues like whether there is a god, which traditions we follow and how we conduct ourselves.

Our world view also has a cultural component. Individualistic and collective cultures are sometimes distinguished from each other based on their opposing world views. Collective cultures, which are common in China, Indonesia and West Africa, hold world views that favour strong community participation and collective democracy. Individual uniqueness is sacrificed for the greater good of the group. Individualistic cultures (e.g.

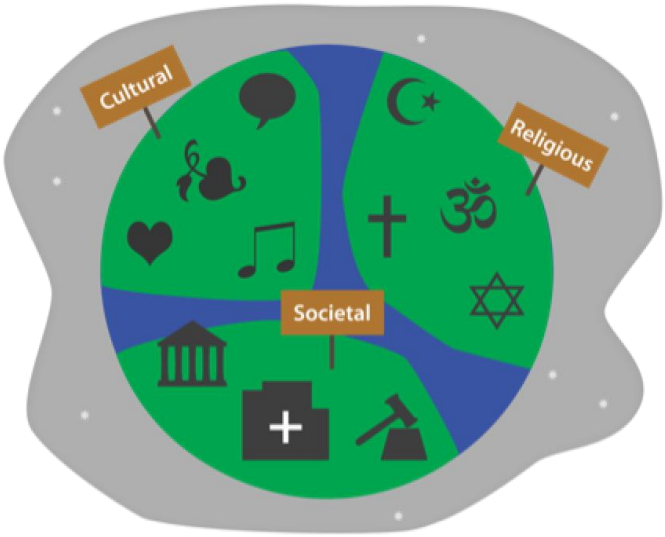
France, Germany, Netherlands and the USA), on the other hand, value individual aspirations and individual uniqueness (Robbins et al., 2004: 71; and Van Staden et al., 2007: 48–52). In South Africa, both of these world views are valued. An example of a South African world view is the notion of *ubuntu*. The underlying belief is in care and compassion culminating in group solidarity (Robbins et al., 2004: 68).

A societal aspect of our world view is embodied in the notion of conflict. Charles Darwin's theory of natural selection has its foundation in the idea of the survival of the fittest. Karl Marx expounds on the struggle between classes. Adam Smith demonstrates economic competition as motivation for success. The political nature of our world can give rise to different world views. A survival-based world view posits that exerting power and control is acceptable. An identity-based world view asserts that the strongest individuals will succeed. The unity-based perspective is that world peace, prosperity and integration are the end goal (International Education for Peace Institute, 2007).

Follow this link to watch a short video about Sam and Sasha, and their different world views:

www.youtube.com/watch?v=VXnSE0uvwzM

The video demonstrates that people are unique and, therefore, can hold different world views. It is important, especially in the workplace, to accommodate world views that are not necessarily the same as yours. You may not agree with them, but it is important to respect them. The following figure illustrates the symbols that can be associated with religious, cultural and societal aspects of our world view.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019)Figure 5.1: The three areas of a world view

The role of world view

While seeing a world view as our view of the world can seem simple, the idea can become more complex. For example, Weider and Gutierrez (2011: 50) see a world view

‘as a filter or lens from which one sees and interprets the world and all that it represents’. This definition suggests that our world view plays a critical role in helping us to decide what is right, what is wrong and why we value certain things in our lives.

Knowing your world view will help you to make more informed decisions, communicate effectively and enhance your professionalism. A world view does not have to be fixed. It is both normal and necessary, as we mature, to question our beliefs and assess their soundness and relevance. When our world view is challenged, we may find it necessary to change our beliefs to better reflect reality. This, in turn, will help us to live a more meaningful life. The transformation of a world view is not something that happens quickly. It happens through an ongoing process of conscious reflection and critical questioning. We can benefit from the exercise of questioning the assumptions we have about the way in which the world works.

5.3.3 Knowing your values

Have you ever wondered what it is that motivates you to take action? Have you ever questioned why you willingly engage in certain activities and avoid others? What is it that guides our choices and our actions? The answers to these questions and others like them can be found by studying our value system. This section will identify why knowing your personal values is necessary for developing your professionalism.

Conceptualising ‘values’

To understand values, we must first distinguish the term from two others: *norms* and *beliefs*. Norms are the rules of acceptable behaviour that most of a group or society follows (Blackwell et al., 2006: 429). For example, it is the norm to eat with a knife and fork in many cultures; in others, however, it is acceptable to eat with a spoon or chopsticks. This is also known as cultural relativism and refers to our tendency to view behaviour as acceptable within a cultural context (Williams et al., 2011: 31). We may consider eating with a knife and fork as the correct way to eat, but we need to be aware that we should not take a narrow-minded view.

Beliefs are ideas that we accept as true, even if we do not have direct proof or evidence of their correctness. They reflect our knowledge and assessment of an object, situation or person (Schiffman and Kanuk, 2004: 408). For example, you may believe that giving to charity makes you a good person.

According to Schiffman and Kanuk (2004), values are beliefs, but are fewer in number; they are lasting and difficult to change; they are not linked to specific people, objects or situations; they are widely accepted by the societal group; and they act as a guide for appropriate behaviour. Values act as standards, or criteria, for evaluating our actions and those of others. Our values are derived from our family, religious institutions,

educational institutions, life experience, the media and our peers (Blackwell et al., 2006: 430).

McShane and Von Glinow (2000: 98) identify four levels of values:

1. Personal values are developed through interpersonal interaction and our experiences.
2. Organisational values are gleaned from the company where you are employed.
3. Professional values are derived from the occupational group.
4. Cultural values are assumed from society.

Values as a 'force'

Values are one of the foundations of our perception, thoughts, motivation and behaviour (Robbins et al., 2004: 67). Robbins et al. (2004: 67) give the example of management valuing hard work and performance or seniority when determining how much each staff member gets paid. They also describe values within the categories of content and intensity. The latter refers to the importance we attach to a particular value. Ranking our values in a hierarchical order would give an indication of our individual value system. The following values can be ranked on a scale of one to five, with one being the most important and five being the least important:

- Equality
- World of beauty
- Wisdom
- Social recognition
- Pleasure

How would you rank these values?

Milton Rokeach developed the Rokeach Value Survey (RVS), which contains two sets of values. Terminal values are the goals we want to achieve in our life and relate to an 'end state'. To achieve an end state, we believe we must behave in a certain way. This behaviour is measured by instrumental values. The 18 terminal and 18 instrumental values are shown in the following table.

Terminal values (i.e. personal goals or end states)	Comfortable life Exciting life World peace National security Pleasure Salvation	Equality Freedom Happiness Social recognition	World of beauty Family security Mature love Self-respect Sense of

		True friendship Wisdom	accomplishment Inner harmony
Instrumental values (i.e. the means or way to reach end state)	Ambitious Broad-minded Capable Cheerful Clean Courageous	Forgiving Helpful Honest Imaginative Independent Intellectual	Logical Loving Obedient Polite Responsible Self-controlled

(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Robbins et al., 2004: 67; and Schiffman and Kanuk, 2004: 420)

Table 5.2: Terminal and instrumental values

Let's look at the four values that most people need to display good intrapersonal skills at work: *adaptability, persistence, dependability* and *resilience*.

Adaptability

Adaptability refers to the extent to which an individual is open-minded, flexible in his or her thinking, and willing and able to adjust his or her behaviour in accordance with what a particular situation demands. Adaptability is a value that may differ from person to person. However, it is increasingly becoming a value that is important for a happy and a well-rounded life. Modern life is demanding and change is ongoing. Adaptability is an essential value to flourish and thrive.

Persistence

Michalowicz (2017) describes persistence as not just showing up, but constantly choosing to show up. It is making the choice to keep on trying, even when it is tempting to give up. Oppong [a] (2017) states that persistence is the ability to maintain action, regardless of how one is feeling. It speaks to the drive and determination that an individual demonstrates, no matter how tough things may get. It is making the choice to keep trying even when one only wants to quit.

Having persistence as a value enables an individual to have an increased likelihood of success – both in the workplace and in their personal life. There are many examples of great entrepreneurs, such as Bill Gates or Warren Buffet, who experienced failure before becoming highly successful. If it were not for their persistence, it is unlikely they would have achieved such success.

Dependability

This refers to being reliable and trustworthy. In a professional setting, it can refer to proven competence and capabilities. Dependability is one of the most important values

an individual can possess, as it allows for great success. Again, this is true in both the individual's personal and professional life.

Dependability leads to better relationships between individuals, as people are naturally drawn to individuals who are more reliable. Nagel suggests that dependability means people will follow through with what they have promised to do – whatever this may be (in Sportron, 2011). More than making a promise to others, dependability is making a commitment to something and following through with it as far as possible.

Resilience

Those who are resilient have a drive that causes them to continue working toward their goals, no matter how challenging things can get. Cherry [a] (2018) states that resilient individuals are aware of their own emotional reactions and the reactions of others, and this aids them in managing whatever situation may arise. They generally also demonstrate an internal locus of control, meaning that they take responsibility for their own actions and do not blame external sources for what happens to them (Cherry [a], 2018).

A resilient individual also shows strong problem-solving skills, good social connection to others, has a strong survival instinct and is always willing to ask for help if need be. Resilience is a necessary value as it is this that will drive individuals forward and stop them from giving up when there are setbacks – whether these are personal or professional.

It is also important to consider the impact that your culture will have on shaping your values.

Values across cultures

It is common knowledge that diverse cultures across the globe have different value systems. It makes sense for us to acknowledge these differences so that we may better understand the attitudes, actions and perspectives of colleagues and associates from different cultures. Shalom Schwartz (in Blackwell et al., 2006: 277) proposed that there are ten universal motivational values that transcend culture, namely:

1. *Power:* Social status and prestige, and control or dominance over people and resources.
2. *Achievement:* Personal success through demonstrating competence according to social standards.
3. *Hedonism:* Pleasure or gratification for oneself.
4. *Stimulation:* Seeking excitement, novelty and challenges.
5. *Self-direction:* Independent thought and action.

6. *Universalism:* Understanding, appreciation, tolerance and protection of people and the environment.
7. *Benevolence:* Preserving and enhancing the welfare of your contact group.
8. *Tradition:* Respect, commitment and acceptance of culture, customs and religion.
9. *Conformity:* Restraining actions and impulses that could upset or harm others.
10. *Security:* Safety, harmony and stability in the society, with oneself and with others.

Using the work of social psychologist Gerard Hofstede as a basis, we will now look at some commonly cited cross-cultural values.

Individualism vs. collectivism

Individualists value independence and achieving personal goals above group goals. Collectivists value the group above self, emphasise harmony and expect protection from the group.

Power distance

This refers to the extent to which people are accepting of the distribution of power within a group or society. High-power distance acceptance means that the group members are tolerant of an unequal power distribution. The superior-subordinate relationship is well respected, and orders and commands will be executed. Low-power distance favours an equal distribution of authority and participative decision making.

Uncertainty avoidance

This is related to the stress that a group experiences when it is faced with an unknown future and the acceptance of uncertainty and vagueness. High-uncertainty avoidance cultures prefer structure and rules to guide acceptable behaviour. Low-uncertainty avoidance cultures are averse to too many rules, as they are perceived to limit one's freedom.

Achievement (masculine) vs. nurturing (feminine)

In an achievement- or masculine-oriented culture, value is placed on money and possessions – i.e. it is competitive and assertive. Gender roles are also differentiated with men displaying more assertiveness. In nurturing- or feminine-oriented cultures, gender roles are less defined, with both men and women focusing on relationships and their concern for others.

Long-term vs. short-term orientation

People may focus on the past, present or future. A long-term orientation is geared to the future. Adapting to circumstances and rational problem-solving are deemed necessary. A short-term perspective is bound in the past, honouring traditions and valuing stability and steadfastness.

Indulgence vs. restraint

There is a connection between this dimension and a long- or short-term view. Indulgence versus restraint refers to fulfilment and enjoyment of life, as opposed to the ability to control or delay the desire for satisfaction. Indulgence in a society permits fairly easy gratification; whereas a restrained society has strict social norms that regulate gratification. This dimension is also related to happiness levels.

The importance of knowing our values cannot be overemphasised. Values establish a foundation for motivation.

5.3.4 Knowing your interests

Interests can range from a passing curiosity to something with more of a long-term appeal. One's interests can include things like professional curiosities, passions and hobbies. Our focus on interests in this section, however, is related to career choices. The idea here is that you could advance your career simply by paying attention to the interests you have not yet had a chance to pursue. Developing a better understanding of those interests to which you are already committed could also enrich your career.

Relating career and interests

How are career and interests related? Current research shows that many graduates enter the business world with feelings of doubt and later feel dissatisfied with their jobs. Theorists Holland (1997) and Super (1980) conducted in-depth research on career development and provide valuable insights on the importance of knowing your interests. They advocate the notion of 'career literacy', which includes four important elements geared at informing career decisions:

1. Readiness
2. Fit
3. Support
4. Self-knowledge

Readiness refers to the skill of planning, gathering information and evaluating that information in terms of defined criteria. A 'good fit' applies when one's abilities match

the performance requirements of a job. Support includes people, such as family, friends and colleagues who encourage the student during their process of career exploration. The final element is self-knowledge, which is gained by asking personal, reflective questions.

New possibilities

Holland (1997) and Super (1980) highlight the importance of interests as one of five components under the banner of self-knowledge. They argue that an understanding of someone's goals, aptitudes, interests, values and personality provides a more rounded understanding of who they are. Their main argument is that the five components converge to provide a strong platform for identifying jobs to suit the unique capabilities of professionals.

These ideas suggest that there is an important link between discovering what you are interested in and what is motivating you. Here, a distinction is drawn between people who are vague about their pursuits and those who have a sharp focus. The main message is that knowing your interests can open up possibilities you may not have thought about. Knowing your interests is, therefore, important. They motivate you to want to explore your true potential. It makes sense that you may be more satisfied if you are doing a job that is aligned with your interests.

John Holland proposed the personality-job fit theory (Robbins et al., 2004: 91–92), which is based on the premise that there should be a match between an individual's personality and the occupational environment. When there is a good match, or congruence, job satisfaction is high and employee turnover is low. Holland outlined the following six personality types and personal characteristics, and identified occupations that would be suitable for each type (in Robbins et al., 2004: 91–92).

1. *Realistic:* This personality type enjoys activity, and physical and practical work. These types of people are comfortable working alone. These individuals may enjoy being electricians, engineers and farmers.

2. *Investigative:* These people are analytical and enjoy thinking, understanding and organising. They are intellectual, curious and independent. Career path choices include mathematics, journalism, biology and computer programming.

3. *Artistic:* Creative expression, ambiguity and lack of structure are preferable to this type of person. They tend to be emotional, idealistic and impractical. Jobs that fit this personality type are graphic design, interior design, musician, acting, art teaching and painting.

4. *Social:* Helping and developing others is the focus for these people. It stands to reason that they enjoy working with others, are gregarious, understanding and

cooperative. Counselling, social work, medical and paramedical jobs suit this personality type.

5. *Enterprising:* Attaining power and influencing others is where this confident, domineering and ambitious personality finds congruence. They are happy in leadership roles as managers, school principals or attorneys.
6. *Conventional:* This personality type likes structure, clarity, routine, rules and regulations. They are unimaginative but practical and efficient. They tend to conform and be inflexible. Job titles include accountants, bookkeepers, administrative clerks, secretaries and bank tellers.

You can take a vocational preference inventory on the following website:

www.truity.com/test/holland-code-career-test

5.3.5 Knowing your skills

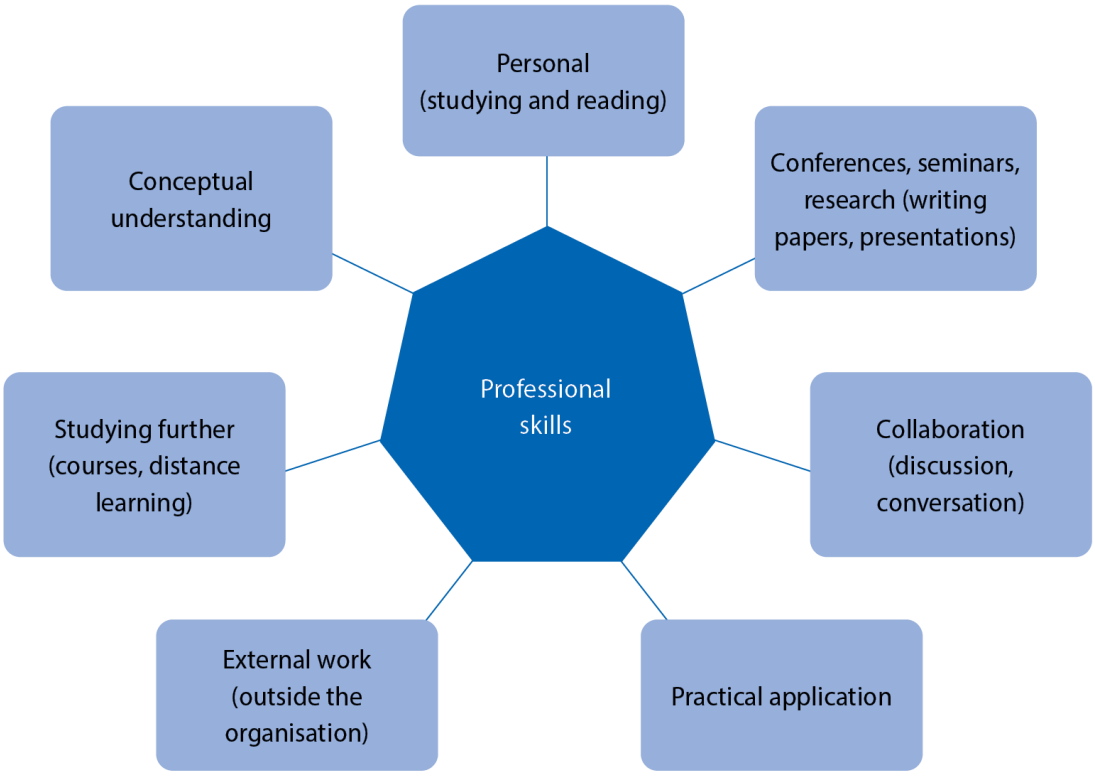
Professional skills development has become increasingly important in response to the increasing pace of change that the modern world currently faces. We live in a world where the amount of knowledge and information available is increasing at an extremely rapid rate. It is common knowledge that we are living in a knowledge-driven world, which implies that our current knowledge could easily lose relevance. This section focuses on the importance of knowing and enriching your skills to sustain your value in the workplace.

The paradox of growing knowledge

There is an interesting paradox that characterises modern life – i.e. the amount of information we can access today makes it very difficult to keep up with it all. This creates two challenges for individuals: ensuring their knowledge is relevant and that it is applied effectively.

As technology has progressed, the workplace has undergone many changes. New demands are placed on employees, requiring them to have a wider range of skills. There is increasingly more teamwork and greater emphasis is placed on virtual work over tangible work. For these reasons, it is important to develop a wide range of professional skills. Knowing your skills enables you to secure a place in the working world and to manage real-life problems.

According to Wilcox (2003), there are key professional skills that cover a wide range of learning situations. A framework of these skills has been reproduced in the following figure.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Wilcox, 2003: 4)Figure 5.2: Learning situations requiring professional skills

Transferrable skills and abilities

From the earliest stages of our physical, mental and emotional development, we engage in the process of transferring skills from one situation to another. It is not unusual to transfer skills from your informal experiences to your formal studies and vice versa. Skills can also easily be transferred from person to person by observing the skill in action when demonstrated by someone else. This makes it easier for the individual doing the observing to be able to demonstrate the skill themselves. Often, the most effective way of learning is by observing and then doing. This allows the individual to gain experience practically and expand their skill set.

Our personal and professional lives have constant interaction with others, so it is imperative for our success that we handle situations well, using the skill set we possess. Yate (2018) outlines seven interconnected transferrable skills that have been identified as important in any job or career path. These include the following:

1. Communication
2. Critical thinking
3. Creativity
4. Leadership

5. Teamwork
6. Technical ability
7. Multitasking

You already have these skills to some degree. To improve them, it is essential to reflect on your strengths and weaknesses to identify areas where you could improve.

Communication skills

These skills encompass reading, writing, listening and speaking. Analysing the communication circumstances enables you to select the correct medium for your purpose and audience. Being able to get your thoughts across clearly and concisely, both in writing and when speaking, is an essential communication skill. Listening and reading with understanding is crucial for competence and avoiding costly errors.

Although numeracy skills are often overlooked, it is important that an individual possesses them. One should be able 'to work with figures, make calculations, understand graphs, charts and simple statistics, and recognise important numerical information and trends' (*SkillsYouNeed*, n.d.).

Both verbal and non-verbal communication skills are important to your success. Looking presentable creates a positive impression, as does sending out documents that look professional.

Critical thinking skills

Critical thinking skills require you to apply a systematic approach to identifying issues, and using problem-solving skills and logic to generate solutions. This involves research skills like sourcing information, interpreting it and evaluating it. Once an appropriate solution has been found, an individual must possess implementation skills like time management, resources acquisition and following up.

Creativity skills

We can distinguish between an idea and creativity. Ideas may pop into our minds and disappear. Creativity is the ability to use critical thinking to transform an idea into a working reality.

Leadership skills

When people perceive you as competent in both knowledge and ability, they will likely be willing to follow you. You should be able to demonstrate your capabilities and get recognition for them. Leadership skills require that you take on responsibilities, prove your sense of initiative, be driven and build good interpersonal relations.

Teamwork skills

Our world is made up of a network of human connections. We cannot accomplish personal or business objectives in isolation. As a result, the ability to work in a team is paramount; this may require putting personal ambition aside for the good of the team and the task. You need to be able to work well with other people, display respect, participate, problem solve, collaborate and deliver.

Technical skills

You will require technical skills in all avenues of life, be it making a call on a smartphone, operating a machine at work, sorting out a computer glitch or using new software. Professional and personal growth require that you stay current with the developments in the technological world in general, as well as within in your specific professional field.

Multitasking skills

Multitasking is the ability to do more than one task at a time; for example, talking on the phone and typing an email or text message. It also requires switching seamlessly between tasks or doing things in rapid succession (Cherry [b], 2018). In the workplace and in our home life, we often need to divide our attention between competing activities. According to Yate (2018), successful multitasking is based on 'being organised; establishing priorities and managing your time'.

You will need planning, prioritising and reviewing skills to be effective at multitasking. However, it should be noted that research conducted at Stanford University revealed that 'multitasking is less productive than doing a single thing at a time' (Bradberry, 2014). It appears that when we multitask, we lose time and are subject to more distractions than when focusing on a single task.

With all of the aforementioned skills, it is also important to understand exactly how we go about demonstrating them. You can improve your skills by evaluating how others feel about you and how you feel about yourself. For example, imagine that you are in the position of a supervisor with several subordinates who report to you. If you receive feedback that these subordinates are confused about what is expected of them and they often feel misunderstood, this may be an indication that you need to improve on your communication skills.

As individuals, we often have insights into ourselves and can feel where our weaknesses lie. Considering this, we should know which skills we should turn our attention to. By applying our minds and reflecting on our own weaknesses, we will identify areas in which the we can improve. The exercise might also help you see where else you can apply your existing skills.

5.3.6 Knowing your personal goals

The previous section encouraged you to think about your values, skills and interests. You should now have a good idea about who you are and what you do well. With this in mind, you can start thinking about what you want to accomplish. Personal goals refer to your personal growth. They may apply to your physical, spiritual, social, financial, intellectual and personality development. In this section, we will discuss how to identify your goals and create an action plan to achieve those goals.

Goal orientations

The importance of having goals is captured in the words of Benjamin Mays, mentor to Martin Luther King Jr.: 'The tragedy of life doesn't lie in not reaching your goal. The tragedy lies in having no goal to reach' (Throop and Castellucci, 2009).

Prominent scholars advise that goals should be both challenging and realistic. Many students find that identifying goals is challenging task. Dreams, which can be perceived as desires that are unlikely to be realised, have been found to be the source of many people's goals. In stories of people whose achievements have been extraordinary, it is not unusual to find that they started by trying to achieve dreams that seemed wildly out of reach.

Although you need to be realistic when setting goals, specifically in terms of them being in line with your unique talents and abilities, they should also be challenging enough to allow you to realise your full potential. For example, consider John, who wants to become a mechanic. John, however, does not have the ability to deconstruct and reconstruct mechanical parts. As a result, his goal is clearly not realistic. The question that arises is whether John should give up his dream of being a mechanic and consider another goal that is more realistic.

Creating goals

It is not enough to think about our goals only. Studies highlighted by Locke (in Daudkhane, 2017: 137) have shown that there is a higher rate of achievement when goals are written down or stated. Locke and his colleagues 'have shown that more specific and ambitious goals lead to increase in performance as compared to easy goals' (in Daudkhane, 2017: 137). The SMARTER structure is a commonly accepted way of setting goals. This method requires the goal setter to think of objectives that are specific, measurable, attainable or achievable, relevant, time-based, evaluated and reviewed (Daudkhane, 2017: 139). We will explore each of these items in more detail in the following sections.

Specific

Goals should be specific rather than vague. Using the Five Ws method (*who, what, when, where, why* and *how*), it is easy to identify how you should set out your goal (Vosloo et al., 2016: 74). For example, instead of saying, 'I would like to achieve at work,'

you could be more specific and say, 'I would like to be promoted to manager in my department by the end of this year, so that I can earn 20 per cent more money.' The idea here is that if you specify your goals, they help you to sharpen your focus and achieve them.

Measurable

Ensuring your goals are measurable enables you to evaluate your success in achieving your goal and make it more tangible. For example, if you wanted to earn more, you would stipulate 20 per cent as an increase. Asking yourself what you would like to accomplish, as well as the the degree and the method of accomplishment, serves as a good guide to establishing measurable goals (Daudkhane, 2017: 139).

Attainable or achievable

This relates to the skills, knowledge, resources and attitude needed to meet the goals. You need to ask yourself if the goal is within your reach (Daudkhane, 2017: 139). You may wish to achieve a promotion to a junior management level, having worked as a manager's assistant and studied a degree in business management. This translates into the goal being attainable if a position is available.

Relevant

This aspect considers whether your goals matters to you as well as how they fit in with your current and future lifestyle and work life. You need to consider whether the timing is right and what your current needs are. You also need to ascertain if you are willing to put in the effort that is required and assess whether you will need support from anyone else (Daudkhane, 2017: 140). For example, you could be a single mother of three young children and have a goal to work as a national sales representative who travels around the country. This goal may not be relevant when considering your personal situation. It is also important to avoid setting too many goals, as failing to achieve goals can be discouraging.

Time-based

Your goals should have a deadline. Care must be taken to ensure your everyday tasks do not take priority over achieving your goals. You need to ensure that you have set yourself enough time to achieve your goals. This can be done by breaking your goals down into the activities needed to reach them, and providing a time frame for each of them (Daudkhane, 2017: 140). Allocating too much time, however, could lead to procrastination.

Evaluated

We need to evaluate our goal setting. We are often afraid of negative feelings that arise when we have not reached a goal. It is advisable to break the goal down into attainable

steps, and celebrate reaching small milestones to ensure you remain on track (Daudkhane, 2017: 142). Having a mentor can give you guidance and another perspective on your progress.

Reviewed

Take the time to update your goals based on what you have learned and achieved. If your circumstances and priorities change, you can amend your goals (Daudkhane, 2017: 142). It is also important to reward yourself when you accomplish a goal, as this is motivating and will encourage you to set new goals at a higher level.

Example 5 A Formulating personal and professional goals

This worksheet will give you an idea of how you can go about formulating your personal and professional goals.

Setting SMART goals	
Step 1: Identify your goal [Insert goal]	
Step 2: Is your goal SMART? Analyse your goal in terms of the SMART criteria. If you answer 'no' to the majority of these questions, you need to reformulate your goal.	
SMART criteria	Yes/No
• Is your goal specific? (Can you provide details of your goal?)	
• Is your goal measurable? (Can you actively measure this goal to determine whether you have achieved it or not?)	
• Can you achieve this goal? (Do you have the skills, knowledge, resources and attitude needed to meet the goals?)	
• Is the goal relevant? (Does it fit in with your current and future lifestyle and work life? Is the timing right?)	

• Have you set a time limit in which you need to achieve your goal?	

(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019)

Table 5.3: Worksheet for formulating effective goals

5.3.7 Knowing your professional goals

The goals you set out for your career are called professional goals. This section explores the value of having professional goals. We start by analysing the characteristics of professional goals.

Key characteristics of professional goals

Bill Copeland stated: 'The trouble with not having a goal is that you can spend your life running up and down the field and never score' (in Mayberry, 2017). Not setting a goal is like wanting to get to a destination, but not having a map or directions as to how to get there.

You need to create your own roadmap. If you have professional aspirations, you need to set out what you would like to achieve and draft written goals. These can relate to money, position or knowledge, and can be broad or specific. For example, suppose you would like to be a salesperson that earns R 300 000 a year. Your goals could also be as specific as wanting to get a job at a certain company.

Goals are generally classified according to three time frames:

1. Short-term goals
2. Intermediate goals
3. Long-term goals

The following table compares the length and time frame of a group of goals.

Length of goal	**Goal**	**Time frame**
Short-term goal	To pass a particular course	Months
Intermediate goal	Earning your degree, diploma or certificate	Years
Long-term goal	Building a career	Decades

(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019)

Table 5.4: The time frame for goal setting

Creating an action plan

After having decided on your goals, you need to plan how to reach them. A written action plan will help you to focus your efforts. Stating long-term goals should be a priority. Giving your goal a time frame comes next. Break the goal down into smaller steps that will help you to achieve it. It is critical to monitor your progress toward achieving your goals, as procrastinating, wasting and misusing time can move you further from your goal. Perseverance is key to making real progress.

Motivating yourself

Our behaviour or actions are motivated by a conscious or unconscious drive that energises us toward fulfilling a need, want or goal. As a result, motivation has been defined as the force within a person that directs behaviour. It has a level of intensity that impacts the level of effort and time we expend in pursuit of our goals (McShane and Von Glinow, 2000: 132). The motivation has been the subject of much research and theorising.

Motivation has been said to come from two sources: *intrinsic* and *extrinsic*. An individual who is intrinsically motivated is self-driven and works for a sense of self-satisfaction and personal fulfilment. Intrinsic motivation may stem from the need for acceptance, power, curiosity, challenge, pleasure, enjoyment, stress relief or other internal rewards. Extrinsically motivated individuals, on the other hand, work toward external rewards and satisfying others. This may be in the form of bonuses, awards, certificates, prizes, praise and other types of recognition.

Herzberg's two-factor theory distinguishes between maintenance factors and motivational factors. It assumes that there are certain factors in a workplace that tend to motivate people. These motivators (i.e. motivational factors) include achievement, recognition, the work itself, responsibility and advancement. If a job includes these factors, the employee will be highly motivated, resulting in job satisfaction. However, the employee will not necessarily be dissatisfied if these factors are lacking. Dissatisfaction is caused by the absence of the 'hygiene factors'. These factors satisfy a person's lower-order needs and include salary, status, working conditions, work security and interpersonal relationships with colleagues (Strydom, 2015).

Other theorists focus on past experiences of behavioural consequences, as they impact future motivation. Skinner's reinforcement theory upholds that behaviours will be repeated if there is a favourable consequence and will be avoided if negativity is experienced (Certo, 1997: 322).

Visualisation

Visualisation is '[t]he formation of a mental image of something' (*Oxford Dictionaries* 1, n.d.). It is a technique that helps people enhance their skills and performance, create desired emotional states, and achieve goals.

The ability to do something has both a mental and psychological component. You may be unaware that your brain constantly visualises the future as a coping mechanism. However, you can consciously employ visualisation to simulate the future. You can picture the outcome of an action or behaviour, or you can mentally simulate the steps that you need to take to get you to the final outcome. Research shows that it is best to use both methods in combination.

The visualisation can also help you fine-tune your goals and increase your belief in your ability to achieve a goal. Picturing and describing your situation in detail serves as a motivator. For example, if you think about wanting an academic degree and dismiss the thought, it will soon be forgotten and remain an unrealised goal. However, if you close your eyes and envisage the enrolment process, attending class etc., your drive to fulfil the goal increases dramatically. In this way, you can keep adding details until the situation feels real (Vilhauer, 2018).

Overcoming fears

Our mental state impacts our ability to achieve our goals. It is often our belief in our own abilities, or lack thereof, that determines our success. It may be that we fear a poor outcome if we attempt something, so we rather do nothing. A good starting point to change this reaction is to look at the cause of the fear. It may stem from critical people we have encountered in our lives, our own unrealistically high standards, low self-esteem or humiliation from previous attempts (*Mind Tools* 1, n.d.).

Failure is a matter of personal perspective. We have a choice about how we look at it. We can consider it to be evidence of our inadequacies, or a learning that brings us closer to our goal and gives us insight into who we are. It is important to keep a positive attitude to build self-confidence and neutralise self-sabotage. Self-sabotage entails creating phantom problems that are used to validate why a goal should not be pursued. However, if we set realistic goals and visualise all the potential, realistic outcomes, this helps us deal with the fear of the unknown. It is also a good idea to try and predict the absolute worst outcome and devise a contingency plan (*Mind Tools* 1, n.d.).

Fear does not only pertain to failure. Some people fear that success will bring new situations and new responsibilities they cannot handle. Some people feel that they do not deserve to succeed. Many people tend to underestimate their abilities.

There are numerous ways to overcome fear. Set small achievable goals to boost your confidence. Use visualisation of the steps in achieving the goal and the final outcome. Be practical and logical – some goals may be too dangerous or unreasonable. The *NHS*

(2016) in the United Kingdom recommends that you should face your fears, look at the evidence for a negative outcome occurring, not try to be perfect, talk about your fears with someone and reward yourself for leaving your comfort zone.

Being flexible

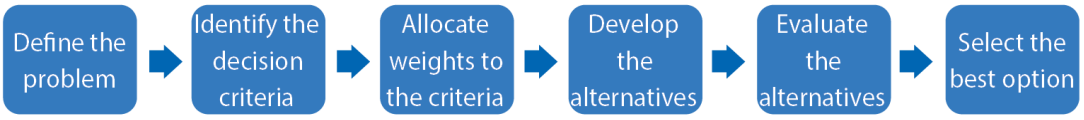
Goals are not cast in stone and situations change. Being flexible and changing your goals and action plans to suit your new circumstances is logical and realistic.

5.3.8 Knowing how to make personal decisions

Every person will reach a point in their life where they must make a decision. Making decisions is applicable in all spheres of life, not only in a professional setting. You may find you need to make decisions about your finances, friends, health and even your family. As you will need to make decisions often, it is essential that you are equipped to do so when the time arises.

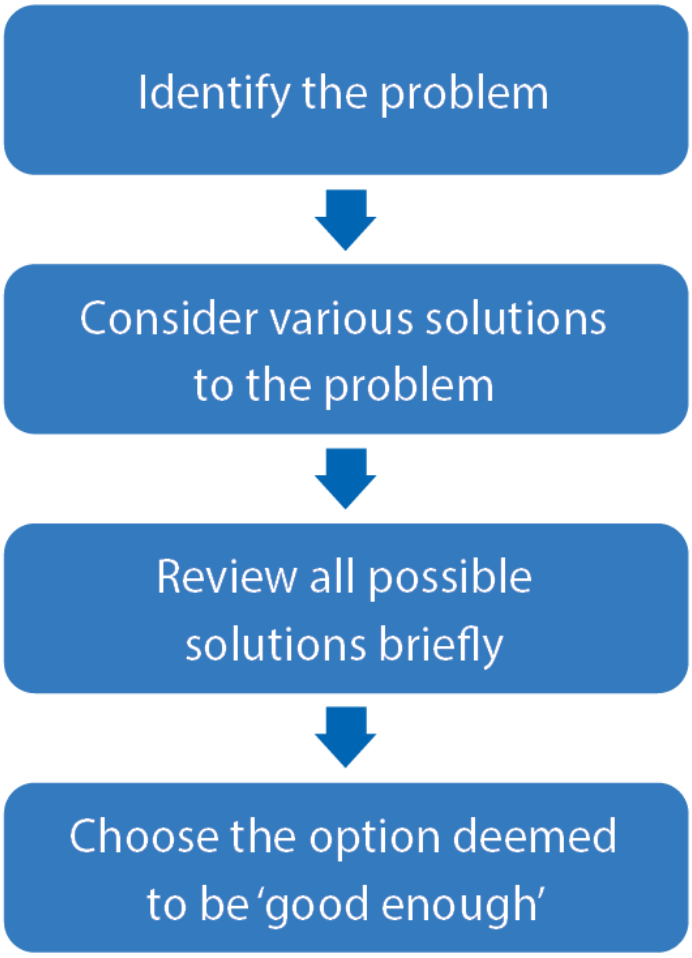
Robbins and Judge (2013: 111) state that there are generally two models used for decision making: the rational decision-making model and the bounded rationality model. These will be illustrated in the figures that follow.

The rational decision-making model is used when the individual has a lot of time, and all the necessary information needed to make an informed decision. It also assumes that individuals make all decisions by weighing up all options, which may not be possible in reality (Robbins and Judge, 2013: 112).



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Robbins and Judge, 2013: 112)Figure 5.3: Rational decision-making model

The bounded rationality model is more often used in everyday life.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Robbins and Judge, 2013: 112)Figure 5.4: Bounded rationality model

This model suggests that individuals are only able to handle a certain amount of information and, therefore, the decision-making process needs to be a simple one. It is less thorough, but also less time-consuming than the rational decision-making model. In addition to this, it results in choosing a solution that will 'satisfice' or fulfil the minimum requirements necessary to achieve the goal (Robbins and Judge, 2013: 112). The solution may not be perfect, but it will be good enough. This method of decision-making will be used more often than rational decision-making method.

When it comes to making a decision, your personal values will determine what you decide. For example, some individuals may have a very rigid ethical code of what is right and wrong, and this will influence their decision-making.

Ethical reasoning

Ethical reasoning is a very tricky area. Ethics are a set of principles that an individual chooses to live by, that may differ from person to person. *Oxford Dictionaries* 2 (n.d.) defines ethics as the 'moral principles that govern a person's behaviour or the

conducting of an activity'. An example of ethics is seen where some individuals believe that a 'white lie' does not hurt anyone, whereas others may view lying in any way as being wrong.

The level of consideration that an individual has for others may also influence decision-making. Some individuals are selfless and seldom put their own needs before those of others. It is unlikely that they would make a decision that would negatively impact another person. Others might be more focused on themselves and have less consideration for how their decision would affect another person.

We are often faced with various ethical decisions in the workplace and are met with the consequences of our decisions. If you are given feedback from others regarding the ethics of your decision, you could take the feedback and adjust your behaviour accordingly or choose to stick with your original decision. Either way, you should always strive to accept any feedback you receive graciously. Displaying ethical behaviour in the workplace will be touched on later in this unit.

5.4 Standing out from the crowd: Managing your 'self' at work

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There are times when you should restrict how much of your 'self' you let manifest at work, particularly when there are other people around. For example, if you are a very loud and bubbly person, it might be necessary to lower your normal level of speaking when you are around colleagues who are working. You will need to know what works best for you to manage yourself to the best of your ability.

5.4.1 Celebrating your strengths and acknowledging your weaknesses

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If you want to be successful in both your personal and professional lives, you need to acknowledge your strengths and your weaknesses. Knowing what you need to do to fulfil your potential will help you to grow. To build successful professional relationships, you need to understand your individual competencies as well as those of others. The following sections will explore how this can be achieved.

Aptitude, ability and competence

There are three important functions that will determine how you perform your job – i.e. your *aptitude, ability* and *competence*.

Aptitude

This refers to one's natural ability to perform tasks in a particular sphere. These aptitudes or capabilities are often called talents. They have little to do with interests, education or culture, and are related to heredity. They are things that we can master quickly and easily. Some people can draw or paint well; some find it easy to grasp mathematical concepts; some people can sing in tune without having to train; while others can think critically with ease.

Our aptitude is closely related to the careers we pursue and the job satisfaction we experience. There are numerous aptitude tests that can be administered to identify your natural abilities, so that you are aware of your strengths and weaknesses and can make wise career decisions (*Johnson O'Connor Research Foundation*, n.d.).

Ability

Greenberg (2011: 160) defines abilities as 'mental and physical capacities to perform various tasks'. There is a subtle difference between aptitude and ability. While aptitude means that you are able to do something because you have an innate or inborn capacity, ability means you can do something – either naturally or by having acquired skills and knowledge to perform the task. You may not be aware of an aptitude (i.e. talent) and have not developed it; therefore, it would not yet be an ability (*Kalvi Malar Beta*, n.d.).

Competence

Competence is based on ability, but relates to the degree to which and individual can perform a task successfully or efficiently (*Oxford Dictionaries* 3, n.d.). Being competent means being proficient and delivering high performance work.

The following table sets out a few of the competencies outlined by *The Nielson Group* (2003).

Personal competencies	**Behavioural competencies**
Accountability	Analysing data
Listening	Competitiveness
Attention to detail	Customer orientation
Conceptual thinking	Organised workplace
Reliability	Flexibility

Creativity	Versatility
Emotional control	
Empathy	
Goal directed	
Self-aware	

(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from The Nielson Group, 2003)

Table 5.5: Personal and behavioural competencies

Emotional intelligence

The term emotional intelligence was coined by researchers Peter Salovey and John Mayer, and later popularised by Daniel Goleman. Goleman (in David, 2014) maintains that although emotional competencies are inborn, it is possible for one to learn or develop them to achieve exceptional performance. He outlines the following five areas of emotional intelligence (in David, 2014).

1. *Self-awareness:* This means being in touch with our emotions and recognising the effect they have on us. Self-awareness occurs through knowing your strengths and weaknesses, and being aware of your drives and values. It gives rise to a sense of self-worth and confidence.
2. *Self-regulation:* Regulating yourself is the ability to manage your impulses, feelings and reactions, and adapt them so that they are appropriate for the situation. This is your self-control and flexibility.
3. *Motivation:* This pertains to the drive to meet and exceed standards, and to achieve for intrinsic reward or self-satisfaction.
4. *Social skills:* Social skills are closely associated with building strong interpersonal relations. It entails the ability to listen without judging, the ability to persuade others, cooperate, negotiate and inspire.
5. *Empathy:* Empathy is linked to social skills in that it requires the ability to identify and understand people's feelings. Empathy also entails considering how our actions or words will affect others.

You can do online emotional intelligence (EQ) tests at the following links:

- https://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/ei-quiz.htm

- https://memorado.com/emotional_quotient
- https://testyourself.psychtests.com/bin/transfer

If you had to describe your strengths, you would probably speak about things that you are naturally good at, capable of doing or knowledgeable about. You will know you are using your strengths when you feel confident that you have something of value to offer. Strengths can also be acquired; it is possible that you have not yet uncovered your greatest potential.

It is also natural for us to have weaknesses. We should not perceive these in any negative way or focus too much on them, as they can make us feel insecure. Knowing your own weaknesses will provide an opportunity for personal growth. With practice, direction and focus, anyone can acquire almost any skill. It is highly possible, then, to turn our weaknesses into strengths.

Understanding our strengths and weaknesses can be regarded as an exercise of self-awareness. If we know ourselves well, we will be better at making decisions that are aligned with our dreams and aspirations. Knowing our strengths and weaknesses affords us a sense of direction and purpose. Our lives can be more fulfilling when we make decisions that reflect our strengths. Naturally, being able to look within ourselves and examine what is most important to us requires honesty and truthfulness.

5.4.2 Managing your time

In the hustle and bustle of the modern work environment, there is always significant time pressure. Professionals can find it challenging to avoid being distracted, maintain focus, use their time and energy to their maximum benefit, and make progress toward their goals. People are, more often than not, overworked and end up doing too many tasks at the same time. As a result, finding time-management strategies is critical.

In terms of how we use it, time is like money – i.e. we spend time, we save time and we invest time. We need to use time effectively and efficiently. Effective means achieving the results that you want (*Cambridge Dictionary* 1, n.d.). Efficient means working quickly in an organised way (*Cambridge Dictionary* 2, n.d.). We need to be mindful that although we may want to do a job perfectly, it may take too much time and not really require a high level of input.

Organisation and performance

Good organisation is linked to goal setting. It is not uncommon to find that organised individuals operate around goals. Earlier, we discussed the idea that creating realistic (i.e. SMARTER) goals can help to support your life plan. Good organisation will help to optimise your performance, allow efficient use of your time and reduce stress levels.

Keeping a calendar, a progress chart or posting reminders can help you to keep track of your progress, as well as assist you in moving forward. It pays to organise your work area; keeping it uncluttered frees up space psychologically, and saves potentially wasted time.

Procrastination

Procrastination is detrimental to time management. It refers to the practice of putting off tasks until a later time. It is a bad habit that obstructs time management and can lead to stress. There are various reasons why people procrastinate; these could range from a fear of failure, a need for perfection, or simply being disorganised or not wanting to perform the task.

Overcoming procrastination is necessary to ensure optimal professional development. One way forward is to visualise the completed task. This can create a subconscious image of success, and serve as a form of motivation. On a more concrete level, you should plan to complete the task. In this case, it will help to list each activity and piece of information needed and set deadlines for when you wish to complete them.

Once you get to work, try to build realistic breaks into your work plan. Prioritising is also a valued aspect of effective time management. This involves organising your schedule according to the importance and urgency of the tasks needing to be completed.

Time wasters

The following four labels are given to individuals who tend to waste time, and a possible solution is offered for each (Bloomsbury Publishing, 2004: 4–7):

1. *The mañanas:* This is taken from Spanish, which means 'tomorrow morning'. Mañanas are people who procrastinate because they prefer to think about work rather than do it. They could procrastinate because they may be bored, lack confidence or are reluctant to get clarification from others. A way forward for this group is to break overwhelming tasks up into smaller, more achievable ones.
2. *The poor delegators:* These are individuals who waste large amounts of time engaged in work that someone else could have completed more efficiently. Poor delegators often get disappointed with others because of their own poor communication skills. The way forward for these time wasters involves differentiating between delegation and abdication, and clarifying all tasks.
3. *The disorganised:* This category of time wasters may be easily recognised by their lack of organisation. They usually have heaps of paper around their desks and often believe that they are overloaded, rather than poorly organised. The way forward for this group is to make to-do lists, which they review regularly. Practising sticking to one task and finishing it is critical to their success.

4. *The mushrooms:* These are individuals who are not always clear about the purpose of the tasks they are expected to complete. They speculate frequently, and often inwardly question what they should do rather than getting down to doing it. They are not assertive and usually have poor communication skills. The way forward for this group is to learn how to make it known that they do not understand how to do a task. Honesty is key to their progress.

It is advisable to avoid wasting time and to be brave enough to ask for help, if and when the need arises.

Methods and tools for time management

High-impact time management can only happen if you understand the value of time, analyse your time usage, have specific tools and skills of time management, and build self-esteem and self-confidence through the proper use of time. The following are a few different ways in which you can manage your time:

- Keep track of big deadlines on a monthly calendar.
- Draw up a daily or weekly timetable.
- Reward yourself for work with relaxation time.
- Use an application to manage your to-do list.

There are also various online tools that can pin tasks to a board, send reminders when you should be reaching a milestone or even turn your productivity into a role-playing game.

A simple way to organise your tasks is to keep a diary and a to-do list. You can keep a physical diary or use tools like a calendar on your phone or computer (Google Calendar is an easy-to-use tool). Write down what needs to be done and make sure that you always have the appropriate materials nearby in order to do the work that you need to do.

Example 5 B To-do lists

When writing a to-do list, it should include the action to complete, the time frame, purpose or context, and necessary details.

The following table sets out an example of how you would write a to-do list.

List element	**Example**
The action to complete (verb)	Phone John

Time frame	Today
The purpose or context	About an insurance claim
Details	021 334 5643 Claim number ref 2018/12/09/1265

(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019)

Table 5.6: Example of a to-do list

A list of tasks can be overwhelming. A way in which you can manage your time better is by prioritising what needs to be achieved. Stephen Covey proposed using the time-management matrix, as shown in the following table, to decide on the order in which tasks should be tackled (*Branford Hall*, 2015):

	Urgent	**Not urgent**
Important	A – Important and urgent	C – Important and not urgent
	Has immediate implications	Has future implications
	Example: Handing an assignment or report in on time	*Example:* Drafting a long-term strategy or charging your cell phone
Not Important	B – Not important and urgent	D – Not important and not urgent
	It is not critically important, but it needs to be attended to	Little value in performing the activity
	Example: Your boss is calling you about a meeting tomorrow	*Example:* Phoning to chat to a friend for no purpose or playing video games

(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Branford Hall, 2015)

Table 5.7: Covey's time-management matrix

Look at your to-do list and allocate each item an A, B, C or D, or write them on the grid in the relevant section. Tackle important and urgent tasks first (A), then deal with tasks

that are important but not urgent (B). Do not forget C, as these tasks are still important, but avoid D.

Former US President Dwight D. Eisenhower said: 'What is important is seldom urgent and what is urgent is seldom important' (Oppong [b], 2017). The Eisenhower method suggests the following:

- Urgent and important tasks (A) should be completed immediately and personally.
- Tasks that are urgent but unimportant (B) can be delegated (*Mind Tools* 2, n.d.). Delegation is a valuable investment of our time. When we delegate, we teach someone to perform tasks we would usually perform. While the training process takes time now, the investment pays off later, since we free our time to perform activities with a higher payoff later.
- Tasks that are important and not urgent (C), should get an end date and be performed personally, if possible.
- Unimportant and not urgent tasks (D) should be dropped. Learn to say no to those who ask you to perform tasks that fall into this category.

The following websites are useful for learning more about Eisenhower's method:

- eisenhower-matrix.com/eisenhower-matrix-tools/
- www.lifehack.org/articles/technology/top-15-time-management-apps-and-tools.html

5.4.3 Managing your stress

For many people, being part of the professional world comes at a considerable individual cost: increased stress. Some people may associate jobs with high levels of stress with power and prestige. However, for those who are at breaking point, stress is not about boasting; rather, it is about pain. This section focuses on the concept of stress, its implications for individuals and practical ways of dealing with it.

Pressure vs. stress

Work pressure and work stress are not the same thing. Work pressure refers to the sense that a certain amount of work must be completed to a specific standard in a defined period. This involves meeting deadlines. Pressure can motivate, stimulate and energise you to complete scheduled work on time. Work stress, on the other hand, is your reaction to the pressure.

Stress occurs when we feel that the demands placed on us are beyond our ability. We also feel that something important is at stake if we do not perform well (Bell, 2016). On a biological level, stress indicates the body's reaction to a situation that is perceived as threatening. It has been found that stress is a key cause of mental and physical illness (Jex, 1998). As a result, it is important to know what will cause you stress and how to tell when you are under stress.

Types of stress

Seaward (1997: 7) highlights three types of stress:

1. *Eustress:* This is the type of stress you feel when the situation is not threatening, but motivating or inspiring. An example of eustress could be going to work on the first day of a dream job.
2. *Neustress:* This is the type of stress you feel when something concerning does not directly affect you, making it neither good, nor bad stress. An example of neustress might be hearing about a flood in Mexico.
3. *Distress:* This is 'bad stress' and can be divided into acute and chronic stress:

    a. *Acute stress:* A feeling of intense stress over a short period of time. For example, if your boss schedules a meeting to discuss your performance. You might start to think of various issues that will be addressed. When you have the meeting, you find out that your hard work has been acknowledged and praised. That feeling of acute stress dissipates immediately.

    b. *Chronic stress:* This feels less intense than acute stress, but lasts over a long period of time. For example, having a boss you do not particularly get along with but have to interact with on a daily basis.

Types of stress and personality

Stress has been related to personality types categorised as either Type A or Type B. Typical behaviour patterns of these personality types are indicated in the following table.

Type A behaviour patterns	Type B behaviour patterns
• Talks, moves and eats rapidly • Interrupts others	• Relaxed approach • Contemplates issues carefully • Works at a steady pace

• Sense of time urgency • Impatient • Loses temper easily • Struggles to achieve more in less time • Competitive • Impatient • Thinks or does two things simultaneously • Emphasis on quantity of work over quality • Rarely creative • Relies on experience when making decisions • Unable to relax or stop working • Susceptible to stress-related illnesses	• Low concern for time limits • Even-tempered • Rarely tries to complete an increasing number of tasks in a shorter period • Does not exhibit superiority • Patient • Stays focused • Can relax without feeling guilt • Does not need to display achievement • Creative • Can develop unique solutions to problems

(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from McShane and Von Glinow, 2000: 207–208; Certo, 1997: 412; and Smit et al., 2016: 342)

Table 5.8: Typical behaviour patterns of Type A and Type B personalities

As can be seen from the previous table, the Type B personality will experience lower stress levels, and is less likely to experience distress and physiological symptoms in comparison to the Type A personality. However, this should not be taken to mean that they are less ambitious (McShane and Von Glinow, 2000: 208).

You can take a test to establish your personality type at the following link:

www.psych.uncc.edu/pagoolka/TypeAB.html

Dealing with stress

There are various practical suggestions for how to deal with stress. First, however, we need to identify the causes and symptoms of the stress. Stress may be caused by work-related factors such as policies and inflexible rules, a very formal organisational structure, physical conditions (e.g. crowding or poor climate control), office politics,

pending lay-offs and ineffective processes (Certo, 1997: 411). Personal stress can be caused by issues at home or in our social circles.

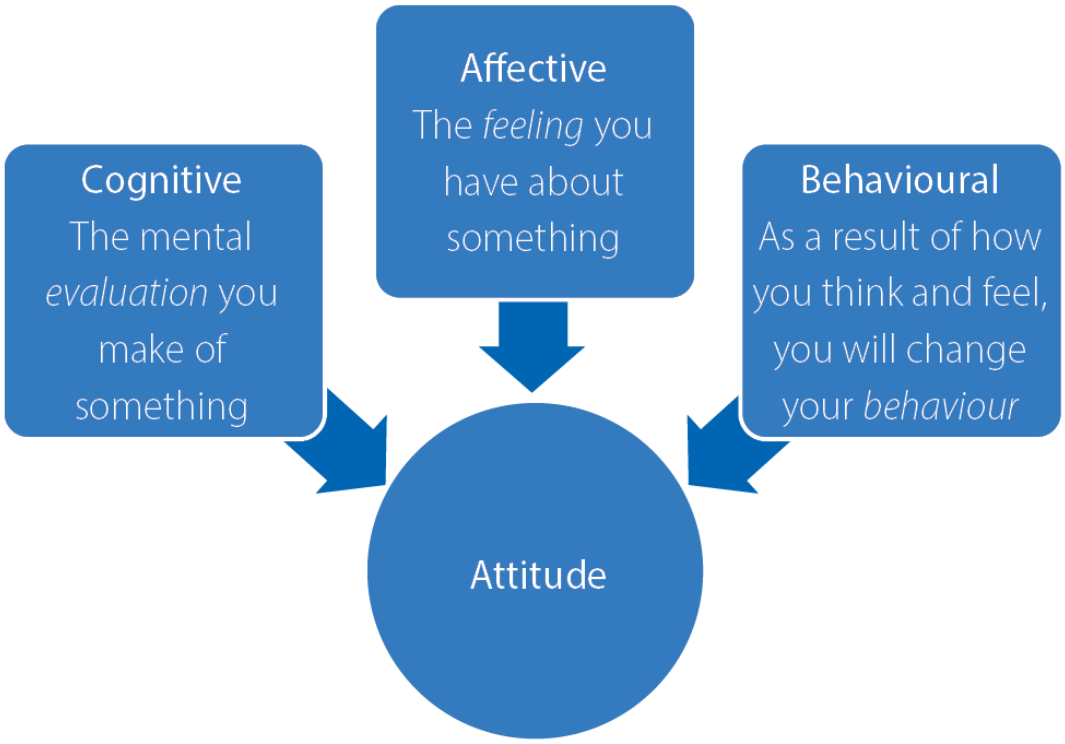
Personality type also impacts stress perception. Considering that stress is a mindset, one must acknowledge the mental aspect as well. Once the root of the stress is identified, a plan can be made to find solutions to relieve or eliminate the stress.

McShane and Von Glinow (2000: 211–216) suggest the following stress-management strategies:

- Remove the stressor.
- Withdraw yourself from the stressor – either permanently (leave your job) or temporarily (take a vacation).
- Change your perception using realistic goal setting, visualisation, self-reinforcement and positive self-talk.
- Control the consequences of stress through wellness programmes or employee-assistance programmes.
- Seek support in dealing with your stress.

5.4.4 Managing your attitude

Robbins and Judge (2013: 58) define attitudes as evaluative statements that can be favourable or unfavourable. These statements are often made about people, objects or events. Attitudes are complicated and include three components: the *cognitive, affective* and *behavioural*. The following figure briefly explains each component.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Robbins and Judge, 2013: 59)Figure 5.5: Attitude components

Imagine that you cannot concentrate at work because the environment is very noisy and there are many distractions every day (i.e. people having meetings, people talking to other individuals in the office etc.). This is making you feel anxious because you are worried you will not meet your deadlines. You also feel slightly annoyed that your colleagues are being inconsiderate. You decide to speak to someone in the human resources (HR) department, hoping they can address the issue.

We can apply each element of attitude to the previous example as follows:

- *Cognitive:* You cannot concentrate at work due to the distractions and noise.
- *Affective:* This is making you feel anxious and annoyed.
- *Behavioural:* You decide to speak to HR about this problem.

Attitude can also be influenced by an individual's values, their level of self-interest or the extent to which they identify with a particular group (Robbins and Judge, 2013: 61).

Managing your attitude is incredibly important as it may drastically impact the way in which other people perceive you. For example, if you come across as willing, capable and enthusiastic, it is likely that your manager will also see you as having those qualities.

Vaughn-Furlow (2017) suggests that a good attitude is far more important than any skills you can possess, as skills are something which can easily be learned. A good attitude, however, is something that can be more difficult to acquire, as it is largely influenced by your background, experiences and world view.

Jarrow (2013) notes that a positive attitude has been shown to link to a higher level of productivity because:

- people are more willing to help positive people, meaning that the workload could be shared more easily;
- less time is wasted on complaining;
- a positive attitude keeps energy levels high;
- positive attitudes have also been shown to inspire people to work together, resulting in greater teamwork;
- those who have a positive attitude have been shown to have high levels of confidence, thus they can often achieve more;
- positive attitudes lead to solving problems rather than creating additional problems; and
- positive attitudes aid in better decision-making, as one is likely to envision a more positive outcome.

5.4.5 Managing your priorities

Once you have established your priorities (e.g. by categorising them using the ABCD method), you can shift from being reactive to being proactive. Know what you have to achieve, by when it must be achieved and have a plan to accomplish your goals. Tim Elmore, author of *Marching off the Map*, recommends asking the following three questions (Vozza, 2018).

1. *What does the role require me to do?* This is the required action that falls within your job description. If it is not within your role or interests, it can be delegated or rejected. You may have these tasks listed on your to-do list or on your calendar.
2. *What will produce the greatest results?* This concerns processes. Completing the tasks we are good at and that can be done quickly usually gives us a sense of fulfilment and motivation. However, it should be noted that even tasks we are not confident to tackle still need to be completed.
3. *What is most fulfilling when I do it?* This requires some introspection and reflection. Using this information impacts how we approach our future tasks.

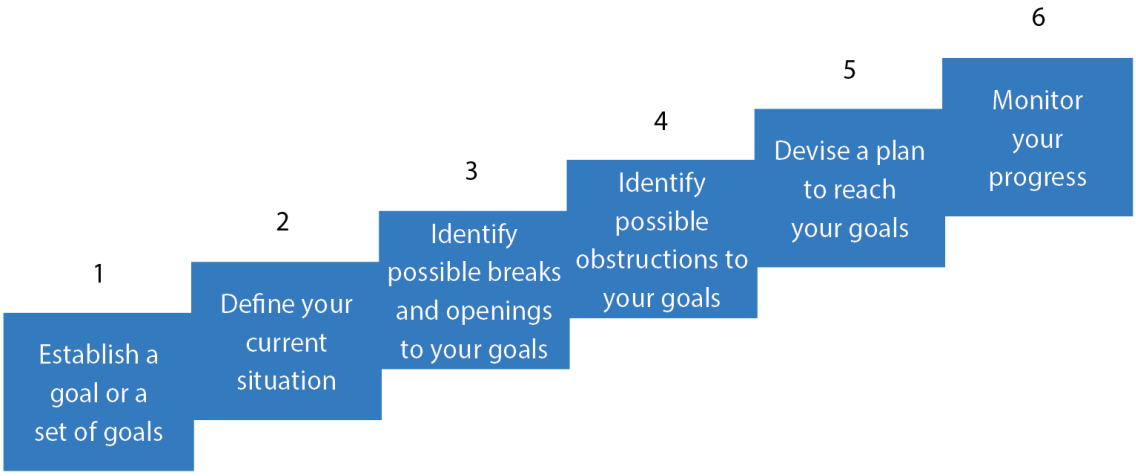
Remember to be realistic and take heed that how you perceive a situation, positively or negatively, is within your control.

5.4.6 Managing your professional goals

As a professional entering the workplace, you will need to draw on your organisational skills to manage the goals of the company for which you are accountable. This section highlights some steps that will help you to manage your professional goals. Following these steps, some of the key points that should be considered in the management of professional goals will be laid out.

Steps to manage professional goals

One of your immediate responsibilities in meeting the company's goals will be to set up and complete your own work schedule. The six steps set out in the following figure represent a synthesis of the common themes, as advised by numerous writers in this tradition.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019)Figure 5.6: Steps for managing your professional goals

Career pathing

We have looked at setting goals and prioritising, but we need to look at the bigger picture of managing our professional lives. Career pathing is the term that describes the process employees use to plot their course for career development. To do this, you must be aware of your knowledge, skills, personality, drive and end goal (Heathfield, 2018).

Kevin Granville, a business editor for the *New York Times*, sheds some light on career pathing. He suggests making a conscious effort to network. This means cultivating and

maintaining relationships with colleagues and other stakeholders from past and present workplaces. Try and work with different teams and volunteer for projects.

Having a good relationship with the people you work with makes your job easier, as people are more willing to give you support. Further to this, fellow workers are a source of information about the company and your industry. Career moves are often made possible due to those with whom we network. LinkedIn and Facebook can be effective career tools, and joining professional organisations is a good way to network with people in your industry.

Being a friendly person is not enough to ensure you advance in your career. It must be tethered to doing impressive work. Be noticed, raise your profile and stay visible so that you do not get overlooked. Participate in meetings, look good, attend functions and volunteer. In addition to good performance, staying informed about changes and best practices in your industry, as well as new technological developments, is imperative. Attend classes, workshops and conferences to network and gain knowledge.

Approach someone you admire and respect in the company to mentor you. Get their input and feedback on your performance so that you can grow. You can diversify (branch out into other related fields) and extend your knowledge to make yourself more marketable. You will also extend your network beyond your immediate industry. Do not focus solely on work – it is important to have other interests and hobbies as well.

If you are not yet in the job market and fall into the category of job seeker, your job is to find a job. You will need tools and skills for a job hunt. Identify places that will help you get an interview – such as online job sites, recruitment agencies or your social network. Have the documents you need ready so that you can customise them for a particular position. Have a good, well-laid-out, error-free curriculum vitae (CV) with a cover letter and certified copies of your qualifications. You will also need to hone your interview skills.

You may decide to develop your entrepreneurial spirit and start your own business, or work as a freelancer. This will require you to implement your planning and analytical skills. Put together a business plan to ascertain the viability and feasibility of the proposed business and, if you decide to move forward, use the document as a guideline.

5.4.7 Behaving ethically at work

As previously discussed, ethics are a set of moral principles that will guide an individual's behaviour (*Oxford Dictionaries* 2, n.d.). These principles guide us in determining what is right or wrong, our rights and responsibilities, and how to live a good life.

According to Valente (2014), acting ethically in the workplace means being trustworthy. It is being accountable and taking responsibility for your actions. For example, committing to complete a task by a certain date and time, and following through on this. Behaving ethically may also entail being courteous and respectful in the workplace (Valente, 2014). An example of unethical behaviour would be verbally attacking a colleague for their personal views; this is the exact opposite of being tolerant and respectful of others.

Honesty and transparency are also important components of being ethical in the workplace. This goes hand in hand with truthfulness, loyalty, fairness, sincerity and openness in communication. These are all traits that others will associate with an individual who is highly ethical (Valente, 2014). Being honourable and acting with integrity is also an important element of behaving ethically. This entails being noble and showing character that is consistent and in line with certain values (Valente, 2014).

Finally, Valente (2014) suggests that behaving ethically entails respecting an individual's confidentiality. Whenever private, confidential information is passed on, whether this is from a colleague or from the organisation, this should always remain so.

Consider the following scenario. You are working to a strict deadline on a project at work. You soon realise that you are running out of time to complete it. You find yourself in the position to make one of two decisions: rush the work and hand it in to meet the deadline (knowing that the work will be riddled with mistakes due to your rushing), or ask your manager for an extension, knowing that you might get into trouble for not meeting the original deadline?

This scenario presents an example of ethical reasoning (briefly touched on earlier in this unit). Speaking up about extending your deadline would be the ethical decision, whereas rushing your work and handing in something mediocre, would be an unethical decision. It would be considered unethical because you would not be taking your responsibility seriously, and this may ultimately have an impact on other people in the process.

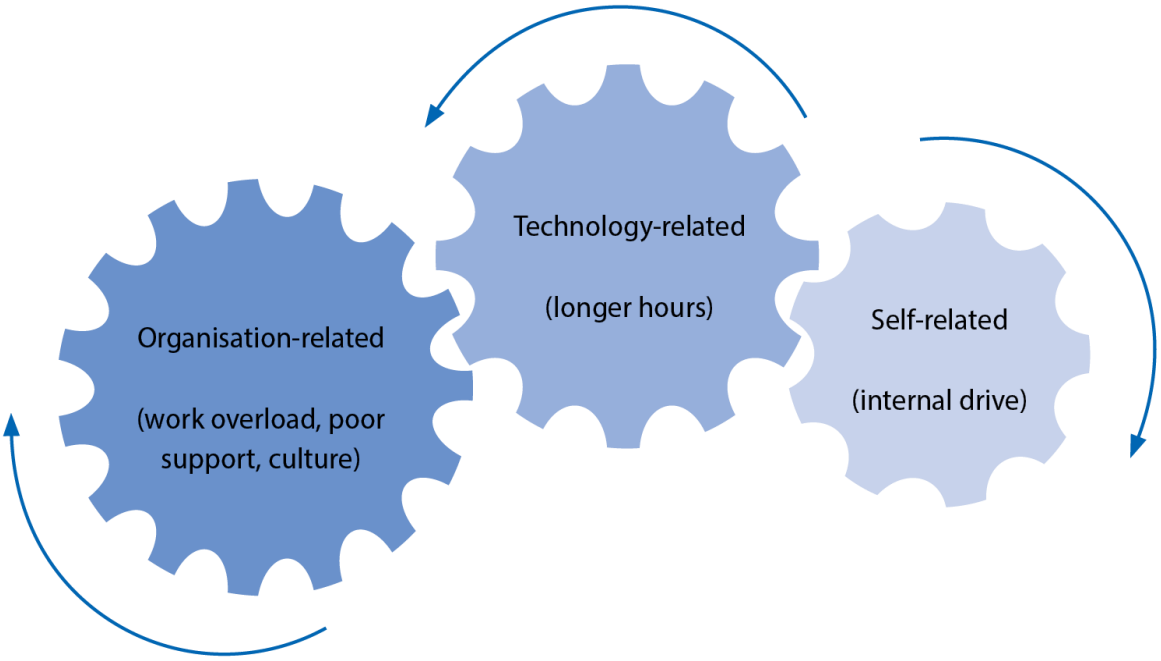
5.4.8 Achieving your work-life balance

It is not unusual in today's frenzied business world to become completely absorbed and immersed in your work life, to the extent that you do not have any time for your social and personal life. In this section, we examine the issue of the work-life balance as a prominent feature of a new-age professional life.

The root of the problem

The source of the work-life imbalance appears to be summed up in the concept of work pressure. The factors that contribute to this pressure could be distinguished on three

levels: *organisation-related, self-related* and *technology-related*. These levels are shown in the following figure.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019)Figure 5.7: Factors that contribute to pressure

Organisational pressure

On the organisational level, contributory factors range from work overload and excessive demands from colleagues and clients, to the company's corporate culture and demanding deadlines. Many organisations place a higher value on teamwork than individual work. However, while the team might share the work, there could be excessive demands for the individual to meet with other team members, with implications for their personal time. The issue of increased competition in all facets of business could also be seen as a contributing factor.

The culture of the organisation could also be instrumental in creating work pressure. Aspects such as internal politics, level of support and poor competence of management can drain time, ultimately creating a work overload. There are those who take work home and continue to be stressed. This cuts into their personal time, and a potential lack of sleep can create a vicious cycle which impacts poorly, in turn, on productivity.

Self-inflicted pressure

In terms of the self, pressure could arise from the individual's internal drive to want to do more. There are many professionals who are unable to say 'no' and therefore end up taking on more responsibilities than they can handle. There is also the possibility of the

employee's fear of receiving a poor performance review. The employee may perceive that his or her reluctance to take on more work may impact negatively on his or her career progression. There are also those individuals who are highly driven and feel fulfilled by taking on more work. The possibility of perfectionism exists, where employees become obsessed with the quality of their work, pushing themselves progressively harder.

Technologically-related pressures

Technology has played a substantial role in creating work-life imbalances in the modern environment. For example, people are now spending more time responding to emails and engaging with online information. Excessive hours spent at a computer reduces time that could be used for physical activity and, ultimately, contributes to poor health and higher levels of stress.

The growth of technology has compounded the work-life imbalance problem, as people are constantly connected to the Internet. This may lead them to feel obliged to respond to emails over the weekend. The individual's inability to compartmentalise work and personal life could lead to blurred boundaries between work and home, especially when the individual is at home physically but cannot stop thinking about work.

The cost of the work-life imbalance

Work-life imbalance can impact negatively in three major areas: *individual, family* and *social circles*. The health of the individual suffers significantly; as there is less time available for physical exercise and leisure, individuals are more prone to obesity and high blood pressure. On a social level, the shortage of time could contribute to their missing out on important social events. In terms of family, there might not be any leisure time spent with relatives. The tendency to spend excessive amounts of time working could progressively build up to becoming addicted to work. The individual progressively becomes more socially detached and ultimately disconnects from his or her family life.

Work-life balance vs. work-life integration

The concept of work-life balance implies that you must work when you are at work and leave your home life behind, and vice versa. This term has been criticised for creating an artificial separation between work and life. The implication is that you are missing out on life while at work or feel guilty during leisure time because you are not working.

The new way of thinking is that work is very much part of life; therefore, we should instead consider it to be a 'work-life integration' (Cheng-Tozun, 2018). This takes into account technological advances, as well as ambitious people who place equal importance on the success of their work and personal lives, and seek who to synthesise the different dimensions of life (*Business.com*, 2017).

Many companies have implemented flexible working hours and permit employees to work independently from various locations, facilitating a work-life integration. Although people may determine when and where they work, having goals and monitoring progress becomes increasingly important for both the employee and management in this scenario. Similarly, excellent channels of communication are required to perform tasks and provide feedback. Also, employees need to have a strong work ethic (*Business.com*, 2017).

Cheng-Tozun (2018) offers advice for those who control their own schedules. It is recommended that the individual keeps a diary or planner to note personal, social and work activities.

5.4.9 Being a lifelong learner

It is essential to be a lifelong learner in the modern workplace. Technology is constantly evolving and there is always something new to be learned. To remain relevant and competent, you should always be willing to learn new skills and adapt to new situations (i.e. be a lifelong learner). This can have a positive impact on economic, personal and professional spheres of your life (Vander Ark and Ryerse, 2017):

- *Economic sphere:* Lifelong learning results in you being more knowledgeable, competent and generally better at what you do for a living. Having this knowledge can lead to ground-breaking discoveries, and better products and services for consumers.
- *Personal sphere:* The saying 'knowledge is power' is applicable here. According to Vander Ark and Ryerse (2017), lifelong learning gives you a sense of meaning, purpose and empowerment, and can result in individuals pursuing passions and experiencing greater life satisfaction. It also results in people being better informed and aware of the world in which they live.
- *Professional sphere:* Being a lifelong learner makes you more employable. Having vast experience and knowledge will make you more appealing to a variety of employers. It also means that you can share these skills with others and upskill them. It also encourages you to develop a greater social awareness and more perspective, because being exposed to more knowledge gives you a better understanding of the differences among people.

Being a lifelong learner is becoming increasingly easy and accessible. Previously, you may have needed to spend hours in a library, poring over books. Today, technology has made it possible for you to gain knowledge and understanding by watching online tutorials and lectures – e.g. YouTube videos and TED Talks. There are also many

websites that offer access to current research in the form of journal articles and textbooks.

FAST FORWARD: Balancing self and work – Future contexts

The term ‘work-life balance’ has been in use for a fairly long time. However, its definition is constantly changing and evolving. Work-life balance is seen as important for a healthy work environment. In the traditional sense, it essentially suggests that you need to balance your work responsibilities with – or even separate them from – your personal ones. This means that when you go home, you will put aside any concerns related to work, and will focus on your personal duties and needs, such as family, friends, relaxation, entertainment, cooking, housework etc. However, the term can mean different things for different people. For some, work-life balance means not contributing a single minute or ounce of energy more than is required of them.

Kohll (2018) suggests that the reason for this phrase still being in use today, can largely be attributed to how millennials perceive work. There are stereotypes attached to every generation; however, millennials tend to be perceived as the generation that does not regard work ethic as the most important part of their life. For this generation, work is simply seen as one ‘part of life’ (Kohll, 2018), among many parts. As such, some employers have intentionally focused on making their workspaces more ‘millennial-friendly’ – in other words, a more comfortable workspace fitted with luxuries such as on-site restaurants, gyms, masseuse services etc. Despite this, many millennials have expressed that they are more interested in working for a company that can support their lifestyle needs, rather than making their work life more appealing.

Kohll (2018) further explains that a company can ideally promote work-life balance by creating a more flexible environment. This may encompass something like flexible working hours, which allow employees to choose when they want to start and end their work day (as long as they put in the core working hours). For instance, for an eight-hour working day, one employee may choose to start at 08h00 and end at 17h00, while another starts at 10h00 and ends at 18h00, or starts at 06h00 and ends at 14h00. All of these employees will have contributed eight hours worth of work. Employees may also be given the opportunity to work from home on certain days.

In addition to being flexible in terms of working hours, employers can also strive to make the workplace more ‘pleasant’, so that it aligns more with employees’ personal spaces. Since the workplace is where we spend most of our time as working adults, it is important for this to be a comfortable environment. It is also important to provide opportunities for personal growth, in order to achieve this balance. For example, many mothers with babies or young children are seeking jobs that allow them to work from home or to have flexible hours, thereby enabling them to look after their children, while being a working professional at the same time (Kohll, 2018).

In light of this, it has been suggested that we are actually moving away from the term ‘balance’, and toward the term ‘integration’. Morgan (2018) asserts that it is not so much about distinguishing our personal life from our work life, but rather, about *aligning* and *integrating* our personal and professional goals. In other words, work becomes life, and life becomes work. Seeing as we spend so much of our time at work, this idea suggests that we need to find a way to meet both sets of goals at the same time.

To achieve this, Morgan (2018) suggests doing the following:

- Take a look at how you spend most of your ‘free’ time – will your hobbies also help you to progress in your career?
- Try to align your personal and professional goals. For example, a professional goal may be to earn a promotion, while a personal goal may be to earn more money. These goals are aligned because, along with a promotion, you will usually also get a higher salary. As such, you would be achieving two goals simultaneously.
- Evaluate how you are treated in the workplace. Your work is an integral part of your life – you should feel respected in this space, just as much as in any other area of your life.
- Set long-term goals. Short-term goals are necessary, but long-term goals will ensure that you do not get stuck in the same routine, and will constantly motivate you to work toward something bigger and better.
- Be sure to work for an employer who has similar values to you. If the company’s values do not align with your personal values (within reason), you may find yourself wrestling with internal conflict, and therefore struggling to achieve true work-life balance, or integration.

5.5 Summary

- This unit has aimed to improve your understanding of the multiple dimensions of the self. We discovered the importance of knowing our personality, world view, values, interests, skills, personal goals and professional goals. The theories, models and ideas provided may serve to be invaluable in our quest to be successful professionals. At the same time, we acknowledge that these ideas may only scratch the surface of who we really are and our true potential. They may, however, serve as an interesting starting point.

Chapter 6

6.1 Introduction

Conrad has just finished his first week at his very first job. He seems to have had a fairly productive few days, but he has noticed that the amount of interaction he is required to have with clients, other employees and his manager, is slightly overwhelming. The role he is in requires constant interpersonal communication – a set of skills that Conrad has not yet honed. While reading through this unit, keep Conrad's situation in mind and see if you would be able to advise him on how to improve his interpersonal skills at work.

You have already employed interpersonal skills regularly in your life – whether you have work experience or not. If you think back to your school or university days, you would have found yourself in an informal group of friends or in a formal group of colleagues working on assignments. The skills that each member of such a group would have employed in interacting with one another were interpersonal skills.

In either instance, you may have experienced individuals who dominated the group, those who would not take suggestions from anyone else, may have been opinionated, or bad at reading what was needed in that particular social context. This is an example of poor interpersonal skills. Someone who encourages others to succeed in a group, understands the emotions of others, and is approachable, however, displays good interpersonal skills.

Interpersonal skills are one of the cornerstones of success within the workplace – for any individual, within any industry or any job. This unit will elaborate on this in greater detail.

The ability to communicate effectively in the workplace depends heavily on an individual's interpersonal skills. This unit will equip you with the skills and knowledge to successfully interact and communicate with people in an organisational context. It will also explore various practical tools and guidelines to empower you as a professional entering the workplace.

The first major focus of this unit is *teamwork*. The unit will help you develop an understanding of the concept of teamwork through outlining the stages of team formation, the basics of team dynamics, and the diverse characteristics of team players. The unit then explores what is involved in the act of leading and motivating people, and provides a set of guidelines on how to lead and motivate others at work. The importance of competent interaction in meetings will also be highlighted by emphasising the value of attending meetings, identifying the key principles underpinning different types of meetings, and explaining the necessity for efficient

meeting processes. We conclude with a section discussing possible reasons for workplace conflict, ways in which to resolve it, and how to deal with workplace bullying. By the end of this unit, you should have an in-depth understanding of interpersonal skills at work.

After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- explain the importance of interpersonal skills at work;
- discuss the various stages in team formation;
- discuss team dynamics in the workplace and highlight the characteristics of team players
- outline Mintzberg's managerial roles in work groups and teams;
- discuss how one would lead and motivate others at work;
- discuss the meeting process and highlight important aspects of attending and chairing meetings;
- list reasons for workplace conflict;
- suggest ways in which to resolve workplace conflict; and
- suggest ways in which to deal with workplace bullying.

6.2 Key terms and definitions

The following key terms and definitions are applicable to this unit:

- *Emotional intelligence (EQ):* Being sensitive to the feelings of others (being empathic) and having a good understanding of one's own emotions.
- *Formal status:* The respect and recognition an individual gains as a result of their skills, expertise or position in the organisational hierarchy.
- *Group stages:* The five stages of 'forming', 'storming', 'norming', 'performing' and 'adjourning', which every group will go through in order to become a more cohesive unit.
- *Informal status:* The respect and recognition an individual gains owing to their social status and the ability they have to influence others.
- *Mintzberg managerial roles:* Ten roles that describe exactly what is required of a manager within the workplace.
- *Non-verbal communication:* Communication that is not spoken; this may include eye contact, folding of one's arms, posture etc.

- *Sources of power:* A consideration of the origin of an individual's power or ability to influence others. Such power can either come from something formal (such as an individual's skills or position) or informal (such as their personality).
- *Team dynamics:* A variety of factors that influence how well team members work together.
- *Workplace bullying:* Workplace bullying exists, broadly, when individuals feel threatened, unsafe or feel that their working environment is negative as a result of another individual. It can, however, occur in various ways.
- *Workplace norms:* Generally accepted behaviours at work that most employees comply with.

6.3 The importance of interpersonal skills at work

By now, you should know what communication entails. Going one step further, *interpersonal* communication can be described as communication that occurs between two or more people, in which they 'take turns' to be either the speaker or the listener. This turn-taking is not always equal, however (McIntosh et al., 2008: 2). A typical example of interpersonal communication in the workplace would be a manager giving instructions to an employee to perform a task. The manager might do most of the talking, while the employee listens. Their roles would switch, however, if the manager had to ask questions such as: 'Is everything clear? Do you have any questions about this?' Here, the manager becomes the listener and the employee the speaker. Their ability to have a respectful, clear conversation, in which they both engage, would be a good example of successful interpersonal communication.

Now, consider the *skills* that you need to successfully engage in interpersonal communication. Interpersonal skills refer to the manner in which an individual is able to relate to others around them, and effectively manage the social situations in which they find themselves.

National Research Council (2011) suggests that interpersonal skills encompass components relating to one's attitude, behaviour and cognitive abilities in communicating with others. Someone who displays *successful* interpersonal skills, is aware of and corrects their social behaviour or performance based on how others react to them. Think back to the manager-employee example mentioned in the previous paragraph. Both the manager and the employee would have to display certain skills during their interaction, for it to be considered successful.

Your emotional intelligence (EQ) also plays a major role in how successful these interpersonal skills may be. Let's look more closely at the concept of EQ, before moving on to examine interpersonal skills at work.

Goleman (1995: 42) states that within the modern workplace, an individual's EQ, has become more essential than their IQ (their traditional intelligence). Research has shown that as much as 80 per cent of an individual's success at work can be linked to their level of EQ. This may be attributed to the fact that as an employee, one is consistently interacting with other people – whether you are interacting with colleagues, mentors, management or clients. In many modern careers, dealing with people is an ongoing occurrence, and employees therefore need to know how to deal with them effectively. When dealings with people are positive, it can result in the following:

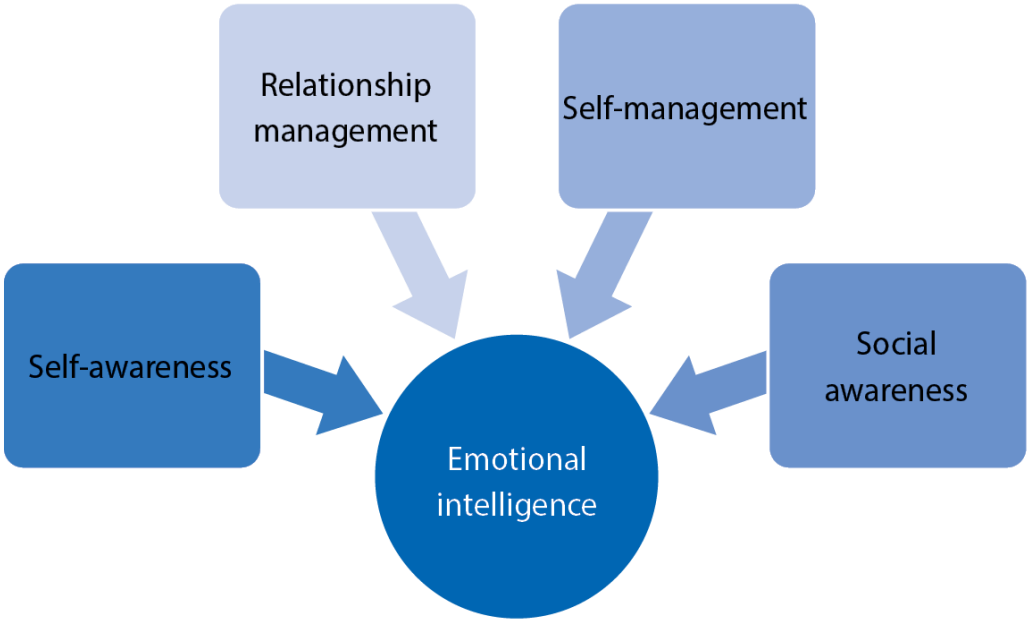
- More cohesive teams
- An increased number of clients
- A positive and collegial working environment
- Less employee conflict
- Greater productivity of employees due to greater understanding of one another
- Greater personal success for the employee as individuals
- Enhanced communication between employees

Goleman (1995: 71) highlights that a high EQ can result in the following benefits:

- A higher EQ assists in forming the foundation for all necessary competencies within a job.

- Individuals with a higher EQ are generally more successful both in the workplace and in their personal lives.
- Such individuals may be more even-tempered and happy.
- They are better at regulating their moods.
- They have higher levels of impulse control.

Goleman (1995: 43) developed a model that includes four key components of emotional intelligence. These are shown in the following figure.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Goleman, 1995: 43)Figure 6.1: Emotional intelligence model

Let's take a look at each one of these components in more detail and consider how they can influence an individual's interpersonal skills in the workplace.

Self-awareness

This entails an individual being aware of their emotions, no matter how unpleasant these may be. It is the understanding of one's own needs, wants, desires and emotions (Cullen, 2018). With this comes an understanding of the impact of one's behaviour, when one acts on certain emotions. A higher level of self-awareness encourages better decision-making, as the individual has more insight into exactly what they want. Such self-awareness can result in a greater sense of fulfilment in life (Goleman, 1995: 43).

A lack of self-awareness could negatively impact interpersonal communication; therefore, it is important to be aware of your emotions, so that you can self-manage them (this component is discussed later on).

Relationship management

This component focuses on how relationships are built with others. This may also involve the understanding of complex emotions in others and trying to see the perspective of others. Goleman (1995: 43) highlights that those who are effective in relationship management are also good at showing empathy when dealing with others. Effective relationship management also relies on mutual trust and respect (Cullen, 2018).

An appropriate workplace example might include a manager conducting a performance review with their team member. Imagine that these two individuals have a friendly relationship outside of work, but during the performance review, a different dynamic is required. The manager and the team member would need to conduct themselves professionally during the review. Just as the manager would need to convey any critiques respectfully, the team member would need to respectfully acknowledge the feedback, and not take it personally. Another example of relationship management would be understanding the difference between the type of relationship you may have with your manager, and that which you may have with a colleague who performs the same tasks as you. This dynamic should always be kept in mind to ensure successful interpersonal communication in either context.

Self-management

While self-awareness is being aware of one's emotions, self-management is the controlling of those emotions and of one's impulses. One might do this to prevent oneself from making any rash decisions. Cullen (2018) notes that this practice includes keeping one's emotions in check and not behaving in a way that is inappropriate. For example, self-management will be demonstrated when an individual is angry, but composes themselves and manages their temper. If they were not able to do this, it could be detrimental to their professional or personal relationships in the long run, and could result in an unprofessional reputation.

This also entails being able to manage negative emotions, such as anxiety, irritability or gloom (Goleman, 1995: 43). Individuals who are unable to manage these emotions properly can have high levels of distress and will have difficulty bouncing back from upsets.

Self-managing in the workplace is a crucial skill, as there may be many situations in which you feel stressed, anxious, frustrated, or simply disagree with something. For example, if a manager instructs you to perform a task within an unrealistic time frame, you might start to feel stressed, or even annoyed with the situation. Instead of simply saying, 'No, this is ridiculous; I cannot do this amount of work in the time you have given me', you should rather be aware of those feelings but express them in a more professional and calm manner. For example, you could say, 'Thanks for the brief, but I am concerned that I might not be able to finish this in time, because …' This would be a better way to handle these emotions.

Social awareness

This component focuses on picking up on subtle emotional cues from others. A great deal of communication is unspoken. Social awareness entails being able to read others' facial expressions, body language or the subtext to something that somebody is saying. Goleman (1995: 43) states that social awareness may include developing a sense of altruism. This is the genuine concern for the well-being of others, and entails having the desire to help where possible (*Psychology Today*, n.d.). Cullen (2018) simply describes it as being in tune with the feelings and needs of others.

Emotional intelligence as a whole

Together, these elements of emotional intelligence lead to an individual having a high level of interpersonal skill. This means that they can communicate well with colleagues, managers, and clients, making them more successful in the workplace.

In a work environment, an appropriate example of the use of emotional intelligence might be a manager showing care for a subordinate. Imagine being a manager; perhaps one day you notice that your subordinate is struggling emotionally, as they are unusually quiet and subdued. Approaching the person privately and offering to talk to them about what is wrong would help you maintain a good relationship with them. Displaying empathy in your engagement with them, and assuring them that you will keep any information that they share confidential, will help build a sense of trust.

Be cognisant of how people like to be treated during times of emotional stress. Some people might enjoy being checked up on often, whereas others may prefer to be left alone. Being aware of how to handle these types of situations will only enhance your interpersonal skills.

Beyond the components of EQ, Cullen (2018) suggests that the following skills contribute to having high levels of interpersonal skills:

- Managing conflict well
- Good problem-solving ability
- Demonstrating responsibility
- Being accountable for one's actions
- Showing appreciation for others
- Being flexible in one's approach to doing work

It should now be clear that interpersonal communication is extremely important within an organisation – for people in management or leadership positions, as well as for employees. This is especially prevalent within the modern workplace – most jobs require some form of collaboration, or teamwork, few jobs require tasks to be done in isolation from other people (McIntosh et al., 2008: 3–4).

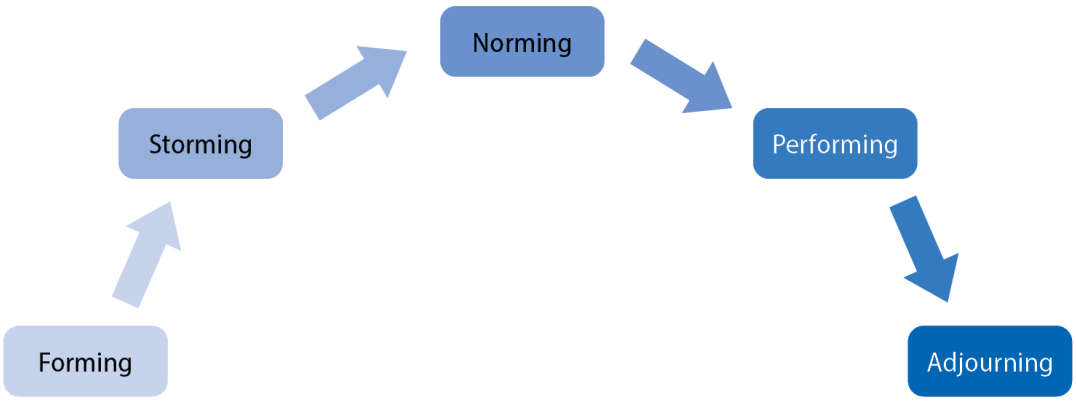
6.4 Knowing the team

Although work can be organised in a fragmented way (i.e. where employees work in an individualised manner and are encouraged to meet deadlines of their own accord), many companies have concluded that teamwork is oftentimes more productive.

Teamwork is said to accomplish far more than individuals working alone, and it frequently plays a key role in organisational success. It differs from individual work, where work goals are pursued with a sense of independence. In contrast, it is defined as 'work that involves a group of colleagues who cooperate quite closely and are interdependent in achieving collective work goals' (Bergh and Theron, 2003: 450). Cooperation and interdependence are therefore key defining features of working in teams (Verderber et al., 2013).
This section of the unit focuses on some of the defining features of teamwork. It firstly investigates a key theory proposed by Tuckman (1965), which discusses the different stages of team formation. It then explores the dynamics of teamwork and the attributes characteristic of team players.

6.4.1 Understanding team formation

Tuckman is one of several psychologists who argue that teams must move through various necessary stages of formation, when completing a task. These stages are: *forming*, *storming*, *norming*, *performing* and *adjourning*, as represented in the following figure (Tuckman, 1965). This particular model of team formation is of special importance, because it acts as the basis for many contemporary team-formation models.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Tuckman, 1965)Figure 6.2: Stages in team formation

Forming

The first stage of team development is *forming*. During this phase, members are usually engaged in orientating themselves toward the team's goal. Their main objective at this stage is to understand the role they will play in reaching this specific goal. During this time, team members usually evaluate each other's skills, talents and abilities in an attempt to gain an understanding of each other, and to determine which of these aspects can be employed to accomplish the team's common goal. At this stage of team formation, members are usually 'cautious' with each other, as they are not completely sure what the team as a whole may or may not accept – and members are generally keen to be accepted by the team (Hartzell, n.d.). Furthermore, disagreements in this stage are usually kept to a minimum, because members want to be seen as open and friendly (Verderber et al., 2013).

Storming

As team members become more familiar with one another, they also become more honest about their opinions. This signals the next stage of team development, namely, *storming* (Verderber et al., 2013). In this stage, the team's power structure becomes important to members, and they will work to establish their place within it. Dominant group members will emerge during this stage, as questions around leadership, responsibilities, structure and authority tend to arise (Hartzell, n.d.). Team members that are not confrontational find this stage quite difficult to go through. While storming, members may take sides and form alliances, which often makes them appear aggressive. If exchanges between group members become severe, and the team finds itself unable to move past this stage, the team's survival is threatened (Abudi, 2009).

Norming

The norming stage, which follows storming, is characterised by a combined attempt by members to develop a sense of unity and trust, increase collaboration, and strive toward achieving the team goal. Members tend to respect each other's differences, and opinions are expressed honestly during this

stage. Relationships also have the potential to become strengthened, and members feel increasingly comfortable to express their ideas and opinions. At this point, the team establishes a set of norms that the members are more ready to accept. Members are now also more receptive to mutual feedback (Verderber et al., 2013).

Performing

The fourth stage of team development is *performing*. This stage is characterised by a sense of congruence (i.e. similarity) and harmony. Members also demonstrate greater productivity, in that they work collectively to solve problems. During this stage, the team pools together its skills and knowledge, and members concentrate their collective energies on achieving the team's goal. The group's conversations are now mainly centred on sharing information regarding the task at hand. However, teams can only achieve their full potential during this stage if they have successfully resolved conflicts that arose during the 'storming' stage, and if they have developed productive norms in the 'norming' stage (Verderber et al., 2013).

Adjourning

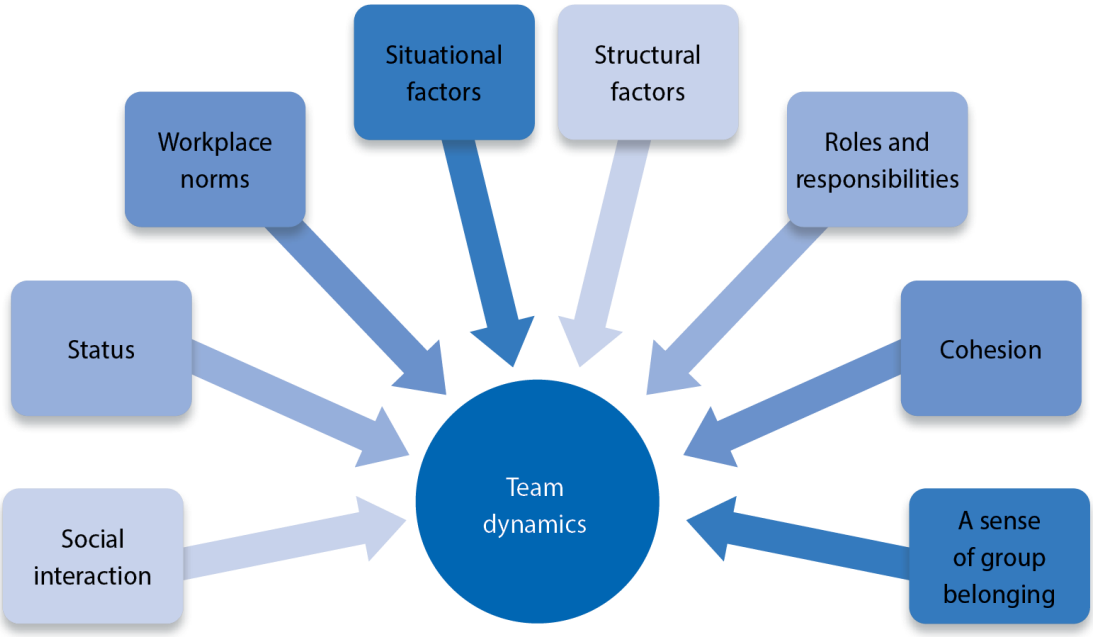
When the team recognises that it has reached its goal, *adjourning* begins. During this stage, the team will celebrate their accomplishments and highlight the roles that members played in the process. Afterward, team members will begin to disengage from their relationships with one another. The team may formally disband (i.e. break up), even though some members may decide to continue seeing each other in social settings; or the team may continue to exist with the aim of achieving a new goal (Verderber et al., 2013).

Verderber et al. (2013) explain that Tuckman's model works optimally for smaller teams that usually comprise about ten to 12 people; however, when it comes to larger teams, the formation of subsystems or cliques creates complications, rendering this particular model inappropriate. Although variations of this model exist, models of team formation frequently recognise that teams require ongoing, honest and effective communication in order to succeed.

6.4.2 Understanding team dynamics

Our next task is to examine team dynamics. Team dynamics relate to the system of (conscious and unconscious) psychological processes of team members. These psychological processes underpin the group's ability to function properly. Team dynamics can be formally defined as 'the behavioural relationships between members of a group that are assigned connected tasks within a company' (*BusinessDictionary* 1, n.d.). Such dynamics are affected by the group members' roles and responsibilities, and these dynamics influence productivity, staff retention rates and performance (on both a team and individual level), job enjoyability and even company profits (*BusinessDictionary* 1, n.d.; and Myers, 2013). Certain factors have the power to influence team dynamics. These factors include the following (Bergh and Theron, 2003; Chand, n.d.; and Plowman, 2015):

- Social interaction
- Status
- Workplace norms
- Situational factors
- Structural factors
- Roles and responsibilities
- Cohesion
- A sense of belonging to the group



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Bergh and Theron, 2003; Chand, n.d.; and Plowman, 2015)Figure 6.3: Factors that influence team dynamics

Social interaction

Social interaction in groups occurs through team members' formal and informal contact. Formal contact may occur in meetings, while informal contact may occur in the canteen, for example. The influence group members have over each other is represented by instances where members persuade each other to try out new things, dominate others and even compete with one another.

Status

Social hierarchies often arise within teams. Usually a status is assigned to a specific member as a result of a characteristic that distinguishes that position from other positions. For example, an individual may be given the leader position due to their seniority, current position in the company, or experience.

Bergh and Theron (2003) argue that there are two main types of status awarded within groups: formal and informal status. *Formal status* is awarded through job titles or features and includes the recognition of a person holding a special place within the organisation; it can also be awarded when receiving an actual award. Status symbols such as large offices, special parking bays and titles are associated with formal status. *Informal status*, on the other hand, is awarded through characteristics such as age, sex, education or skill. For example, someone may be informally recognised by colleagues as being intelligent or skilful; however, they may not be formally recognised by the company in the form of an official title. A group may be dominated by an individual who may not necessarily have an elevated position in the organisational hierarchy, but who does have a strong, charismatic personality that easily influences others. The status that a team member holds often influences how other members of the group socially interact with them.

Workplace norms

Team members are usually expected to agree on what they want to achieve during their planning sessions. After agreeing on their goal, the members would, ideally, actively collaborate to achieve these objectives by abiding by the norms that have been put in place. A norm is defined as 'a standard or pattern, especially of social behaviour, that is typical or expected' (*Oxford Dictionaries*, n.d.).

Norms consist of a range of acceptable behaviours and can be formalised by being stated explicitly as part of a workplace's policy. Such norms can include aspects such as starting times of meetings, dress code, social etiquette, attendance, productivity etc. The group often punishes members who do not adhere to important norms by isolating, excluding or ignoring them (Chand, n.d.).

Negative consequences of conformity to such workplace norms do, however, exist. They can include the loss of individuality and the promotion of moderate performance levels. On the other hand, the positive consequences of group conformity include the predictability of behavioural patterns – which can aid group performance.

Situational factors

Situational factors such as group size and structure, appear to have a strong influence on the overall behaviour of the group (Bergh and Theron, 2003). These factors also impact productivity.

Larger team sizes will entail more resources being available (i.e. knowledge, skills and personality characteristics) when working toward achieving a common goal; however, a larger team will also entail an increased risk of conflict. When levels of conflict increase, productivity, cohesion and satisfaction are likely to decrease (Chand, n.d.; and Plowman, 2015). Small groups consisting of two to ten people are therefore considered more effective, due to each team member having an opportunity to participate, as well as the decreased potential for conflict (Chand, n.d.).

Structural factors

Structural factors such as the geographic dispersion of the group (i.e. people from different branches in different regions of the same organisation working together), also impact group behaviour. Cultural factors may also affect adherence to group norms, as cultures that emphasise group cohesion tend to comply more with norms than cultures that emphasise individualism do (Bergh and Theron, 2003).

Roles and responsibilities

Team members are expected to organise and share the work by assigning tasks to different people, authorising various people to assume roles (e.g. those of chairperson or leader), and laying down rules for behaviour.

According to Bergh and Theron (2003: 238), 'roles' refers to 'a set of expected behaviour patterns attributed to someone occupying a given position in the group'. For example, the leader may be responsible for making final decisions, facilitating meetings, negotiating disputes, keeping the team on track and being accountable for the team as a whole. These roles are expected behavioural patterns that the leader is responsible for, by virtue of holding a leadership position in the team. The roles of a team member can be determined by task requirements, personal attributes and group characteristics (Bergh and Theron, 2003). For example, the leader is required to carry out certain tasks, but such tasks can only be carried out if they are personally capable of doing so, and if there is not already another individual in the group responsible for carrying out these tasks. It is therefore important to consider the various aspects related to team members' roles (Bergh and Theron, 2003):

- *Role identity:* This is the identity that an individual assumes based on the role they play in the group. The actual behaviours and attitudes consistent with an assigned role determine the individual's role identity. However, individuals can move from one role identity to another, according to the required changes of a situation and its demands.
- *Role perception:* This involves how individuals themselves view how they ought to behave in a specific situation. These personal expectations of behaviour will determine their behaviours in various situations. The media, television, books, friends and other influences may be instrumental in forming such perceptions.
- *Role expectations:* This relates to others' perceptions and expectations of how an individual should act in certain situations. The individual's behaviour is therefore influenced by the context in which they exist. Contextual aspects can include one's society or family, for example.
- *Role conflict:* This refers to a situation where an individual is confronted by conflicting role expectations or role responsibilities (*Academic Library*, n.d.). Role conflict can occur when one role assumes contradictory behaviours; for example, when a human resource manager has to offer support to an employee, while simultaneously being involved in that same employee's disciplinary hearing. Another type of role conflict occurs when individuals belong to many groups simultaneously – in such cases, the requirements of one role within a group may directly contradict the requirements of another.
- *Role ambiguity:* This is the discrepancy between the actual and the perceived role (*Academic Library*, n.d.). Role ambiguity is a major problem in the workplace, because if employees are not made aware of what is expected of them, they can end up spending a great deal of time attempting to clarify their roles. This is directly related to performance in the workplace, as ambiguity often leads to frustration, stress and job dissatisfaction (Academic Library, n.d.). 'Role overload' is also related to role ambiguity, and occurs when excessive demands are placed on the individual, as a result of the role(s) they perform in the group.

Cohesion

Cohesion refers to the strength of the team members' bond. It includes the team's sense of unity, members' feelings toward one another, and the individual team members' desire to remain part of

the group (Chand, n.d.). The amount of group cohesiveness usually depends on factors such as how often team members interact with one another, intragroup competition, the level of agreement on norms and goals, as well as a favourable group evaluation. Teams that are small in size and that interact on a frequent basis are more likely to be cohesive than larger teams, where members do not spend regular time with one another.

Although cohesiveness is positive in many ways (it increases productivity and employee satisfaction, while decreasing absenteeism and turnover), it can encourage 'groupthink' (Chand, n.d.). Groupthink occurs when teams suppress views that differ from their own, in order to preserve group harmony (Plowman, 2015). The phenomenon of groupthink can be detrimental, as it results in careless judgements and unrealistic courses of action that ensure the avoidance of team conflict (Chand, n.d.). It can also result in a group of individuals who remain afraid to ever challenge the status quo and as a result, the group may not risk generating new, creative and innovative ideas.

A sense of group belonging

Group members are expected to identify and perceive themselves as part of the group. The composition of the group is central here – i.e. the variety of skills, personalities and other characteristics that make up a group.

One factor that relates to team identity (or the lack thereof), is 'group demography'. This concept considers the extent to which members of an organisation share common attributes; for example, their level of education, age group or experience. The more similar people are, the more their sense of belonging ought to increase. However, most groups consist of members with a large variety of knowledge and skills (Bergh and Theron, 2003). Groups can also be heterogeneous in terms of opinions, personalities and perspectives. This results in a greater probability of the group possessing the required characteristics and creativity to be successful in their relevant tasks, but a lower amount of similarity.

Although heterogeneity in a team can be beneficial, research indicates that turnover in a group (i.e. the number of members leaving the group) is higher in diverse groups. This is because of difficulties in communication that can result from differences in experience between members. Power struggles and conflict are therefore more common if a team is highly diverse, resulting in a lowered sense of group belonging. There are three types of team behaviour that can result in a lowered sense of group belonging:

- *Social loafing:* This refers to people's tendency to work less hard – or put in less effort – when they work in a team rather than on an individual basis (Cherry, 2016). Team members often feel that other members of the team will take responsibility for the task; in extreme cases, some individuals feel that other team members will take responsibility for the entire task (Cherry, 2016). For example, have you ever been assigned a group assignment where you ended up doing all the work, while the other team members sat back and waited for you to do so? This is a prime example of 'social loafing' by the other members. However, social loafing is not always merely a result of laziness – often people feel a lowered sense of responsibility, due to their difficulty in identifying with the group. Group members may not always feel a sense of belonging, and consequently, they will 'slack' in the group.
- *The free-rider effect:* This refers to team members' tendency to reduce their efforts when they think their contribution (or lack thereof) will not contribute to the final product whatsoever (Long-Crowell, n.d.). In this case, individuals demonstrate lower levels of commitment, because they believe their contributions to the group are not necessary.
- *The sucker effect:* This behaviour becomes apparent when the individual contributes a minimum amount of effort, based on the belief that the other members of the group are not performing to the best of their abilities. Individuals that display this kind of behaviour are often those who are concerned that other team members will leave them to do all the work (i.e. make them into a 'sucker') if they themselves contribute meaningfully throughout the process (Long-Crowell, n.d.).

To avoid behaviours such as social loafing, the free-rider effect and the sucker effect, managers in the workplace need to ensure that working in groups enhances morale and teamwork. They should also ensure there are measures in place that can identify individual contributions and efforts (Bergh and Theron, 2003).

6.4.3 Being a team player

Teamwork forms an integral part of today's working environment. A company cannot become successful by relying solely on the work of any single employee, regardless of how competent or efficient they are (Maxwell, 2002). While teamwork is highly valued, there are serious implications for the productivity of any company when a member of one of its teams fails to cooperate.

For an individual to become a team player, a number of interpersonal skills must be developed. In this section, we discuss several interpersonal skills that are important for effective teamwork in the workplace. Maxwell (2002) lists 11 of these skills, which we will briefly unpack.

1. Adaptability

In Maxwell's (2002) view, adaptability is essential to the skillset of any team player. Adaptability helps a team player welcome new members to the team without feeling threatened, and it also helps individuals be open to changes to the way things are done. People who have this trait do not fear doing something different, and they focus on the efforts of the team, rather than on themselves. Maxwell (2002) suggests that people can learn how to become more adaptable by getting into the habit of trying new things and regularly re-evaluating their role within the team.

2. The ability to collaborate

Maxwell (2002) argues that collaboration goes beyond cooperation, in the sense that it consists of more than working together in an agreeable manner; rather, it involves working together in a more 'aggressive' way. He proposes that every team player contributes something of value and goes beyond putting in the minimum required effort. He also suggests that every team member incorporates collaboration into their skillset, by giving specific attention to their perception and attitude toward other team members. The idea conveyed here is that a team player should re-evaluate how they perceive their fellow team members, and should aim to see them as collaborators, instead of competitors. When this is the case, skills and talents work to complement one another, rather than compete against one another.

3. Having a sense of commitment

Commitment can be defined as a person's dedication to something they have agreed or set out to do. Team members need to be committed to the team, in order to work in the most effective manner and achieve the goals they have outlined as a team. Maxwell (2002) argues that a committed team member does not surrender easily, nor do they depend on external rewards. This means that a committed team member will not give up easily, nor will they necessarily act in a certain way to merely receive a reward (e.g. recognition). Commitment should therefore be dictated by choice, not circumstance.

Maxwell (2002) states that commitment lasts longer when an individual bases it on their values. This is because people are more likely to work toward something that they consider to be meaningful or something that they believe in. A team player may therefore work toward improving their level of commitment by drawing correlations between their commitments and their values. This task requires them to make a careful comparison between their professional commitments and their own core values.

4. Communication skills

Team players need to be communicative in the sense of not isolating themselves from others, and by providing accessible avenues for others to reach them. People can work to improve communication by being honest, and can foster trust through a sense of openness. Speaking to other team members in a truthful, yet kind and respectful manner, is another way to improve communication. It is vital to be as inclusive as possible: this involves team members keeping each other informed at all times, and not withholding information from one another (Maxwell, 2002).

5. Competence

Being competent involves more than possessing sufficient skills to accomplish a job. It suggests that the individual should have the necessary qualifications to complete the task in a capable manner. Competence goes hand in hand with a commitment to excellence. It entails devoting time to all the details of a task, performing consistently and never settling for mediocrity. For the most part, people are encouraged to select an area of specialisation, work toward perfecting this area, and then give their best effort when doing tasks relating to this area (Maxwell, 2002).

6. Dependability

Dependability refers to a person's ability to be relied upon. Being a dependable team member involves an individual keeping their word when taking on a responsibility, exercising sound judgement and making consistent contributions. It is very important for everyone in the team to be dependable, as this will ensure that members of the team are able to rely on each other, regardless of what happens. Maxwell (2002) suggests improving team members' dependability through

individuals examining their motives and committing themselves to a set of goals. Team members should evaluate their goals in relation to the team they form part of, in order to find ways to align their personal priorities accordingly (Maxwell, 2002).

7. Being disciplined

According to Maxwell (2002), becoming a team player involves developing disciplined thinking. This involves an individual keeping their mind active by consistently focusing on the 'right' things. The 'right' things are those actions that will assist a team member in working toward the goals they have set out to achieve.

It is also advisable to discipline one's emotions. Emotional discipline is the ability to choose how one feels. For example, when someone is in a stressful scenario, they may decide to keep calm, as opposed to feeling stressed; thereby making a conscious decision to feel a certain way. The ability to discipline one's thinking and emotions leads to disciplined actions – i.e. acting in a way that best benefits the team. A person can enhance their levels of discipline by taking on challenges they are not accustomed to overcoming.

8. Enlarging

To sustain high levels of success, team members need to be consistently inspired. Team players who appreciate the contributions of their team members, add value to the team. Maxwell (2002) explains that this appreciation enlarges searches for distinctive talents in others, and helps bring out those talents for the benefit of the team. Naturally, this involves motivating them to move out of their comfort zones and do more for the team (Maxwell, 2002). For example, a team leader may recognise that one of their team members has great leadership potential. In order for this individual to be promoted to a leadership position in the future, the current team leader may decide to take this individual under their wing and train them.

9. Reciprocity

Earning the respect of others (and respecting them in turn) is an important attribute for a team player to develop (Maxwell, 2002). Trust is vital for sustaining relationships and reciprocity is essential (i.e. the sense of giving and taking in the team relationship). In order to better relate to other team members, it is advisable to make others feel special by paying attention to their contributions, genuinely complimenting them, and showing sincerity when doing so.

10. Selflessness

A team player should display an attitude of selflessness and emphasise interdependence over independence (Maxwell, 2002). Becoming more selfless involves taking on a subordinate role, finding positive things to say about others, and promoting others (Carstens, 2015).

11. Being solution-oriented

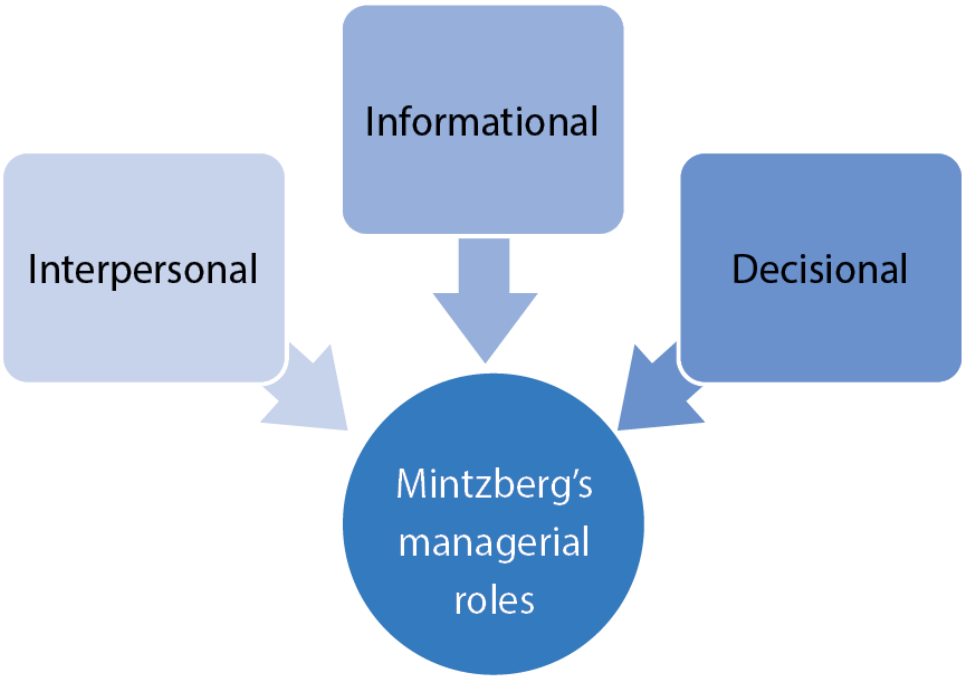
A team player is solution-oriented when they see that problems stand in the way of progress and that they are solvable (Maxwell, 2002). Team members should not allow a problem to halt the team's progress. To develop team-playing skills that are solution-oriented, it is imperative to rethink current strategies and constantly brainstorm new ideas and approaches to address specific problems.

6.4.4 Understanding Mintzberg's managerial roles in the context of teams

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One of the most well-known and important theories regarding the roles of managers is that of Mintzberg. Being in a managerial role comes with various responsibilities. These may range from handling conflict between employees, to handling meetings, to addressing difficulties with customers.

According to Mintzberg, a manager's different roles can be broadly categorised into ten distinct roles – and these roles are further categorised into three overarching categories (Robbins et al., 2009: 5). These three categories are shown in the following figure.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Robbins et al., 2009: 5)Figure 6.4: Mintzberg's managerial role categories

Let's take a closer look at each of the ten roles, and how they are distributed within these categories.

Interpersonal role

This role focuses on dealing with others, and providing information and ideas to others. The specific roles in this category are discussed in what follows (Robbins et al., 2009: 5):

1. *Figurehead:* This entails being the person with authority and the individual who is the 'face' of the company. A manager will be required to carry out several duties of a routine nature as a figurehead.
2. *Leader:* This role includes managing, directing and guiding employees.
3. *Liaison:* The manager is responsible for communicating with internal parties (such as fellow employees), as well as external parties (including suppliers or clients).

Informational role

The elements included in this role focus on how information will be *processed*. The roles in this category are discussed in what follows (Robbins et al., 2009: 5):

4. *Monitor:* Managers are on the receiving end of a large amount of information – whether it comes from inside the organisation, or externally. Being a monitor involves receiving this information and monitoring the performance and well-being of a team, which constitutes further valuable information.
5. *Disseminator:* In this role, a manager disseminates any communication or information received to the relevant employees, appropriately.
6. *Spokesperson:* As a spokesperson, the manager speaks on behalf of the organisation, transmitting information to external parties. This often occurs when liaising with clients or the press.

Decisional roles

This category relates to how the information gained has been used. Each element is discussed in greater detail in what follows (Robbins et al., 2009: 5):

7. *Entrepreneur:* A manager should be searching their environment for opportunities in which they can create and control change. This may include solving problems and generating new ideas within their team.
8. *Disturbance handler:* Whenever there is a roadblock, the manager takes charge, implements actions to correct the situation, and mediates disputes when necessary.

9. *Resource allocator:* A manager is responsible for making and approving important decisions for the organisation in terms of resources – e.g. allocating funds or assisting in setting a budget.
10. *Negotiator:* Occasionally, the manager may need to take part in, or direct, important decisions during major negotiations.

This information is especially important within the context of teams. It gives us a clearer understanding of what the manager of the team is meant to be responsible for, and shows the type of dynamic that should be present between a manager and their team.

6.5 Leading and motivating others at work

The success of a team leader largely depends on their ability to lead and motivate team members (Gaines and Wilson, 2005). Team leaders have the obligation to provide leadership to their team; however, this responsibility also revolves around their ability to drive their group through change, to motivate their team, to make well-informed decisions, and to guide the efforts of the team toward completing tasks productively. This section focuses on a few key suggestions proposed by Gaines and Wilson (2005), which emphasise how team leaders can enhance their skills of leading and motivating a team.

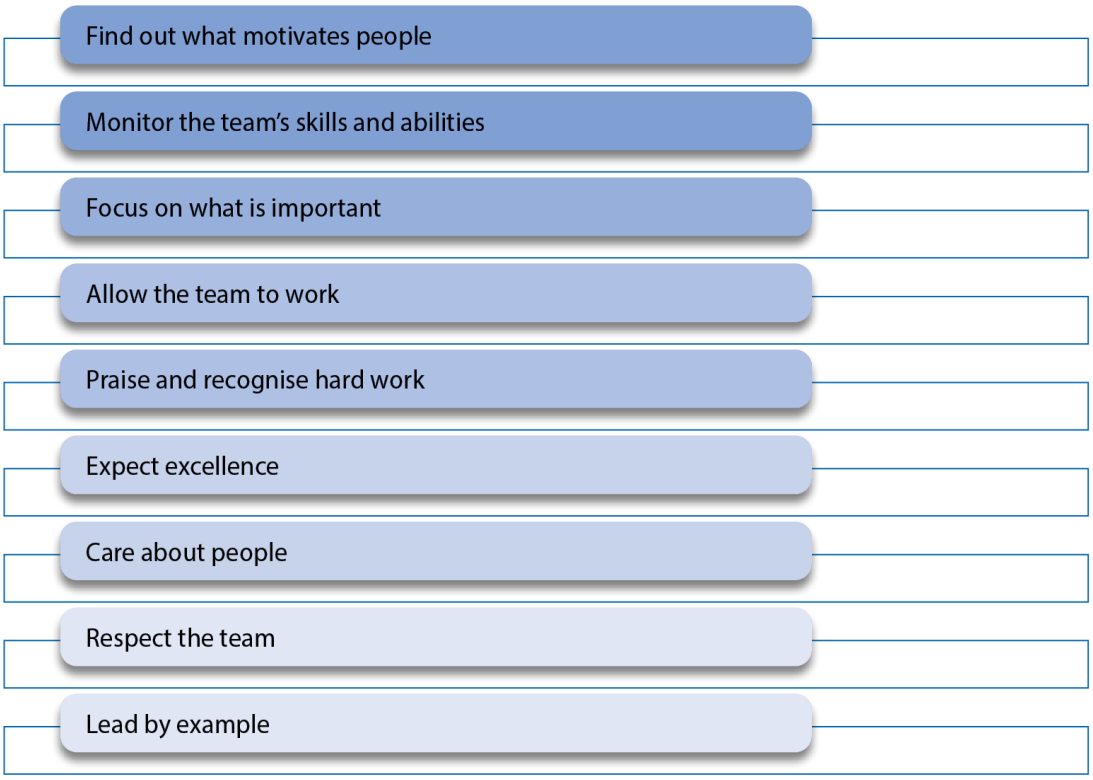
What does leading and motivating involve?

Leadership is not about the exercise of power and the domination of team members. Instead, leadership centres around helping people to efficiently meet the expectations that have been set out for the team. The role of a leader involves decision-making regarding complex issues, and a demonstration of courage when required to take risks. An efficient leader is expected to be an agent of change – i.e. someone who seeks out opportunities for change, and then builds enthusiasm for the changes required (Gaines and Wilson, 2005).

The task of motivating a team is a vital responsibility of any team leader, because it has direct implications for team productivity and effectiveness. Gaines and Wilson (2005) indicate that when teams are motivated, they work together with energy and enthusiasm. Their chances of being productive are then much higher than when the group is bored or dissatisfied. Clearly, a critical part of any team leader's role is to build team motivation.

How to lead and motivate people

The steps discussed in what follows represent a framework of nine strategies that can be employed to lead and motivate people in a team. These ideas are illustrated in the following figure.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Gaines and Wilson, 2005)Figure 6.5: Strategies to lead and motivate people

Find out what motivates people

Finding out what motivates people provides a useful road map to addressing the problems a team faces. This process involves drawing up and obtaining answers to pertinent questions that will help a leader understand what factors drive members of the team to perform optimally, and what factors stand in the way of their maximum contribution. Examples of such questions include (Douthwaite Wolf, n.d.):

- How do you want to be rewarded?
- What do you like about my management style?
- What can I do to make your job more manageable?
- How do you work best?

The answers to these questions can indicate what motivates people within the team. The team leader can then use this information to motivate the team, by making changes to the activities that team members do not enjoy and enhancing those that they do enjoy.

Monitor the team's skills and abilities

A key responsibility of a team leader is to ensure that members' skills and knowledge are suitable for the task at hand. If team members do not have the specific skills and abilities that are required for a specific job, it may create inequity (i.e. a lack of fairness) within the team. This inequity can have serious implications for the motivation of the team, as members who are performing optimally may display attitudes of resentment toward individuals who are underperforming. Additionally, the person who is having difficulty meeting the standards of the team may also experience frustration. If the team members do not have the required level of skill, arrangements should be made to organise the training that they need.

Focus on what is important

As a leader, it is advisable to drive the team to complete those tasks that have the highest impact on the organisation. There is a strong probability that when team members understand how their work fits into the organisation's plan, they will work harder and smarter. In this regard, the role of leader involves helping the team to prioritise work and to point out situations where time is being wasted on trivial and distracting work.

Allow the team to work

Once a team leader has explained the essential aspects of the task, the team should be given the space to independently complete it. Meddling, interfering or second-guessing other members' work, may be demoralising and demotivating for such individuals. While it is important to be aware of the team's progress, part of their professional growth involves learning from their mistakes. A good leader should be available to remove impediments (i.e. obstructions) to the team's progress and redirect actions if they are off course. A good leader respects the autonomy of the team, allows others to make decisions as part of their work and, thereby, trusts their judgement.

Praise and recognise hard work

Human beings naturally need to feel good about themselves and their contributions to the broader group. Praise and recognition can serve as powerful motivators. This could range from a simple 'thank you', to a substantial financial bonus for a job well executed. Gaines and Wilson (2005) argue that praising ongoing accomplishments can help generate greater team enthusiasm. A good team leader should, however, not only reward *large* accomplishments – they should also reward incremental progress.

Expect excellence

Gaines and Wilson (2005) argue that motivation is directly linked to excellence. People want to be associated with admirable achievements. On the other hand, mediocre work is demoralising to everyone involved. Gaines and Wilson (2005) highlight that people are more likely to succeed if they believe that others are expecting them to do so. Part of your role as motivator of the team is to discourage negative attitudes or unproductive complaining. The idea conveyed here is that the team leader should not just *ignore* all trivial complaints, but rather steer people toward believing they are capable of solving problems in an effective manner.

Care about people

A further argument put forward by Gaines and Wilson (2005) is that a strong leader is one who is open to ideas and opinions from all members of the team, regardless of their status or position. Caring about people involves taking necessary criticism, answering tough questions, finding out how all members are doing, and finding out what members find satisfying and frustrating. A good leader listens carefully in order to demonstrate their care for the team.

Respect the team

There is a high probability for team members who do not feel respected to become dispirited, and as a consequence, contribute minimally to the task. A good leader needs to engage with team members to create an environment where members feel comfortable to openly express their views. The team leader needs to encourage team members to demonstrate respect, through a process of listening and responding to the concerns and perspectives of others. Team leaders who nurture diversity and celebrate the unique qualities that each individual brings to the team, are likely to be successful.

Lead by example

As a final point, Gaines and Wilson (2005) argue that team leaders can serve as role models for their teams, as well as for the organisation. It naturally follows that, if a leader expects excellence and enthusiasm from their team, they need to exhibit excellence and enthusiasm in everything they do. In essence, the leader needs to lead and motivate by example. It is advised that leaders should aim to model healthy values: they should exemplify a healthy work-life balance, by showing that living a rich and balanced life is a worthwhile and attainable goal.

6.6 Chairing and attending meetings

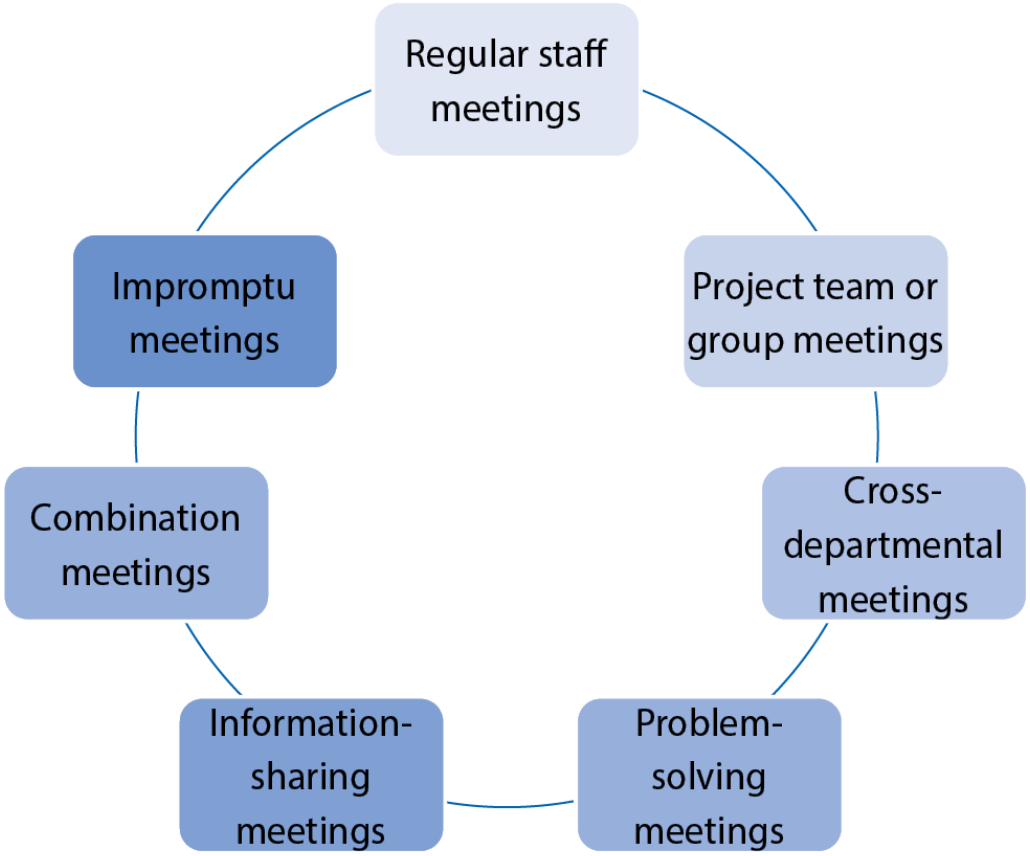
A meeting is defined as a deliberate assembly of people, whose purpose is to discuss issues and make decisions, in an informal or a formal setting (*BusinessDictionary* 2, n.d.). Meetings serve various important functions in the organisation: these range from providing a platform for decision-making, to resolving complex organisational issues. A professional should think carefully about the important aspects of the meetings they will be attending in the workplace.

This section draws attention to the important role meetings play in the processes that shape organisational life. We begin this discussion by highlighting the value of attending and participating in meetings. We will then move on to examine the different types of meetings, the meeting process and the role of the chairperson in meetings.

6.6.1 Types of meetings

When working as a professional, one will encounter various types of meetings, which may involve different participants, diverse preparations, varied expectations and wide-ranging types of follow-through. It is therefore critical for any professional to be aware of the different purposes associated with each type of meeting. This section will help clarify the types of meetings that may be held by professionals.

According to the American Management Association (n.d.), seven types of meetings exist, in which a professional may routinely participate within an organisation. They include regular staff meetings, project team or group meetings, cross-departmental meetings, problem-solving meetings, information-sharing or update meetings, combination meetings and impromptu meetings. These meeting types are illustrated in the following figure.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from American Management Association, n.d.)Figure 6.6: Types of meetings

Regular staff meetings

Regular staff meetings are likely to be scheduled by a manager or supervisor, and usually take place with staff members at regular times in an ongoing programme of work. The primary focus of this type of meeting is usually to update participants on current issues, to address special problems or to kick-start an initiative.

Project team or group meetings

This type of meeting is relevant to special projects. These meetings have replaced the traditional committee meeting. The main aim of a project team or group meeting is to define a goal or objective, and reach agreement on methods, schedules, responsibilities, policies etc.

Cross-departmental meetings

When there are issues that affect multiple departments, cross-departmental meetings are held. These meetings are usually dedicated to clarifying the roles and responsibilities of each department. Cross-departmental meetings may also be scheduled to address problems that have arisen during the process of implementing a project, or to brainstorm better work strategies.

Problem-solving meetings

Problem-solving meetings serve the purpose of addressing issues that are causing problems within the organisation. The aim is to draw attention to such problems and call on sources of authority in order to arrive at a solution. These meetings are held at all levels of the organisation.

Information-sharing or update meetings

The main purpose of information-sharing meetings is to communicate information to members of an organisation. When important messages are shared, the chances of success on a project are higher, as every member of the team has an understanding of the goings-on relevant to it.

Combination meetings

These meetings pool together the important aspects of each of the types of meetings mentioned in this section. A staff meeting is an example of a combination meeting, because it involves problem-solving and information sharing among various staff members.

Impromptu meetings

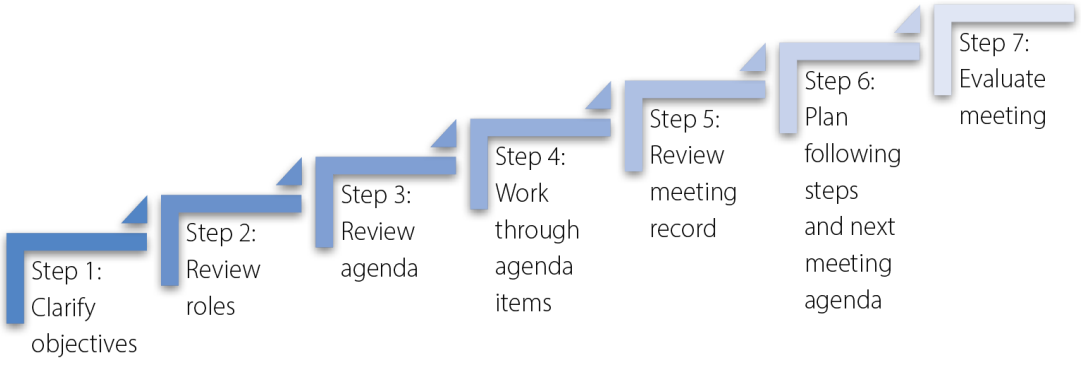
This type of meeting is characteristically ad hoc and usually of short duration (i.e. about 15 to 30 minutes). Due to the short duration of these meetings, the focus is generally on a single topic. The main idea is to share important information with several people simultaneously. Meetings of this nature could also be orientated toward feedback, where ideas are gathered from participants to help make a specific decision.

6.6.2 The meeting process

Having detailed the various types of meetings in the previous section, we now move on to the activities that constitute the actual meeting process. Well-organised meeting processes allow for important issues to be addressed economically, informatively and objectively (Hyer et al., 2003).

This section introduces the general principles that underpin the meeting process. To facilitate this understanding, we refer to the 'seven-step meeting process' model offered by Hyer et al. (2003). This model has become popular in professional circles, because it simplifies and standardises the method of conducting a meeting in the workplace. The seven-step meeting process model is useful on two levels: it firstly serves as a guide for any professional who has been tasked with the structuring of a meeting; secondly, it helps teams to review and evaluate their efficiency and productivity.

The following figure illustrates the seven-step meeting process model.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Hyer et al., 2003)Figure 6.7: The seven-step meeting process model

These steps are discussed in more detail in what follows (Hyer et al., 2003):

1. *Clarify objectives:* Ensure that all participants understand and are in agreement with the meeting's objectives.
2. *Review roles:* Discuss who will take on the respective roles of timekeeper, recorder, leader and facilitator. Also decide on the time at which feedback intervals will take place.
3. *Review the agenda:* Review the details of the agenda items (as listed under Step 4). Ensure that all team members understand and are in agreement with the agenda items.
4. *Work through the agenda items:* Each agenda item should be worked through, all procedures explained, and possible challenges identified.
5. *Review the meeting record:* Review the records of the meeting, which may have been circulated in hard or soft copy. Look for changes and additions that have been made during the meeting.
6. *Plan the following steps and the next meeting agenda:* Decide who will do what before the next meeting. Decide what the objectives and agenda items will be for the next meeting.

7. *Evaluate the meeting:* Raise questions regarding what the team did well during the meeting, to ensure the team continues doing these things during future meetings. Assess what the team could do differently to improve the meeting process.

6.6.3 Attending and participating in meetings

It is important to be familiar with certain rules of etiquette related to attending and participating in meetings. Meeting etiquette is defined as codes of behaviour that an individual should follow when attending workplace meetings (*Management Study Guide*, n.d.). Outlined in the remainder of this section are a few tips on etiquette that should be applied when attending and participating in a meeting (Giang, 2013; and *Management Study Guide*, n.d.).

Before going to a meeting, content and topics of discussion should be prepared to ensure the meeting has a clear agenda and flows smoothly. Being prepared helps one stay on track in the meeting. Failure to prepare may result in increased anxiety and mistakes.

It is essential that people are on time for a meeting. Being late is considered extremely rude, and the person holding the meeting may think the person who is late is wasting their time.

Once people are in the meeting, it is considered polite to introduce people who do not know each other. It is recommended that people be introduced according to their rank – i.e. those with the highest rank should be introduced first.

After everyone has been introduced to each other, people are likely to sit down around or at a table. It is suggested that one's chair should be adjusted to the height of everyone else's, in order to prevent an appearance of dominance or subordination (i.e. if a chair is adjusted too high or too low).

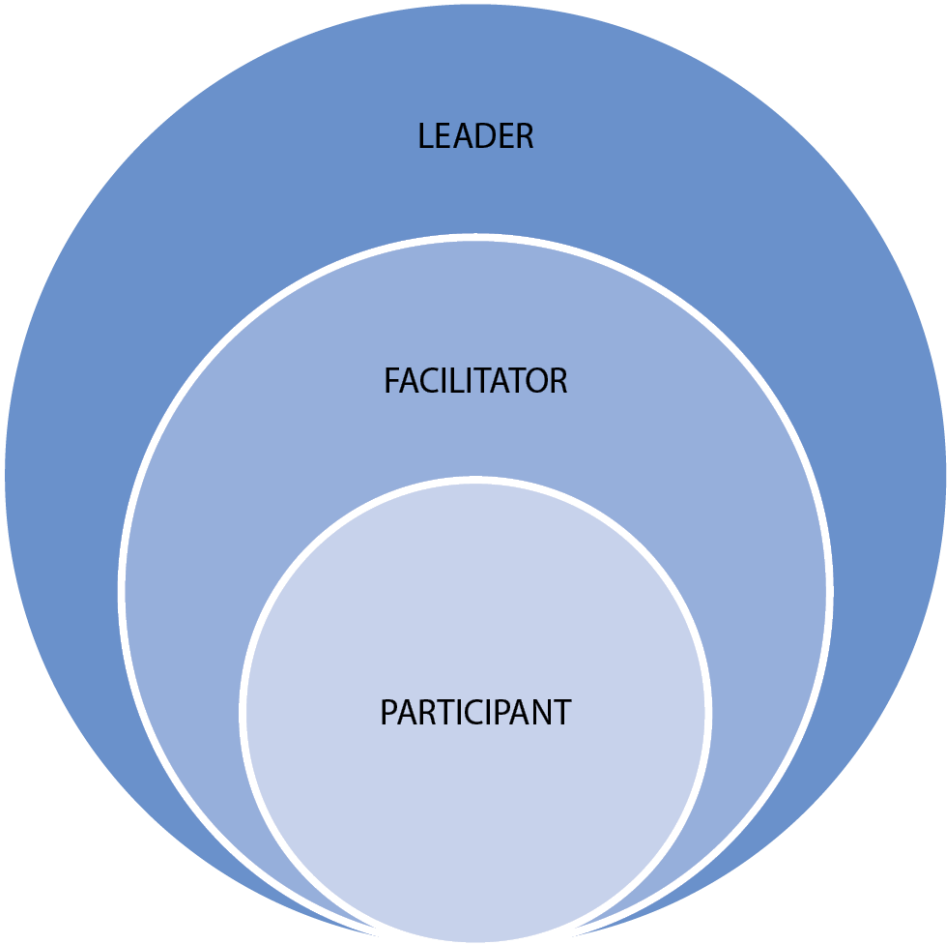
When speaking in a meeting, it is essential that one speaks clearly. Make sure words are clearly pronounced, to reduce the risk of misunderstanding and confusion. Speaking too loudly, however, may intimidate people; whereas speaking too softly can affect a person's perceived professionalism. It is therefore very important to speak at a level at which everyone in the meeting can comfortably hear what is being said. When other people in the meeting are speaking, do not interrupt them, as this is considered impolite.

With regard to cell phones, it is important that they are turned to silent or vibrate mode, to ensure they do not interrupt the meeting. Cell phones should also be put away in the meeting and not left on the table. If cell phones are left on the table, they can act as a form of distraction. It is considered extremely impolite to text while in a meeting; refrain from doing so at all costs. If an emergency phone call comes through, and it is absolutely necessary to take the call, one should excuse oneself from the meeting, and remove oneself from the venue before answering the call.

In a meeting, it is considered acceptable to drink water or a hot beverage such as tea or coffee; however, more often than not, eating is not permitted. Food can be distracting in many ways; for example, its smell, noisy packaging, the manner in which people eat etc. Eating also prevents a person from being able to speak during a meeting when they may be required to do so. If drinking from a mug or a glass in a meeting, make sure to clear it from the meeting venue when leaving.

6.6.4 Convening and chairing a meeting

The chairperson is the individual who convenes the meeting and ensures that participants follow meeting convention. The chairperson is the highest-ranking officer present at the gathering (*Skillmaker*, 2013). Erasmus-Kritzinger and Swart (2005) state that the chairperson has to play three simultaneous roles in order to achieve the specific goals set out for the meeting. These roles are that of *leader*, *facilitator* and *participant*, as illustrated in the following figure. This section is dedicated to exploring the multiple responsibilities and roles of a chairperson in a meeting.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Erasmus-Kritzinger and Swart, 2005)Figure 6.8: The simultaneous roles of a chairperson

Responsibilities of a chairperson

Since the chairperson has to simultaneously be the leader, facilitator and a participant of a meeting, they have various responsibilities they have to fulfil. These responsibilities are listed in what follows.

Setting the tone

The chairperson's first responsibility involves controlling the meeting; this starts with them setting the tone for the meeting process. Making reference to any pertinent ground rules can help set the meeting's tone. This task can be broken down into three parts:

1. State the meeting's objectives
2. Provide an information base for participants
3. Set up boundaries for the discussion

Encouraging participation

Encouraging participation is another important obligation of a chairperson. The following strategies can be used to encourage participation (Collins in Erasmus-Kritzinger and Swart, 2005):

- Be aware of others' as well as one's own control of a discussion; intervene if necessary.
- Avoid verbal or non-verbal disapproval of ideas.
- Ask open-ended questions to stimulate discussion.
- Frame problems in positive language.
- Draw out the introverts' perspectives in a non-threatening way.
- Remind participants of the meeting's objectives when they digress.
- Respect individual differences.

Drawing silent types into the discussion

There may be various types of silence in meetings. Silence relating to individuals who are quiet by nature (but do agree with the discussion) is not of serious concern. Individuals who are silent

because they are shy and lack confidence, however, need to be reassured that their perspectives are of value, and they should be encouraged to participate. One factor of serious concern is the silence that stems from antagonism (i.e. dislike) and hostility. In this case, the person(s) may seem to be detached due to a pre-existing conflict with another participant. The chairperson's duty is to get to the root of the problem, to ensure maximum participation.

Joining the discussion

There are two ways in which a chairperson can participate in a discussion, depending on the situation. As a general rule, the chairperson should maintain a neutral and facilitative role throughout, so as not to influence the group. However, if the chairperson has important information, they are obliged to share this with the group for the common good of the meeting.

Managing emotions

The main idea argued for here is that the chairperson should promote positive emotions as far as possible, but at the same time, they should not ignore negative emotions. In acknowledging negative emotions, the chairperson opens up avenues for trust.

Dealing with latecomers

The chairperson needs to be punctual in terms of starting and ending meetings. Every effort should be made to find out why certain people are habitual latecomers.

Managing conflict

When people have different views, it is natural for them to experience conflict. This should not be perceived in a negative way. The chairperson should not discourage conflict, as conflict can help improve the quality of decision-making. It can also stimulate creativity and promote objectivity. At the same time, we have to acknowledge that conflict is not always productive. It is a chairperson's skilful management that determines whether conflict will take a destructive or constructive path.

Dealing with tension

One popular way to deal with tension in meetings is to reframe a problem in a humorous way. Humour can serve as an interesting asset in many uncomfortable situations in meetings. A personal anecdote related to funny incidents at work seems to work better than jokes. The fact that such anecdotes are real, enhances their impact. While it is important to use humour in meetings, it should be used appropriately, and it is the chairperson's responsibility to discourage inappropriate jokes.

Ending the meeting

The chairperson has the responsibility to close the meeting, as soon as all the items on the agenda have been addressed. The chairperson needs to sum up progress regarding problems raised, or the meeting of objectives and accomplishments; they also need to highlight anything that remains to be done. If specific action is required by any individual, this should also be summarised. A tentative date for the next meeting should be presented, if not yet confirmed. The chairperson is obliged to set the tone for future meetings and develop a sense of control.

Evaluating the meeting

It is critical to assess the results of the meeting, after it has taken place. This involves an assessment of the meetings' objectives, its progress regarding problems, its accomplishments and any actions to be taken. It is important to evaluate the meeting, in order to improve the nature of future meetings.

It is common knowledge that, despite the amount of planning and preparation that goes into meetings, challenges arise. These challenges are rooted in trends that occur in today's business world, of which a chairperson should be aware. Chairpersons should take these trends into account when planning and conducting meetings. These trends can include the speed at which we work, the use of multiple sites, the change in organisational structures, high employee turnover, and the need for adaptability. A recognition and understanding of these challenges will promote successful meetings.

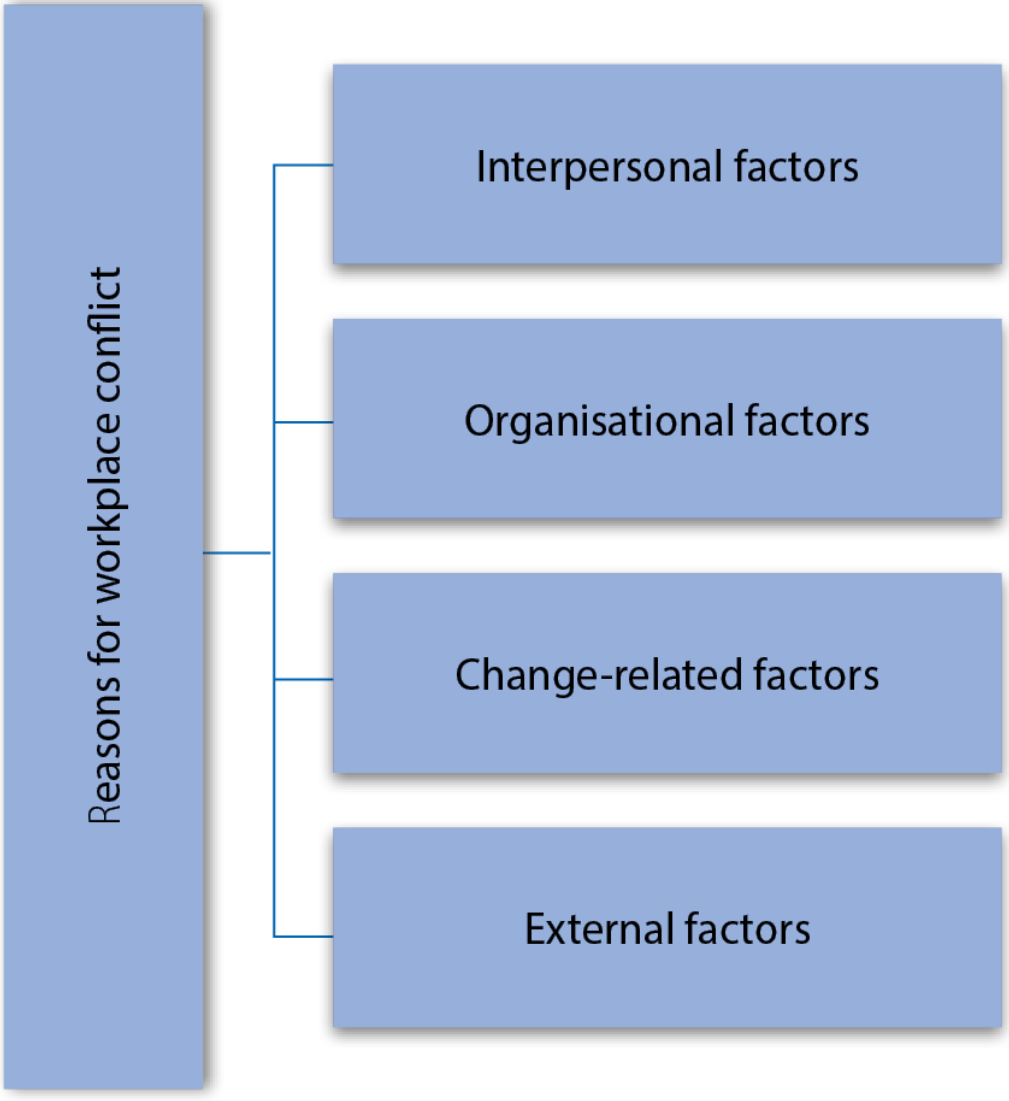
6.7 Managing conflict at work

Conflict occurs when workplace participants realise that they have clashing interests (Erasmus-Kritzinger and Swart, 2005). The existence of conflict has two main implications for the organisation. It can be beneficial, in that its presence shows that a healthy interchange of ideas exists in the organisation. On the other hand, conflict can be counterproductive if it harms employees' satisfaction levels, impairs productivity, or increases absenteeism, turnover or work-related stress. Consequently, even though conflict can be regarded as a natural part of organisational life, it needs to be carefully managed, as it can threaten the productivity and survival of the organisation.

Conflict in the workplace is the focus of this section. In this section, we will explore workplace conflict from three different perspectives. Firstly, we will look into the reasons for workplace conflict; secondly, we will analyse the dynamic of workplace bullying; and lastly, we will review suggested strategies for resolving conflict.

6.7.1 Reasons for conflict at work

In their attempts to effectively manage workplace conflict, theorists such as Donais (2006) argue that a useful starting point is to develop an understanding of the reasons for it. Following this advice, the reasons for workplace conflict are discussed in what follows, using a four-tiered framework that is adapted from the ideas of Donais (2006). This framework comprises interpersonal, organisational, change-related and external factors. It is depicted in the following figure.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Donais, 2006)Figure 6.9: Reasons for workplace conflict

Interpersonal factors

The multicultural work environment, which is comprised of people from multiple age groups, races, religions and genders, may be characterised by varying value systems, differing practices, traditions or beliefs. Intercultural differences in any of these areas could become a source of conflict. For

example, in the current multicultural work environment, it is possible that differing language or personality types may lead to interpersonal clashes.

Gender differences in the workplace could also be a strong source of conflict. However, this is dependent on the organisational practice regarding men and women. In the case of an organisation that welcomes gender diversity and encourages the inclusion of both sexes in key areas (e.g. when making company decisions and offering promotional opportunities), the possibility of conflict is minimised (Scott, n.d.). On the other hand, if an organisation discourages gender inclusion, the possibility of promoting bias in the workplace is increased.

Differences in outlooks between generations can also be a source of conflict. A diverse workplace would typically include employees of different generations – each group having differing views on how work should be done, an employee's role and company loyalty etc. For example, the Baby Boomer generation may show greater commitment to the company, but they may be less tech-savvy than Generation Y. Generation Y on the other hand, may show less commitment to the company, but be accustomed to working with diverse team members and demonstrate higher levels of flexibility than Baby Boomers. A high probability of clashes can therefore result from generational differences.

Educational differences can also account for conflict. There may be employees with strong academic credentials who work alongside employees who have vocational and on-the-job qualifications. Some employees may believe their university degrees have better equipped them to manage the processes demanded by the job than employees who have accumulated a wealth of practical knowledge through experience. These differences may be a strong source of conflict in some workplaces.

In the multiracial character of today's workplace, ethnicity and race are often sources of conflict. Conflicts arising from these sources can occur especially when ethnic and racial perceptions lead to inaccurate conclusions about people, causing offence to other parties. Verbal and non-verbal language differs greatly across cultures, increasing the possibility of miscommunication and misinterpretation of intended meanings. Cultural differences resulting in language barriers can also impact negatively on communication between workplace participants (Donais, 2006).

Organisational factors

The management of labour can be a key source of workplace conflict. Most organisations are structured hierarchically, which often results in power differences between members. Conflicting interests related to the management of labour are often compounded by these power differences.

The key areas of conflict with regard to organisational factors involve inequity (i.e. unfairness) in relation to various factors. For example, there could be varying styles of supervision between departments, with members of one department being treated uncompromisingly, while others are held less accountable. Further examples include inequity in terms of salary, the imbalanced provision of resources, the unjust sharing of duties, and imbalanced workloads and benefits etc.

Poor communication or a lack of communication are also sources of conflict: if important messages are not communicated effectively, miscommunication and confusion can occur; and if there is no communication, misunderstanding is inevitable.

Working conditions, such as inadequate physical and psychological conditions, may also lead to conflict. Examples include badly lit offices, inefficient equipment, long working hours, inadequate leave benefits etc. (Donais, 2006).

Change-related factors

There are various factors related to change that can be sources of conflict. For example, it is not uncommon in today's workplace for change management and downsizing to occur. Employees who are displaced or retrenched may clash with management.

Technological change can also cause conflict through changing work methodologies. For example, employees have to learn new techniques or master new software due to rapid changes in technology, and they might find these demands stressful (Donais, 2006).

External factors

External factors that cause economic pressures can also lead to conflict in the workplace. These factors may include a recession, changing markets, domestic and foreign competition and a high unemployment rate.

Conflict can also arise with clients and suppliers; for example, when pressure is put on customer services and the delivery of goods.

Changes in government structure or policies are additional external factors that have the potential to cause conflict in both profit and non-profit organisations (Donais, 2006).

Although conflict is acknowledged as an undeniable part of the business world, it is still an organisation's responsibility to manage anything that negatively affects its productivity and success. Conflict that persists for prolonged periods of time will invariably have a detrimental impact on operations and production.

6.7.2 Workplace bullying

Research has demonstrated that workplace abuse is extensive (Tehrani, 2003). Workplace abuse seems to exist in various forms; for example, threats, sexual harassment, verbal abuse, bullying, cyberbullying, back-stabbing and undermining others. Researchers who have studied this phenomenon argue that bullying in the workplace is largely influenced by certain factors that emerge from three broad sources. These sources include the perspectives of the individual, the group and the organisation, as illustrated in the following figure (Tehrani, 2003).



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Tehrani, 2003)Figure 6.10: Factors that influence workplace bullying

Bullying defined

While there are several different interpretations of workplace bullying, there is consensus among writers that there are common elements that underpin this concept. For example, Caponecchia and Wyatt (2011) have written extensively on this topic, explaining that typical bullying at work takes the form of repeated negative or unreasonable behaviour that jeopardises the health and safety of other members of an organisation. Tehrani (2003: 15) gives the following definition for bullying in the workplace:

Bullying at work involves repeated negative actions and practices that are directed at one or more workers. The behaviours are unwelcome to the target and undertaken in circumstances where the target has difficulty in defending him or herself. The behaviours may be carried out as a deliberate act or unconsciously. These behaviours cause humiliation, offence and distress to the target. The outcomes of the bullying behaviours have been shown to cause clinically significant distress and impairment in social, occupational, and other areas of functioning.

Tehrani (2003) states that workplace bullying has four common elements:

1. Behaviours that are negative
2. Repeated negative behaviours
3. The abuse of power
4. Threats to health and safety

Behaviours that are negative

Tehrani (2003) usefully highlights four main types of negative behaviours related to bullying:

1. *Personal derogation:* This occurs when one person humiliates, criticises, ridicules or undermines the integrity of another.
2. *Intimidation:* This occurs when one person threatens another with physical violence. One person can also intimidate another using psychological tactics. This happens mostly in situations where power is misused to get the victim to a point where they are helpless and defenceless. The target subsequently finds it difficult to take any form of action to protect themselves.
3. *Work-related bullying:* This occurs when a person intentionally withholds information from someone, strips them of their professional responsibilities, overloads them with work or even steals the credit for the work the target has done.
4. *Social exclusion:* This occurs when the wrongdoer cuts the victim off socially – isolating them completely – scapegoats them or creates a situation where the victim is marginalised or disregarded by other employees.

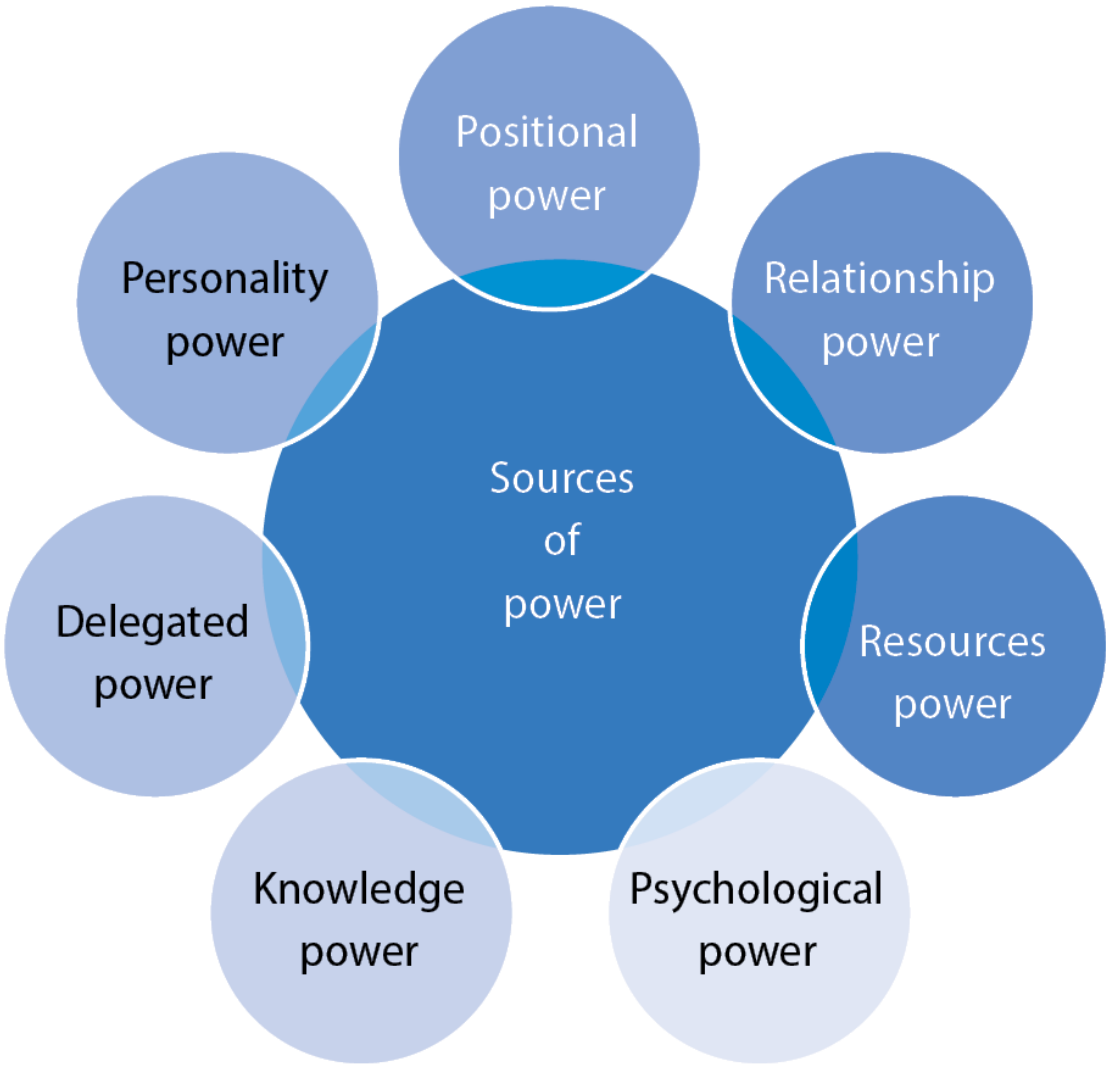
Repeated behaviour

It is argued that behaviour can only be categorised as bullying if it involves repeated or persistent negative actions (Tehrani, 2003). As a consequence, the target is made to feel permanently fearful and anxious. While these ideas relate to obvious forms of bullying, we should also be aware of actions such as intimidation, harassment and victimisation, which may go unnoticed due to their subtlety.

Imbalance of power

There is a strong argument to be made that imbalances of power in the workplace make bullying possible, and could perhaps even be its cause (Tehrani, 2003). The following is a summary of the key sources of power in the workplace, and how these sources can be used to bully others (Tehrani, 2003):

- *Positional power:* This type of power comes into play when a person abuses the power their position grants them to impose unfair restrictions or rules on people.
- *Relationship power:* This type of power becomes particularly evident when groups are set up to violate the rights of workers outside the group.
- *Resources power:* This type of power occurs when people in power make it difficult for the group to achieve objectives, by removing scarce resources.
- *Psychological power:* This type of power exists when certain people have knowledge of sensitive issues relating to a target, and consequently exploit this knowledge. This is detrimental, because it exposes the psychological vulnerabilities of the target.
- *Knowledge power:* This power comes into existence when a person in power withholds important information from the target.
- *Delegated power:* This type of power is evident when the person in power persuades another individual to undermine and/or threaten a target.
- *Personality power:* This power is manifested when the person who is in power does not allow others to challenge them or question their behaviour. They use their personality-driven behaviour to bully and intimidate others.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Tehrani, 2003)Figure 6.11: Sources of power in the workplace

Threats to health and safety

When determining whether there are any threats to health and safety in a workplace, it is necessary to first establish whether bullying has already occurred. Tehrani (2003) advises the use of two principles to determine whether bullying has actually taken place: the first principle involves examining whether the action is normal in terms of acceptable standards of behaviour, and the second principle is to examine whether the behaviour was actually disadvantageous to the target.

If bullying has taken place, it then needs to be determined whether or not such bullying was intentional. Tehrani (2003) suggests the following three categories to assist the examination of bullying 'intent':

1. *Wilful intent:* This occurs when the behaviour is directed at the target with the intention of causing actual occupational, physical or psychological harm.
2. *Instrumental intent:* This occurs when the negative behaviour is an unintended side effect of a behaviour that is directed at achieving another goal.
3. *Unintentional intent:* This occurs when the offender has a lack of sensitivity or awareness of the negative impact of their behaviour.

Example 6 A Workplace bullying

In 2014, a major technology company in the United States paid an ex-employee two million dollars after losing a workplace bullying case. The employee was a salesman with a clean work record and an upstanding reputation in the company; however, he started being bullied by co-workers and supervisors, after he ended a relationship with a woman who later became his boss. The employee's

work started to be repeatedly undermined; he was also marginalised and even blocked from receiving promotions. Consequently, the employee complained to the human resources department about this behaviour.
Instead of taking the employee's complaints seriously and dealing with the people inflicting these actions on him, the company got a female employee to file a false sexual harassment complaint against him. The company allowed the negative behaviours against him to continue, and he eventually even faced sexist and racist remarks from the executives in the company.
After multiple complaints about his treatment within the company, the employee decided to take legal action against it. The outcome of the legal process was a verdict that the tech company was guilty of corporate bullying. The judge instructed the company to pay the ex-employee two million dollars for the legal fees he had incurred, as well as the emotional and psychological distress they had caused him as a result of such bullying (Craig, 2014; and McGrath, 2016).
The four common elements of workplace bullying are present in this example, as illustrated in what follows:

1. The behaviours toward the employee were, without a doubt, extremely negative; they could therefore be defined as 'bullying behaviour'.
2. The bullying behaviour was repeated on numerous occasions.
3. The bullying involved the abuse of power. We can see this in the way that it started when the employees' ex-girlfriend became his boss, and his superiors and company executives were involved in the bullying.
4. The bullying threatened the employees emotional and psychological health and well-being.

A way forward

It is argued that, in order to eliminate workplace bullying, serious attention must be given to several issues. Some of these include the setting of standards of acceptable and unacceptable behaviour, identifying and dealing with errors and mistakes, engaging more flexible work roles, and giving focus to priorities etc. The following are general guidelines for resolving workplace bullying (Tehrani, 2003):

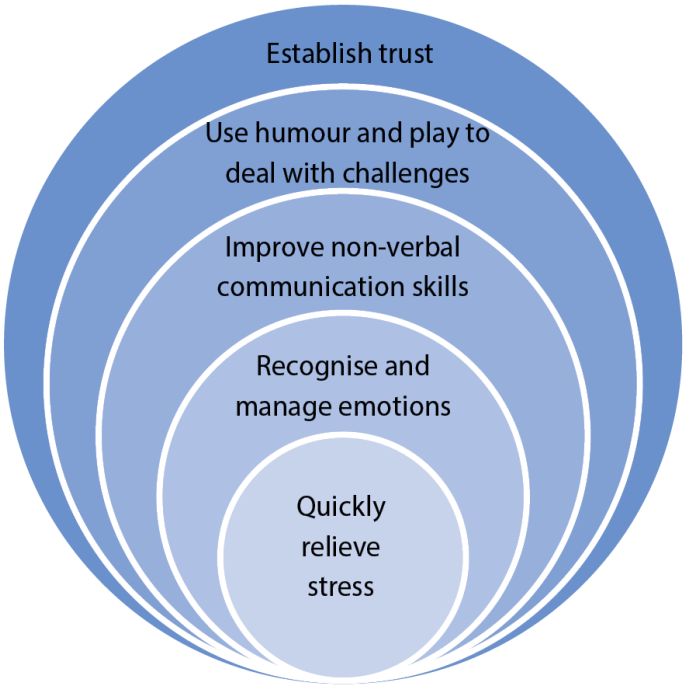
- *Refer to workplace policies and procedures:* Workplace policies should provide guidelines on acceptable standards of behaviour and how to report abuse.
- *Speak to the other person:* In a calm manner, an individual can speak to the person bullying them about their behaviour. It is possible that this person may be unaware they are offending the individual. The individual could also suggest alternative behaviour that is less offensive.
- *Seek advice:* If an individual is unsure about what to do, they should seek advice from an independent person who has knowledge of the options available for dealing with workplace bullying.
- *Report the matter:* Always report workplace bullying – whether verbally or in writing. Inform a supervisor or manager. An individual could also ask their union representative to make a report on their behalf, or they could use other established reporting procedures.

6.7.3 Resolving workplace conflict

The mismanagement of conflict can be harmful to professional relationships. This makes it vital for any professional entering the workplace to learn how to manage conflict in a healthy way. In this section, we focus on how a professional who acquires the skills to resolve conflict, can successfully strengthen and grow their personal and professional relationships.

Recognising and resolving conflicting needs

It is believed that workplace conflicts revolve around individuals' differing values, interests and personalities, among other factors (The University of Oklahoma Human Resources, 2017). It follows that successfully resolving conflict depends on how respectful individuals are of different views, how they control their emotions and behaviour, and how much sensitivity they show toward others' feelings.
This section therefore focuses on key conflict-resolution skills.
Skills to recognise and resolve conflict
Segal and Smith (2017) advise the use of a particular set of skills to recognise and resolve conflict. They organise these skills using a five-part framework, represented by the following figure.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Segal and Smith, 2017)Figure 6.12: Conflict-resolution skills

The first four parts are comprised of the following steps:

1. Quickly relieve stress
2. Recognise and manage emotions
3. Improve non-verbal communication skills
4. Use humour and play to deal with challenges

The sum of these four parts creates the fifth skill, which relates to being able to resolve differences in a way that can establish trust. Each of these steps are discussed in more detail in what follows.

1. Quickly relieve stress

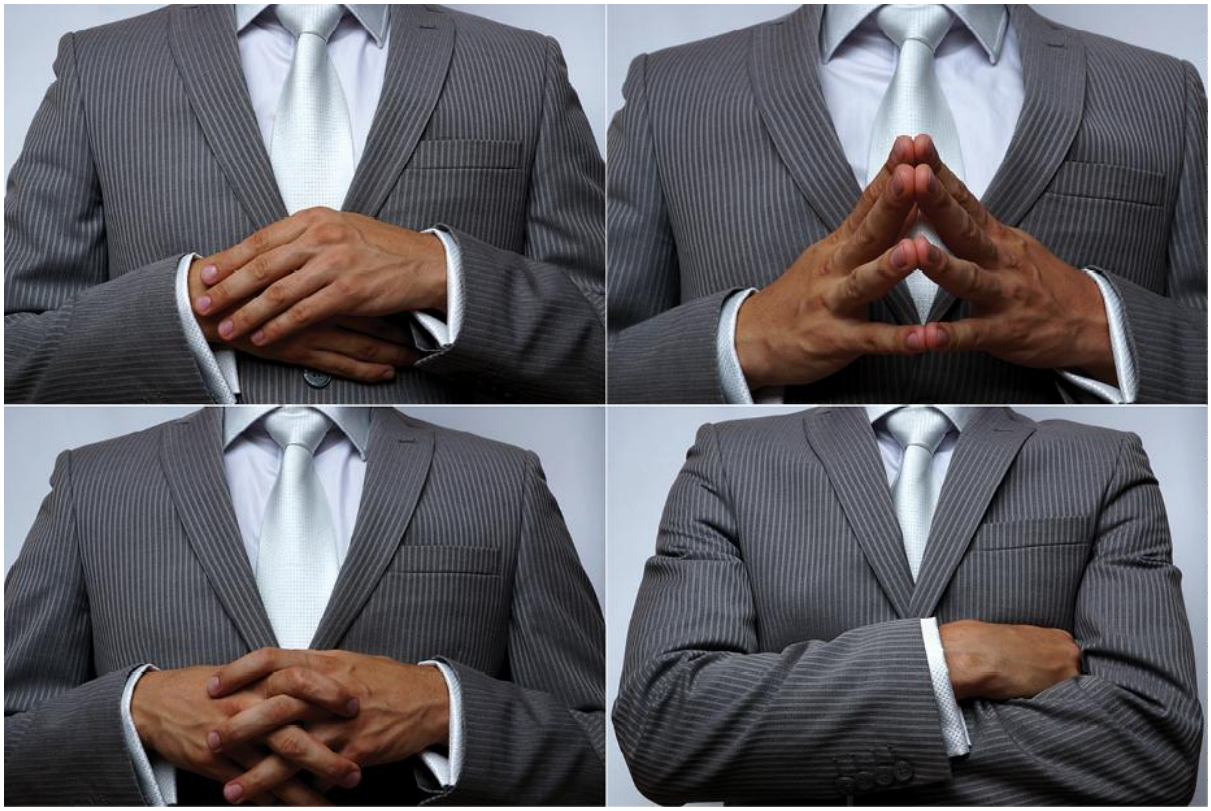
The capacity to remain calm in tense situations is vital to resolving conflict. If a person can stay in control of their stress levels during a stressful situation, their risk of becoming overwhelmed by conflict is reduced. One way to help relieve stress is to engage in activities that aid relaxation; for example, doing yoga.

2. Recognise and manage emotions

Being emotionally aware will help a person understand themselves and others. If someone can recognise and manage their own emotions, the chances of them becoming more sensitive to others' emotions is increased. In turn, this will help them recognise and resolve conflict situations.

3. Improve non-verbal communication skills

It is believed that conflict is more often communicated in non-verbal forms than verbal forms; for example, through body language, such as eye contact, facial expressions, tone of voice, posture, touch, gestures etc. In order to recognise conflict situations, careful attention must therefore be paid to others' non-verbal signals, as it will help determine the meaning that the other person is trying to convey. In attempts to resolve conflict, a person should respond to others using reassuring non-verbal language; for example, a calm tone of voice or a comforting touch. The following image shows examples of a person who is listening to another, and perhaps trying to avoid conflict in the top two pictures. The bottom two, however, suggest that the individual might be becoming impatient and may be open to initiating conflict.



(Source: Shutterstock.com)Figure 6.13: Non-verbal body language

4. Use humour and play to deal with challenges

Humour and playful behaviour can help to lower tension and put the situation into perspective. If done appropriately, humour and playful behaviour can help to reduce conflict situations and solve those currently at hand. It is important to note, however, that inappropriate humour can lead to an increase in conflict.

5. Establish trust

The sum of the four previous steps is the skill of being able to resolve differences through the ability to establish trust. Establishing trust can help to recognise conflict – if those involved trust each other, they will be more inclined to confide in each other about any existing issues. Trust is also an important contributor to avoiding future conflict situations. Concurrently, a lack of trust breeds an increase in conflict. The ability to establish trust is therefore important when attempting to recognise and resolve conflict.

Conflict resolution strategies

Bergh and Theron (2003) list several conflict resolution strategies. They are applicable to different situations of conflict and are outlined in what follows.

Competition

This strategy involves putting people up against one another. The use of competition is not normally successful, as one party tends to win at the expense of another, which can result in further conflict. For example, imagine that two employees, who are arguing about which solution will be most suitable when solving a particular issue within a company, are called into a meeting with a manager. Instead of attempting to find common ground from which to work, the manager asks the employees to prepare a pitch of their ideas to present to a panel of judges. The panel of judges will then decide whose ideas are most appropriate. As you can see, the manager has put the employees in competition with one another, in an attempt to resolve the conflict. However, this scenario will likely end in a 'winner' and a 'loser', which can potentially lead to further issues.

Collaboration

This strategy involves both parties cooperating with one another to handle the conflict, resulting in a solution that ensures that both parties 'win'. Drawing on the previous example, a manager using a collaborative conflict resolution strategy would ask the two employees to go and brainstorm how their ideas could be combined; they could also be asked to work in conjunction with one another to solve the issue at hand. In this way, the manager is encouraging the employees to collaborate with one another to find a solution that satisfies them both.

Avoidance

This strategy involves ignoring and avoiding the conflict at hand. Although this strategy may be somewhat successful in the short term, it becomes problematic in the long term, as conflicts do not simply 'disappear'. For example, if the manager chooses to ignore the conflict between the two employees, it may not be too problematic at first; however, as time goes by, the employees may become increasingly frustrated with each other, resulting in an escalation of conflict.

Accommodation

This strategy relates to the practice of one party placing another's interests above their own. This strategy is most likely to be successful when the relationship between the two parties is recognised as paramount. For example, if the employees with varying ideas are best friends, and come to the realisation that their friendship is more important than putting their ideas forward in this situation, one of the friends may step down and allow the other employee's ideas to be used.

Compromising

In this conflict-resolution strategy, both parties 'win', because they both sacrifice in order to achieve conflict resolution. For example, the manager may notice that both ideas could be used if a certain element is removed from each of the employees' strategies. The employees could then agree to this compromise and as a result, have their conflict resolved.

Guidelines for resolving conflict

Resolving conflict can be complicated, frustrating and at times, quite scary. The following conflict-resolution guidelines may help to make the process as positive as possible (Berman, n.d.; and *The University of Oklahoma Human Resources*, 2017):

- *Meet with the people involved in the conflict scenario:* Ask the individuals involved when it would be convenient for them to meet in a place where they will not be interrupted. Set up a meeting and stick to the time and date set. Inform the participants that the purpose of the meeting is to attempt to resolve the conflict that has arisen.
- *Stay calm in the meeting:* It is very important that people 'keep their cool' in a conflict-resolution scenario. The escalation of negative emotions during a meeting concerning a conflict is likely to result in further conflict.
- *Focus on events and behaviour instead of people:* Comments should be depersonalised and should focus on the issue at hand. Use phrases such as 'When this happens…' as opposed to 'When you do…' If a person feels as if they are being personally attacked, they will probably become defensive and retract themselves from the conflict-resolution meeting. This will result a diminished chance that the conflict will be resolved. It is therefore important to focus on the event or behaviours in question, rather than the people involved in the conflict.
- *Avoid blaming people:* Assigning blame to others is not constructive when attempting to resolve a conflict. If the goal is to fix the problem at hand, finding out who has created the problem and blaming them will not necessarily make the conflict dissipate; in fact, it will likely exacerbate the scenario.
- *Listen carefully to what people are saying:* Instead of getting ready to react to what people are saying, rather focus on what they are expressing. It is important not to interrupt people while they are talking. Instead, ask questions about what they have said, and even rephrase things and repeat them back to the speakers, to ensure everyone understands what has been said.
- *Identify different points of agreement and disagreement:* The areas of agreement and disagreement should be summarised in the meeting. The agreements should be celebrated to emphasise the positive points and to move toward neutralising the situation. On the other hand, disagreements should be worked on until they are at a point of resolution.

Additional guidelines include focusing on the future instead of the past, and finding ways in which the people involved can learn from the experience instead of seeing the conflict as a burden. Beyond this, encourage the participants to build on the successes of the conflict-resolution: it should be viewed as an opportunity for growth and future improvement.

FAST FORWARD: Teams of the future

In years gone by, interpersonal skills were a cornerstone of success in the working environment. While interpersonal skills are still important, they were applied mainly on a face-to-face basis in the past. A knowledge of etiquette via email or Skype was not a part of the required skill set of a successful professional as it is today. The scope of interpersonal skills has therefore increased.

More frequently, it is becoming the case that teams do not necessarily have face-to-face contact at all anymore – neither with team members, management nor even clients. Research suggests that in

future, more organisations will be following this trend. In fact, Shin (2016) states that by 2020, it is believed that 50 per cent of employees in America could be working for a virtual organisation.
10up is an example of such an organisation. Its members are entirely virtually-based, and the company owns absolutely no physical office space. Its employees work as freelancers and are scattered all over the world. The company specialises in assisting companies or individuals in managing their websites. It provides services such as the setting up of a website, managing traffic onto the site, and managing adverts for the company on Google and through Google searches. Mainly, the company's focus is on enhancing the organisational strategy of its clients and increasing their sales via the use of a cutting-edge and user-friendly websites (*10up*, n.d.).
According to Shin (2016), the establishment of virtual organisations is increasing at a rapid rate. Companies are choosing to make use of virtual organisations to outsource whole departments, such as HR, IT or training departments. 10up is an example of a virtual organisation that a company might use to completely outsource its IT function.
Employees working for virtual organisation's such as 10up report that employees actually can be more productive than when they work in a traditional office environment, as they are likely to experience fewer distractions when working from home (Shin, 2016). Virtual organisations also have easy access to talented staff all over the world. From the perspective of an employee, working remotely allows for greater work-life balance, and employees often show higher levels of engagement and commitment to their employer.
As a result of this, an entirely different set of interpersonal skills will be required in future. Employees or teams will have to learn to work well together without seeing each other face-to-face, while still including all team members from different parts of the world in decision-making on projects. Employees will also need to learn how to bond as a team, even though they may never actually meet in person. Etiquette via Skype, email or any other form of social media, will also need to be observed, as this will become a crucial skill set for anyone working in a virtual organisation.

6.8 Summary

In this unit, you learned about interpersonal skills at work. You were introduced to the stages of team formation, the various factors that influence team dynamics and the qualities that are required to be a team player. The unit also taught you how to lead and motivate others at work, the etiquette required when attending and participating in meetings, different types of meetings, the meeting process and the chairing and convening of meetings. Lastly, this unit explored the reasons for conflict at work, how to resolve such conflict, and workplace bullying.
Overall, this unit has pointed out that possessing strong interpersonal skills is a strong predictor for professional success. When a professional enters an organisation, it is critical to gain the interpersonal skills demanded by the workplace. If individuals in the workplace are prepared to empower themselves with robust interpersonal skills, and to consistently evaluate their conflicting needs with compassion and understanding, pathways will be opened to better quality relationships, as well as an enhancement of trust.

Chapter 7

7.1 Introduction

Chantel sends a text message to her friend, Lindiwe, and gets a very cold, unfriendly response back from her – or so Chantel thinks. Immediately, she wonders what she may have said that was offensive in her message, or whether everything is alright with Lindiwe. However, instead of asking to see Lindiwe in person, she continues the conversation via text, and before she knows it, both her and Lindiwe are offended and have had a falling-out. When they get the opportunity to meet, it turns out that Chantel had misunderstood Lindiwe's initial response, and had not interpreted the tone of her message correctly. Without seeing her facial expressions or actually physically speaking to her, it was difficult to interpret the message correctly.
Whether you have plenty of work experience or have yet to begin your first real job, you should be familiar with the process of communication and how it works. You should also be familiar with just how important it is, and how easily misunderstandings can occur. Simple things that are said in

person, or even via non-verbal communication such as email or text message, can often be misconstrued or taken in the wrong way. This can very easily lead to conflict, which could have been otherwise avoided. By being conscious of the communication process and exactly how to communicate effectively, you will be well prepared for the working world.

This unit addresses the basic concepts of communication at work, as well as how communication can be used effectively in the workplace. More specifically, the unit explores the communication *process* – i.e. all the elements that are involved in transmitting a message from one person to another. After exploring topics such as active listening skills, organisational structures and communication lines, as well as channels of workplace communication (i.e. formal and informal channels), you will be well equipped to communicate with others in the workplace effectively.

After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- list and discuss elements in the communication process;
- discuss barriers to effective communication, and apply this knowledge to a hypothetical scenario;
- distinguish between formal and informal channels of communication, and apply this knowledge to a hypothetical scenario;
- distinguish between flat and hierarchical organisational communication lines; and
- describe how effective verbal, written and non-verbal communication with others can influence our working relationships.

7.2 Key terms and definitions

The following key terms and definitions are applicable to this unit:

- *Communication barrier:* A communication barrier is anything that makes communication more difficult, such as physical noise, an individual's perceptions or language barriers.
- *Decoding:* Decoding occurs when the person who has received the message from the sender (i.e. the receiver) tries to interpret and make sense of the message they have received.
- *Encoding:* Encoding occurs when an individual wishing to send a message (i.e. the sender) formulates the message they wish to convey to another person.
- *External communication:* This refers to communication with parties outside of the organisation, such as suppliers, investors, customers and other stakeholders.
- *Flat structure communication lines:* A flat organisational structure includes fewer levels of managers and, therefore, promotes simpler, more straightforward communication, and allows for simpler, more democratic decision-making.
- *Formal communication:* This is communication that is controlled directly by the employer, such as the company intranet, company emails or business meetings. The tone of this communication tends to be more professional.
- *Hierarchical structure communication lines:* A very hierarchical structure is one that has many levels of management, therefore making communication and decision-making a more complex process.
- *Informal communication:* This is communication that is not controlled by the employer, and may include things like gossip or employees merely meeting and chatting as friends.
- *Internal communication:* This is communication that takes place exclusively between employees and those inside the organisation.
- *Non-verbal communication:* This is communication that is unspoken and subtle; however, it can often say more than verbal communication can.
- *Verbal communication:* This is direct communication that is usually face-to-face – i.e. it is said and heard.

7.3 The communication process

All of us communicate throughout our lives, and do so on a daily basis. Research suggests that even babies in the womb are involved in the communication process; scientists maintain that from 30 weeks of pregnancy, an unborn baby has the ability to hear, and can differentiate between sounds that form part of the language they are exposed to (McElroy, 2013).

We communicate in different environments and in different roles. At home, you may communicate with your family as a mother, father, sister, brother, child, aunt, uncle and so forth. In a social setting, you communicate as a friend or peer. In a professional setting (which we will focus on in this unit), you may communicate as a colleague, subordinate or superior. There is also a distinction between formal and informal communication channels, which we should use depending on what is

appropriate to the situation. The organisational structure in which we operate also influences how we communicate at work.

Organisations cannot function without effective communication. This communication can occur at two levels, namely *internal* or *external*:

1. *Internal communication:* This type of communication takes place between 'management and staff at various levels of the organisation for the purpose of reaching organisational goals' (Van Staden et al., 2007: 13). In this context, communication occurs in order to inform employees of what is expected of them, share the information required in order for them to conduct their tasks, and provide feedback on how they are doing. Additionally, employees need to communicate with one another, in order to cooperate with one another, and to ensure that their work is coordinated.
2. *External communication:* This type of communication takes place with people or stakeholders who do not work for the company, such as suppliers, maintenance technicians or customers.

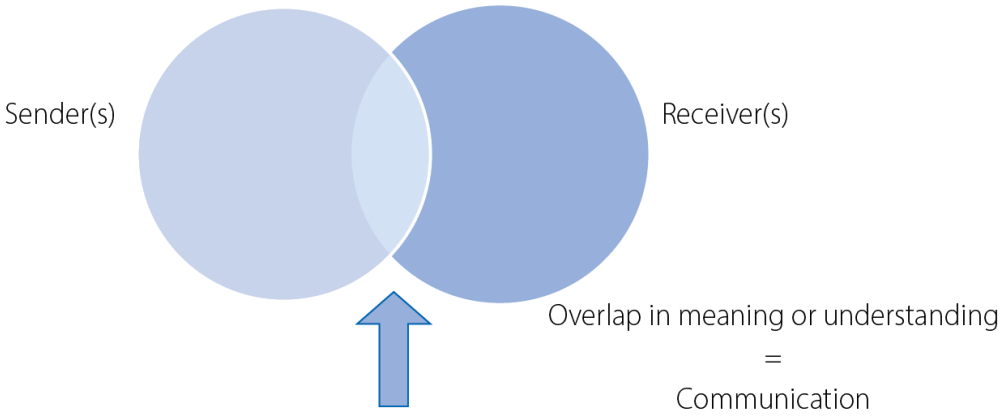
Effective communication in the workplace enables everyone to do their jobs, as they have the necessary information and can express themselves well enough to keep others informed. Effective communication saves time, money and effort, and prevents miscommunication and misunderstandings from occurring.

To become effective communicators, we first need to understand the communication process and the elements involved. These elements include the *environment*, the *context*, the *sender*, the *message*, the *medium* or *channel*, the *receiver*, the *feedback*, and the *processes of encoding and decoding*. If we are aware of how each element contributes to productive communication, we can structure and deliver our messages to create mutual understanding, and therefore have the desired impact. This process begins when the sender encodes or develops a message, which then goes through a particular channel – whether this be face-to-face, via email or messenger, or any form of non-verbal communication. The receiver then gets the message and decodes it (i.e. makes sense of the message), and then responds and provides feedback to the sender.

This entire process is influenced by context and the environment in which the communication occurs. In addition to these, we need to be conscious of the factors that prevent or hinder the communication (e.g. barriers or noise), so that we can avoid them or take corrective measures. As communicators, we not only construct and send messages, but we also receive them. This means that we also need to become proficient listeners and/or readers.

This is the basic process of communication, and will be discussed in further detail in a later section.

The term 'communication' originates from the Latin word *communis*, which means 'common' (Shimp and Andrews, 2013: 150). From this perspective, communication can be regarded as the process of creating common understanding between the people or parties involved. These parties are referred to as the *senders* and *receivers*. Because people are different and unique, they will rarely have exactly the same understanding of a message; however, there will be an overlap, which is the area of communication, as shown in the following figure. Therefore, in order to be effective communicators, we need to create as much overlap as possible.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019)Figure 7.1: Communication resulting from an overlap in meaning

Employees are expected to both transmit and receive information effectively, in order to perform their jobs. *Communication competence* refers to the ability to send messages that are well constructed, as well as use the most appropriate medium of communication and interpret messages correctly (McShane and Von Glinow, 2003: 322). As such, communication competence is essential at all levels of an organisation.

Research by Klemmer and Snyder (1972) has shown that people spend 50 to 80 per cent of their work day communicating. The authors argue that the majority of this communication takes the form of talking. These figures are noteworthy, as they indicate that we spend more than half our time at work communicating, which in turn highlights the importance of communication competence.

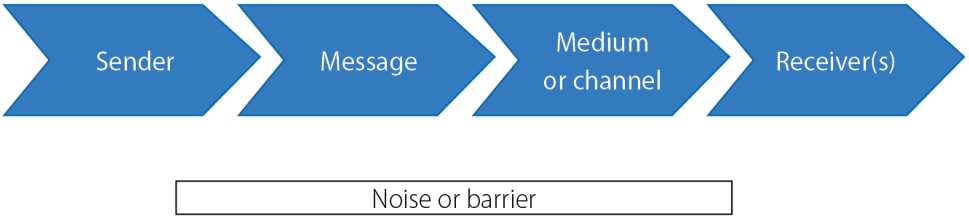
However, communication is a *process*, which means that it contains a series of steps that lead to the achievement of a particular goal. Various theoretical models of the communication process have been proposed; there is no single model that applies to all communication, as it is a complex process, and depends on the situation at hand, the parties involved and the channels used. The following models will, however, be discussed in this unit:

- Linear model
- Interactive model
- Convergence model
- Many-to-many communication model

Linear model

The linear model represents communication as a line that extends from the sender, who starts the process, to the receiver, who is at the end of the process. This communication is *unidirectional* – i.e. it moves in a single, one-way direction (Fielding, 2003: 13).

This communicative process is typical of an advertising message that a company would send to customers; for example, in the form of an SMS. In this case, the advertising company would be the *sender*, the content of the SMS would be the message, the cell phone or mobile device used would be the *medium* or *channel*, and the *receivers* would consist of potential customers who read this message.

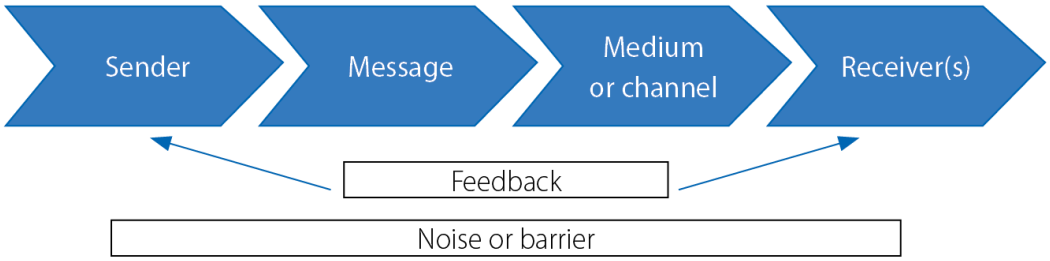


(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Fielding, 2003: 13)Figure 7.2: Linear communication model

Interactive model

The interactive model is an extension of the linear model, as it includes a response from the receiver. It is therefore a *bidirectional* communication process – i.e. it moves in both directions. This type of

communication is typical of face-to-face conversations, email correspondence and phone calls (*The Communication Process*, 2013).

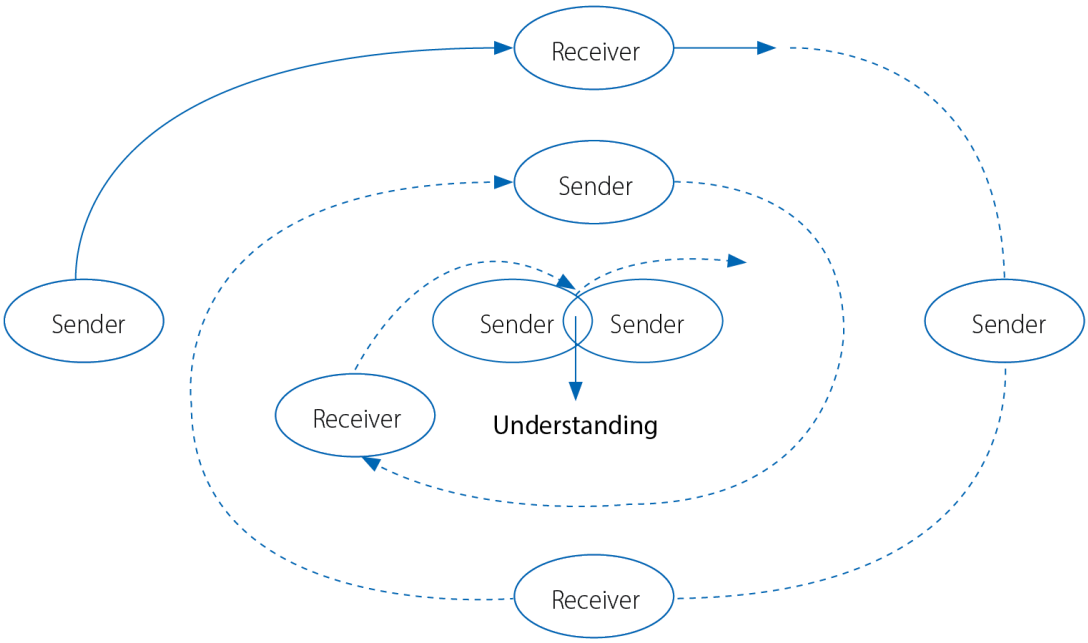


(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from The Communication Process Z, 2013)Figure 7.3: Interactive communication model

Convergence model

The term 'convergence' implies coming together from different directions, until there is a meeting point. (*Oxford Dictionaries* 1, n.d.). This model illustrates how the communication will continue to go back and forth between the sender and receiver, until there is common understanding or an overlap in meaning (Fielding, 2003: 19).

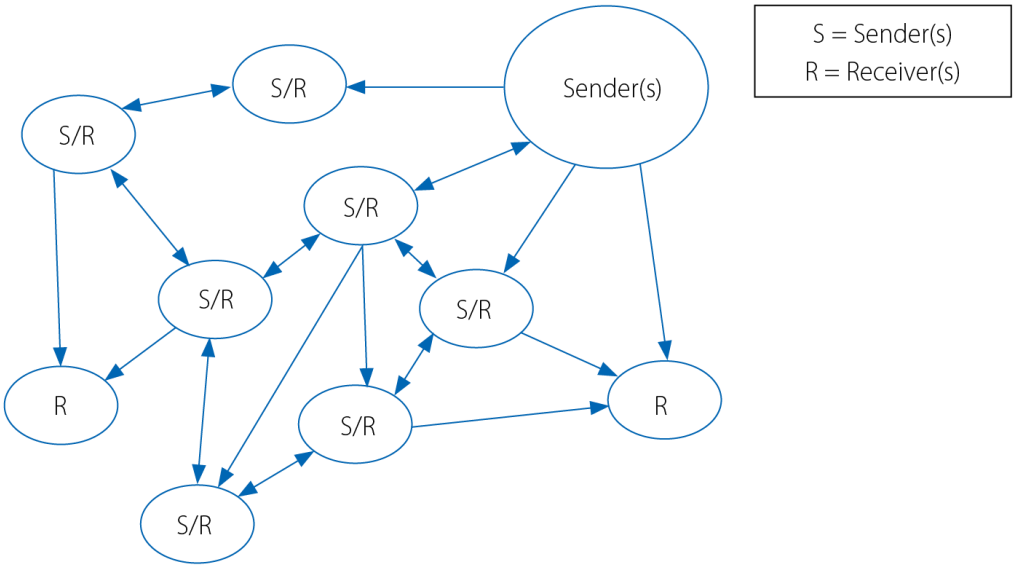
Let's consider a practical example of convergent communication. Imagine that you ask a courier to deliver a package to a specific address, and you provide them with directions for getting there. You could ask the driver to repeat the directions back to you, in order to ensure that they are correct. If there were errors or misunderstandings along the way, you would repeat the instructions and get the driver to explain the route again. This would continue until the message has been understood correctly. In other words, there would be a convergence or 'coming together' of understanding.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Fielding, 2003: 19)Figure 7.4: Convergence communication model

Many-to-many communication model

Technological developments such as the Internet and social media (e.g. Facebook, Twitter, YouTube, Pinterest, LinkedIn etc.) have contributed to the increase in communication that occurs between numerous senders and receivers worldwide. Within this context, communication is neither unidirectional nor bidirectional; rather, it is *multidirectional*, as it involves multiple senders, receivers, and others who may also relay the message and provide feedback. As illustrated in the following figure, this communication pattern resembles a spider's web (Chaffey and Smith, 2013: 122). As can be seen, a receiver may get the message from one or more senders. They may then choose to share the information, thereby becoming a sender. However, if they choose not to share the information, they are simply a receiver.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Chaffey and Smith, 2013: 122)Figure 7.5: Many-to-many communication model

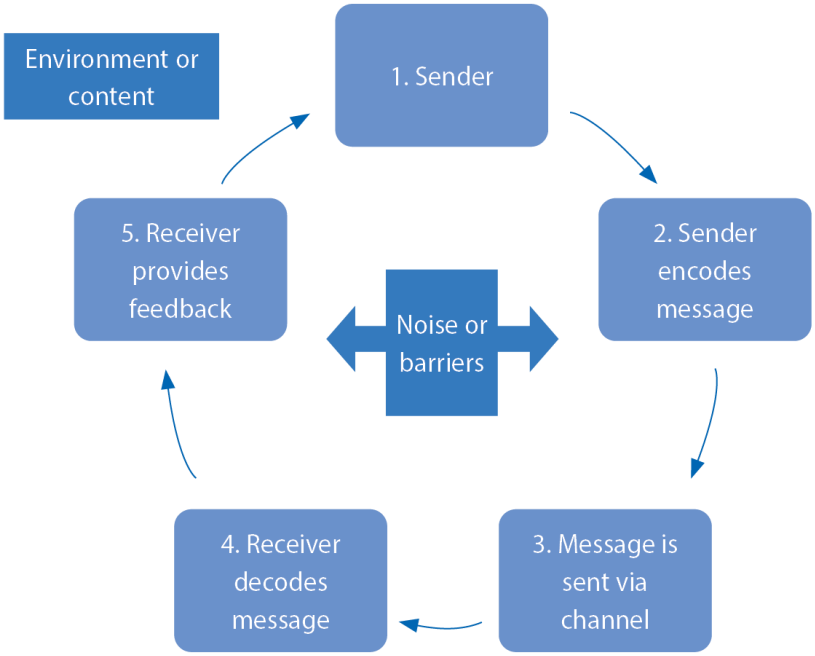
For example, consider a company like Nando's, which often places humorous advertisements in the media. It's marketing messages often go viral, meaning that the message is circulated widely on the Internet and via social media. Consequently, there will be many senders and receivers involved in this communication process.

Regardless of which model is used to depict the communication process, each one contains the same key elements. We will now examine these elements in more detail.

7.3.1 Elements of the communication process

The communication process includes the following key elements:

- Environment
- Context
- Sender
- Encoding
- Message
- Medium or channel
- Receiver
- Decoding
- Noise or barriers
- Feedback or response



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Cleary, 2014: 2)Figure 7.6: Elements of the communication process

The environment

The Annenberg School for Communication (n.d.) highlights that our environment contains various aspects that interact with each other and, consequently, impact the process of communication. These aspects include the:

- physical environment;
- sociocultural environment;
- organisational or corporate culture;
- psychological environment;
- economic environment; and
- technological environment.

Physical environment

This can refer to elements such as the organisation's building, office space, furniture, lighting, background noise levels, air quality and more. An open-plan office with desks positioned close to one another makes contact and communication easier; however, this area may also have a high level of noise and disruption. Similarly, a physical aspect like lighting can create glare on a computer screen (if it is too bright), or may affect one's ability to read documents (if it is too dark). Many organisations use the physical environment to encourage communication between employees; for example, by providing spaces that bring people together, such as canteens or lounges.

Sociocultural environment

Organisations typically employ people from various cultures, each with their own set of beliefs, customs, practices and behaviours. These elements make up the sociocultural environment. When it comes to communication, it is vital to be respectful toward other cultural groups. Therefore, many companies offer diversity training, to encourage people to communicate in a culturally appropriate and sensitive way.

Organisational or corporate culture

Each organisation has its own unique set of values and beliefs that guide the behaviours of employees, which is known as *organisational culture* or *corporate culture*. This, in turn, influences the *organisational structure* (discussed later in this unit). For instance, the organisation may value a strict hierarchy (ranking), which makes it difficult for employees to communicate with superiors. This illustrates how the organisational structure will impact the flow of communication, as well as the level of formality involved in communicating.

Psychological environment

The psychological environment determines how free people feel to engage with one another; for example, to ask for assistance if they need it. The organisational culture has a direct influence on

the psychological environment. A healthy environment is one in which employees feel confident and are not fearful of rejection, as well as one in which they receive acknowledgement and take responsibility for their actions (Ridgway, 2018).

Economic environment

Features of the economic environment include 'time and resources available to engage in everyday conversation and community activities' (Annenberg School for Communication, n.d.). For example, a shop assistant may find that they have plenty time to converse with colleagues or customers if the store is not busy.

Technological environment

In the context of communication, technology refers to equipment that facilitates communication; for example, telephones or mobile devices, the Internet, email etc. The easier the company makes it for employees to communicate, the more people *will* communicate. However, this communicative freedom can also be abused, as employees may use the technological infrastructure for personal purposes, which affects their productivity. An example of this would be using the Internet for activities unrelated to the job at hand, such as social networking, playing games or watching videos online.

The context of communication

Communication does not take place in a vacuum – it requires *context*. To illustrate this, read the passage in the following text box.

> ***The procedure***
> At first, this procedure may seem complicated, but it will soon become a routine task that can be repeated often.
>
> First, you will need to arrange the items in different groups or piles, and then determine the sorting criteria; for example, the colour, type of material, temperature endurance, time needed, or chemicals that need to be added. One pile may be sufficient, depending on the quantity and assortment you are dealing with. However, you may not have the necessary facilities to complete the process. In this case, you will have to outsource it or find the appropriate facilities to do it yourself. It is important to not do too much at a time, as mistakes can be costly.
>
> After the procedure has been completed, you will need to arrange the items in different groups again, so that they can be put into their appropriate places. Eventually, they will be used again, and the entire cycle will need to be repeated.

You may have had some difficulty determining what was being described in this passage. The reason for this is that it was not *contextualised* – i.e. the situational background was not provided. Although you may have figured it out eventually, the procedure is describing the process of doing the laundry. Now that the context has been provided, the passage should immediately make more sense.

The communication context therefore refers to the situation in which the exchange takes place. As such, it gives us clues that help us to understand the message. It also helps us to determine whether to use formal or informal communication channels, which medium is most suitable for transmitting the message, and what the appropriate message content is.

The sender

The sender, who is also referred to as the *source*, begins the communication process. Since each person is unique, they will structure their message in a way that is commensurate with (matches) their skills, knowledge, attitudes, emotions and resources, as well as in a way that is most convenient. For instance, a person who is illiterate might choose to convey the message via spoken language or by drawing a picture, while a person who is computer literate may choose to type a message and send an email, rather than speaking to someone on the phone. However, it is the sender's responsibility to ensure that the message is communicated in a way that is clearly and easily understandable to the receiver. This means that the sender requires some information about the intended receiver(s). The following questions are helpful in this regard:

- Who is my receiver?
- Which resources do they have access to, in order to receive and respond to communication?
- Which medium or channel of communication will suit them best?
- What is the size of the intended audience (i.e. the number of receivers)?
- What is their cultural background?
- What is their level of education and literacy?

- Which age group do they belong to?
- What language do they understand?
- What is their relationship with the sender?
- How formal must the communication be?
- What do they already know about the message?
- What do they still need to know?
- What is their attitude toward the subject matter?
- What is of interest or will appeal to them?
- What will be seen as negative?
- When is the most convenient time to engage in communication?
- What should the audience do with the information?

Encoding

When content is being communicated, the sender formulates the message using a code. The code may be language that is spoken or written, or it may take the form of signs or symbols captured in pictorial form (e.g. an icon or chart). The code may even be a physical gesture, such as nodding or waving. Regardless of which code is used, it is important that the sender encodes the message in a way that the receiver will understand.

In the communication context, a code can be classified as either *verbal* or *non-verbal*.

Verbal

The term 'verbal' refers to the use of words (*Oxford Dictionaries* 2, n.d.). In this sense, verbal communication takes the form of either written or spoken messages that contain words. This may be, for example, a face-to-face conversation, or a letter sent via the post. As with all forms of communication, it is important to select words that will be understood by the receiver(s). Your analysis of the receiver (as outlined in the guiding questions previously discussed) will help you to do this effectively. For instance, it may be more appropriate to use a simple word like 'agree', rather than 'concur', in order to ensure that the message is understood. In addition, factors like incorrect spelling and grammar, or even jargon or slang, may create communication barriers. From this perspective, the advantage of written communication is that we can take time to prepare and review how we have encoded the message. Spoken communication, on the other hand, is more spontaneous, and therefore, we constantly need to think about how our message should be phrased, before we speak.

Non-verbal

Non-verbal communication means that no words are used. It can include physical appearance (e.g. clothing), gestures (e.g. body language, eye contact, facial expressions, movement or touch), or signs, symbols and pictures. We will now explore these forms of non-verbal communication in more detail.

Appearance

In the workplace, organisational culture may determine what we wear – i.e. the dress code. The company will generally enforce this kind of regulation in order to project a positive professional image. However, even in social settings, your clothing will convey a particular message. It is therefore important to wear clothing that is appropriate to the context, so that it is interpreted favourably by others.

Eye contact

This describes the way in which we look at the other parties involved during the communicative exchange. Importantly, there are cultural aspects to this. In Western cultures, for instance, it is considered good manners to look at the receiver directly, as a sign of honesty and openness. However, in some African cultures, it is considered disrespectful to make direct eye contact with superiors (Van Staden et al., 2007: 66). Once again, your audience analysis will help you to determine what is most appropriate within the particular communicative context.

Facial expressions, gestures and body movement

These factors add depth to face-to-face communication. Facial expressions, gestures and body movement can serve to reinforce our words, or they may function as feedback.

Our *facial expressions* generally give others an indication of what we are thinking or feeling. For instance, a smile that accompanies a greeting will indicate that we are happy to see the person. On the other hand, if we frown while listening to someone, it may indicate disagreement or lack of understanding.

A *gesture*, such as a handshake, wave or hug, often accompanies a greeting. However, much like eye contact, this has cultural implications. In some cultures, a firm handshake means that the person is

assertive and dominant, while in other cultures, a gentle handshake signifies harmony and peace (Van Staden et al., 2007: 52).

Our *body movement* and posture can also function as a form of communication. For example, it can indicate whether we are feeling confident, excited, angry or insecure. A rigid posture may be interpreted as social awkwardness, whereas flowing movements can suggest self-assurance. Open and free gestures can also make us seem more approachable, and therefore invite communication and contact (Van Staden et al., 2007: 70–71).

Although facial expressions, gestures and body movement are often involuntary and unconscious, effective communicators will constantly consider the message they are sending via these non-verbal cues.

Vocal tone and pattern

In the context of spoken/oral communication, our voice also plays a significant role. When used correctly, our voice can add a sense of interest to our words, and therefore hold the receiver's attention. This is particularly relevant when the receiver cannot see the sender (e.g. during a phone call). Aspects of voice include *pitch, pace, pause, volume* and *tone* (Cleary, 2014: 22).

A high *pitch* often indicates cheerfulness or excitement, whereas a low pitch can suggest secrecy or sadness. However, a very high pitch may be unpleasant for the listener, and can therefore act as a barrier.

Speaking at a very fast *pace* may give the impression that the speaker is nervous or in a hurry. A steady and fluid pace, on the other hand, can indicate that the speaker is knowledgeable and intelligent, while a medium or slow pace can suggest calmness and honesty. Generally, receivers tend to be more comfortable with a pace that matches their own style of communicating (Van Staden et al., 2007: 75).

A *pause* gives the receiver time to think about the message being conveyed, and serves to regulate the flow of communication. When the speaker pauses, it indicates that the receiver is expected to respond (Cleary, 2014: 18).

When speaking, we need to use a volume that is appropriate. While we may alter our volume to convey a sense of happiness, excitement or enthusiasm, this may also be considered disrespectful if it disturbs those around us; for example, speaking loudly in a library or open-plan office. In contrast, while whispering may be appropriate in settings like these, it may be interpreted as secretive or gossiping in other contexts.

Finally, our tone indicates our attitude toward the subject matter. It should therefore be used cautiously, and in a way that is appropriate to both the situation and the receiver. Often, how we say something is more important than what we say.

Signs, symbols and pictures

Graphics are often more effective than words – they can grab people's attention quickly, create interest and convey a lot of information in just a quick glance. They also do not necessarily require someone to speak a certain language in order to be understood. There are many signs that are internationally recognisable; for example, traffic signs.

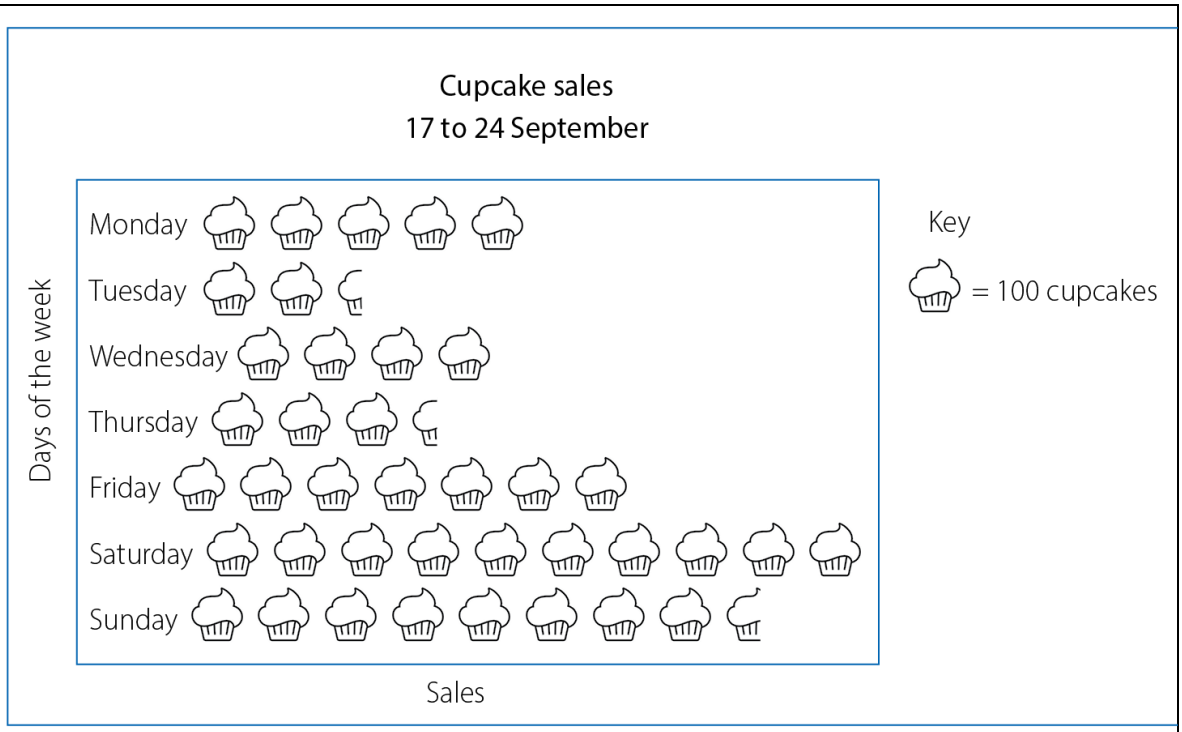
Most people can look at a picture or sign and immediately understand what it means. This makes signs and symbols a good option when encoding a message for people who speak a different language or are illiterate.

Consider which of the following examples is more effective in terms of communicating the same information.Example A: Verbal communication

Example A: Verbal communication

On Monday, we sold 500 cupcakes; on Tuesday, we sold 250; on Wednesday, we sold 400; on Thursday, we sold 350; on Friday, we sold 700; on Saturday, we sold 1 000; and on Sunday, we sold 950.

Example B: Non-verbal/graphic communication



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; and Shutterstock.com)Figure 7.7: An example of non-verbal/graphic communication

Appearance of documents

When we draft a document, we typically use words (verbal communication). However, we also use many non-verbal elements to encode the message, so that it can be read and understood easily. These elements include layout, headings, subheadings, borders, colour, font, font size, spacing, bold, italics and underlining. These elements can, as such, either enable effective communication or hinder it.

Message

The message refers to the actual content, subject matter, point or idea that the sender wants to convey. Additionally, the sender usually has a reason for sending a message. The purpose may be one, or a combination, of the following:

- To give information
- To offer an explanation
- To request information
- To record information
- To foster good relations
- To satisfy social needs
- To modify behaviour
- To encourage an action
- To entertain

The purpose underlying the message will, in turn, dictate the content. Likewise, the characteristics of both the sender and the receiver will influence how this content is communicated. If the receiver is already quite knowledgeable about the subject matter, it would be unnecessary for the sender to provide much background information.

Medium or channel

The terms 'medium' and 'channel' are synonymous, and are the means by which the message is transmitted. These may be formal or informal (which will be discussed in a later section). However, people usually respond via the same channel that was used by the sender. In other words, if you receive an email, you are likely to respond via email; if you receive an instant message, you will likely reply with an instant message. The sender therefore needs to consider the medium, and whether it will facilitate an easy response.

In the workplace, channels for written communication can include emails, memos, reports, letters, fax or instant messaging platforms such as Skype or Slack. In contrast, channels for spoken

communication can include telephone calls, meetings, face-to-face conversations or videoconferencing platforms such as Skype or FaceTime. Although there is no singular ideal medium, choosing an unsuitable medium for a particular situation can lead to communication barriers.

When selecting a medium, the following aspects need to be considered:

- Available resources of sender
- Available resources and literacy of receiver
- Proximity
- Subject matter
- Complexity of message
- Size of audience
- Level of formality
- Cost
- Time
- Need for feedback
- Need for hard copy or proof
- Media richness

Available resources of sender

When selecting a medium, it is necessary to first consider the resources at your disposal. For example, if you do not have access to the Internet, you cannot send an email. Similarly, if the post office is on strike, it is not advisable to send a letter.

Available resources and literacy of receiver

You also need to consider the resources available to the receiver. For example, if the receiver does not have a mobile phone or the technological know-how to operate it, then instant messaging is not an appropriate option. Similarly, if their level of literacy is low, you would need to consider communication channels that do not involve the use of text – e.g. a phone call.

Proximity

Proximity means closeness in terms of physical space and location. If the sender is in close proximity to the receiver, then a face-to-face conversation may be the logical choice – unless other factors (such as the ones we will discuss shortly) influence the medium selection. On the other hand, if the receiver is located far away, then email, video calls or instant messaging may be more appropriate.

Subject matter

If the subject matter is personal or private, it will significantly influence which medium is selected. For example, a performance review would be conducted in a personal, face-to-face meeting, whereas the launch of a new product would be announced publicly – e.g. via newspaper, radio, television or online.

Complexity of message

If a message is highly complex, it may be better to include a written point of reference; for example, a set of instructions. On the other hand, face-to-face communication may also be suitable, to ensure that the message has been understood clearly and correctly. In some cases, the sender may decide to use more than one channel – i.e. a set of written instructions as well as face-to-face communication.

Size of audience

It is vital to consider the size of the audience – i.e. the number of intended receivers – when choosing the medium of communication. For example, a large audience can be addressed at a group meeting, conference or via email correspondence; or, alternatively, through other forms of media, such as television, radio, newspapers, flyers, billboards or social media. For one-to-one communication, however, some of these channels would be less appropriate.

Level of formality

Spoken/oral communication is often regarded as being less formal than written communication. Therefore, in a situation that calls for more formality, a letter (even sent as an email attachment) would likely be more suitable than a phone call or instant message.

Cost

Most organisations are very conscious of expenses. If a company has 500 account statements to send to its customers, it might cost the business around R 3 per account if these are sent via the post. This amounts to R 1 500. Alternatively, the company could send these accounts via bulk SMS, at about 18 cents each. This would total R 90 – i.e. R 1 410 less than the postage option. However, using email would be more ideal, as this is likely to have no additional costs attached.

Time

The time that it takes for a message to be received will also influence the medium selection. If the message is urgent, it is most likely best to contact the relevant person directly – e.g. in person or via phone call. Although email and instant messaging promise speedy delivery, the message might not be read and acknowledged as quickly by the receiver.

When it comes to time, it is also important to consider efficiency. For example, it would be a waste of time to hold a meeting if the message could be communicated via an email or memo.

Need for feedback

Both the content and context of the message will dictate which medium is most suitable in terms of gaining feedback. Certain media facilitate unidirectional (one-way), bidirectional (two-way) or multidirectional (multiway) communication better than others. For instance, a billboard creates one-way communication, a phone enables two-way communication, and social media facilitates multiway communication.

Additionally, we may or may not require an immediate response to our communication. For example, placing an advertisement in a magazine would result in a delayed response to the message or, perhaps, no response at all. When we are in a face-to-face conversation, on the other hand, we gain instant verbal and non-verbal feedback. As an in-between option, many digital communication media provide automated feedback regarding whether a message has been delivered and read.

Need for hard copy or proof

When proof of communication is required, a written and physical record is usually preferred. This may take the form of a contract, report, letter or printed email correspondence. However, in some situations, a voice or video recording can also serve as proof.

Media richness

Media richness refers to the type of information that the medium is able to carry. A medium can be considered either media rich (i.e. it carries a lot of varied information) or media lean (i.e. it carries small amounts of simple information). Communication channels such as face-to-face contact, video calls and telephone calls are considered media rich, because they are capable of carrying a large amount of verbal (and, in some cases, even non-verbal) information. In contrast, letters and reports are considered media lean (McShane and Von Glinow, 2003: 334–335). Depending on the context, you would select the channel that best matches the level of media richness you require, in order to convey your message as effectively and efficiently as possible.

Receiver

The receiver is the intended recipient of the message. Just as the sender is a unique individual, so too is the receiver. When engaging in the communication process, the receiver brings their own set of skills, knowledge, attitudes, experiences and emotions. In addition to being a recipient of the message, the receiver also often becomes an active participant in the exchange. As such, they are responsible for paying attention to the sender by being observant, listening to and/or reading the message, and responding appropriately. Likewise, they need to be open to the communication and avoid creating barriers (Krizan et al., 2011: 12).

Decoding

When presented with a message, the receiver analyses and deciphers the code used by the sender. This is called *decoding* (interpreting) the message. If the receiver decodes the message correctly, there is an overlap in meaning, which results in understanding, and ultimately communication, between the sender and receiver.

Feedback or response

Feedback refers to the reaction or response of the receiver, after they have decoded the message. It may be verbal or non-verbal, and serves to continue (or discontinue) the communication process.

A response is vital to the idea of shared meaning or common understanding. It provides a means for the sender to gauge whether the message has been received and understood as intended, or whether any barriers have prevented this from taking place. Feedback also allows the sender to take corrective action where necessary. In order to ascertain the level and accuracy of understanding, it may also be beneficial for the sender to use techniques such as posing further questions or asking the receiver to repeat the message (Krizan et al., 2011: 16).

The nature of the response is often directly influenced by the channel used for conveying the message. If the communication occurs face-to-face, feedback will be immediate, and can be heard, observed and/or even felt. Phone calls, video calls and instant messaging also allow for direct feedback, although they may be somewhat more limited. Depending on the situation, emails and other online engagements may or may not elicit an immediate response; sometimes, the response

will be delayed, or the receiver may choose to ignore the message entirely. Other forms of communication, such as postage, may also require the sender to wait for prolonged periods before the feedback is received.

Noise or barriers

This refers to anything that interferes with the message, by preventing it from being either transmitted or understood. This can occur at any point in the communication process – it can stem from the physical environment (e.g. a noisy open-plan office), the medium (e.g. a faulty telephone line), or the sender or receiver (e.g. if either party is a poor communicator). It is also possible for more than one barrier to be present in an exchange. It is therefore essential to identify barriers (either present or potential ones), in order to avoid or overcome them.

7.3.2 More on noise: Barriers to communication

As suggested previously, communication barriers can result in misunderstanding, confusion and overall miscommunication (*Business Consi*, n.d.).

We will now examine barriers that stem from the following areas:

- The organisation
- The physical environment
- Physiological issues
- Psychological issues
- Personal barriers
- Language

The organisation

An organisation may unwittingly create communication barriers – both internally and externally. This is true of many organisational cultures that do not promote openness, transparency and access to superiors (*Business Consi*, n.d.). Employees require accurate information, at the right time, and in the right place, in order to function productively. Therefore, if the organisational structure is very complex, and it is unclear with whom one should be communicating and when, then a communication barrier is likely to occur. Similarly, if there are many levels through which the message must pass, it may get lost or become distorted. Inaccurate or incomplete information will also create communication barriers; this is termed *message underload* (Fielding, 2003: 42). In this way, companies that fail to provide clear guidelines run the risk of poor communication.

The physical environment

This type of barrier stems from the external environment. For example, a thunderstorm may result in faulty telephone lines, or the sound of a siren may prevent you from hearing an instruction from your supervisor. With written communication, small text or unclear handwriting may also act as a physical barrier.

Furthermore, because we live in an environment that constantly bombards us with messages, we tend to ignore some of the communication, or take it in very quickly. This barrier is referred to as *information overload*, and can result in the message being misunderstood or ignored (McShane and Von Glinow, 2003: 326).

Physiological issues

Such barriers result from internal physical factors, such as tiredness, illness or hunger. If the sender or receiver is not feeling well physically, this may impact their ability to communicate (Cleary, 2014: 16). Other forms of physical ailment or disability can also create a barrier; for example, being visually or hearing impaired.

Psychological issues

Psychological barriers relate to an individual's mental and emotional state. Our general mood, state of mind and even level of stress will all influence how we communicate. For example, if you are feeling anxious or depressed, you may experience difficulty expressing yourself accurately and clearly, which can result in misunderstandings. Other emotional factors such as fear, anger, boredom or love can also play a significant role in a person's communicative motivations and effectiveness.

Personal barriers

Bagraim et al. (2007: 182) list the following areas as personal barriers to communication:

- *Ability to communicate:* People have varying skill levels when it comes to reading, writing and speaking. If the message is not encoded well, it can lead to miscommunication or confusion. Similarly, if the receiver has poor decoding skills, it can result in misunderstanding.

- *Ability to listen:* The sender and receiver need to be able to listen effectively, to ensure that the message has been communicated correctly.
- *Ability to be objective:* This means listening to what is actually being said, rather than hearing what one wants to; for example, by ignoring or blocking out information that is undesirable, or with which one disagrees.
- *Frame of reference:* This refers to how a person interprets information according to their cultural background, social circle, level of education, interests, past experiences, personal expectations and more. The sender and receiver will each have their own frame of reference that they use to encode and decode messages. Depending on the individuals and the context, this can either aid or hinder communication. Consider the cultural example of wishing a non-Christian person a 'Happy Easter'. Depending on the receiver's own frame of reference, this may cause offence. It is therefore vital to always be sensitive and respectful, in order to avoid miscommunication or misunderstanding.
- *Filtering:* This occurs when the sender only conveys part of a message. For example, the sender may leave out negative data by creating a sales report that shows goods delivered, but does not show goods returned and orders cancelled. In this case, the sender is providing incomplete information, which is a barrier to communication.
- *Personality:* An individual's behaviour and outward demeanour can function as an obstacle. For instance, a shy person may avoid face-to-face communication, while an outgoing personality may be perceived as domineering or overbearing.
- Language
- Language barriers stem from the sender's choice of words when they encode the message. The following table describes some examples of language barriers.

Vague words	Words like 'just now' or 'soon' are open to interpretation, and can therefore result in different expectations. It is better to be specific and say, 'I will send my report by 14h00 today,' rather than, 'I will send my report just now.'
Jargon	Jargon consists of language and terminology that is specific to a particular field or occupation. For example, information technology (IT) jargon includes words like code monkey, ping, silo, cloud, nibble, 404 etc. These terms might make little or no sense to those who are unfamiliar with the field.
Acronyms	An acronym is a word that is formed by using the first letters of a string of words – e.g. SOP is an acronym for 'standard operating procedures', COB stands for 'close of business', and ASAP is an acronym for 'as soon as possible'. Organisations often have their own work-related acronyms. If the receiver is unfamiliar with the context, they will not understand the acronym or its meaning. However, it is acceptable to use both jargon and acronyms with colleagues or peers in the industry, and possibly with certain suppliers and clients, if they are familiar with the terms.
Slang or local dialect	Slang is very informal language, used by a particular group of people. In some circles, the word 'dope' is a slang term for cannabis, while in other

	circles, it means 'very good' – or both! As you can tell, the potential for confusion is evident. A dialect, on the other hand, is a form of language that is spoken in a specific region (*Oxford Dictionaries* 3, n.d.). For example, Afrikaans has many dialects, such as Western Cape Afrikaans, Orange River Afrikaans and Eastern Cape Afrikaans (*Ethnologue*, n.d.). Even though people may speak the same language, the different dialects may cause confusion and miscommunication.
Difficult words	The aim of communication is to create common understanding. Using difficult words defeats this aim. If you were asked to 'describe the vagary of the weather,' you may feel uncertain of what this means. If a simpler phrase were used, like 'describe the strange weather pattern,' you would have a clearer understanding of what you were expected to communicate.
Insensitive language	Working in a culturally diverse environment presents many opportunities for causing offence to others, due to differing customs, traditions, religions, levels of education, health or physical statuses, ages, genders and even sexual preferences. Terms such as 'girlie', 'moffie', 'soutie' etc. are therefore likely to be insulting to others. For this reason, you should always be mindful of, and sensitive toward, your audience.
Pronunciation	Pronunciation refers to how a word is spoken, and is sometimes influenced by a person's accent. It also has the potential to change how the meaning is interpreted. For example, a German person may pronounce the word 'thinking' as 'sinking'. Consider the popular advertisement by Berlitz Corporation, a language education company, in which a German coastguard receives an emergency call on the radio on his first day of training. The voice on the other end exclaims, 'Mayday, Mayday, […] we are sinking, we are sinking!' The trainee, trying his best to respond, replies in his German accent, 'Hello. This is the German coastguard […] What are you thinking about?' In this scenario, the coastguard misunderstands 'sinking' as 'thinking', due to different pronunciations. You can view this advertisement at the following link: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=0MUsVcYhERY
Incorrect grammar, spelling and punctuation	Using long-winded sentences or incorrect grammar, spelling and punctuation can make it challenging to decode a message. For example, consider an employee who sends a message to a customer, telling them that the delivery is delayed because they are experiencing a problem in the 'whorehouse' (brothel). Here, the employee has, in fact, misspelled 'warehouse', thereby altering the meaning of the message entirely.

- *(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Cleary, 2014: 14–15)*
- *Table 7.1: Examples of language barriers*

7.4 Channels of workplace communication

Every organisation utilises both *formal* and *informal* communication channels, so that it can function productively and achieve its goals. However, employees also have personal needs that are satisfied through communication. We will now examine these formal and informal communication channels in more detail.

7.4.1 Formal channels of communication

This process is often described as going through the proper/official channels. Formal communication refers to a structured flow of communication that moves between different organisational positions, using selected channels. This flow of communication is *controlled* (*Oregon State University*, n.d.), and usually moves according to the hierarchical structures represented in the organisation's organogram. Importantly, formal documentation such as policies and procedures also guide the direction and flow of communication.

Formal communication can be categorised according to the following directions:

- Downward communication
- Upward communication
- Horizontal communication
- Diagonal communication

Downward communication

Downward communication flows from the upper levels to the lower levels of the organisational structure. It is mainly used to convey information, provide feedback, indicate problem areas, assign tasks and set goals (Bagraim et al., 2007: 171). An example of downward communication would be a finance manager instructing a clerk to draw up a balance sheet.

Upward communication

This is the inverse of downward communication – i.e. it flows from the lower levels to the upper levels of the organisational structure. It is an essential part of the feedback loop. Most organisations encourage participation from the lower levels by providing channels that facilitate communication – e.g. meetings. Effective upward communication aids the development of trust and promotes morale among all employees (Bagraim et al., 2007: 172). An example of upward communication would be a machine operator reporting a technical malfunction to the supervisor.

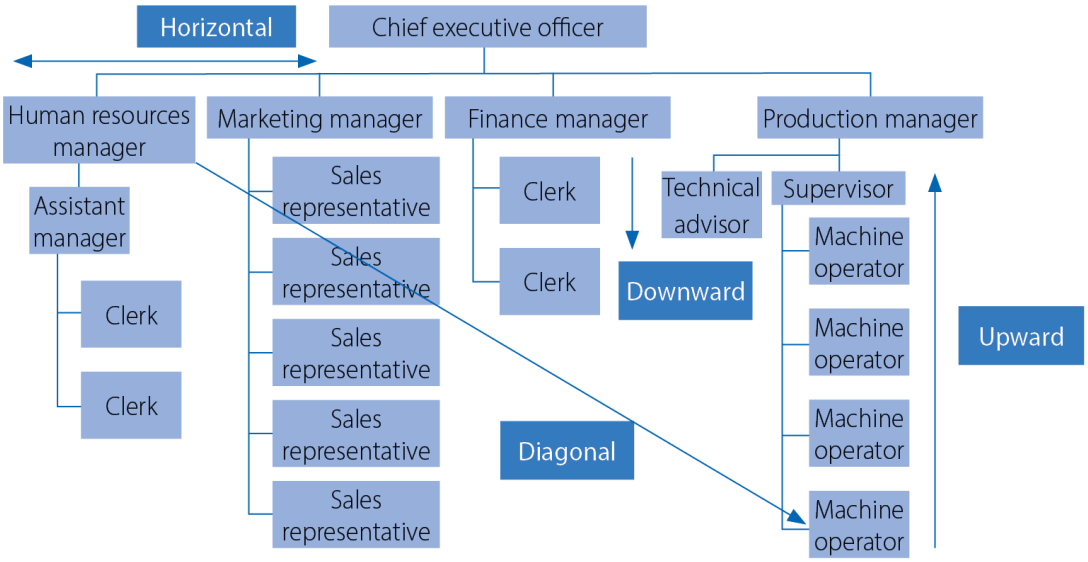
Horizontal communication

Horizontal communication – also referred to as 'sideways' or 'lateral' communication – occurs when employees at the same level of an organisation (but in different departments) communicate with one another. This type of communication is vital for coordination and cooperation, and facilitates problem-solving, information-sharing and teamwork. For example, if a marketing manager needed to know how much budget had been allocated for advertising, they would consult the finance manager.

Diagonal communication

Communication may take place across different levels and throughout various departments of the organisation. For example, the HR manager may conduct a performance review with a machine operator.

These different directions are illustrated in the following figure.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Bagraim et al., 2007: 171–172)Figure 7.8: Organisational chart displaying different directions of formal communication

7.4.1.1 Advantages

Within the workplace, there is value in both formal and informal communication. This section will specifically highlight some of the advantages of *formal* communication, including that it is planned, structured and systematic, and ensures that set procedures are followed. It also clearly defines the flow of communication, thereby increasing overall efficiency and allowing for equal opportunity within the workplace (Beauvais, 2019: 112).

Formal workplace communication has been shown to help maintain discipline, maintain authority for those in charge, and allow for information to be recorded and documented. It is often the case that with formal communication such as meetings, records will be kept of what was said.

It also assists in establishing a connection between the direct superior and subordinate, provides lines for guidance and support, helps to facilitate feedback, and keeps higher levels of all that is happening within the organisation.

7.4.1.2 Disadvantages

In contrast, the disadvantages of *ineffective* formal communication include that employees may view the flow of communication as being rigid and inflexible. Often, an over-reliance on formal communication can result in a very authoritarian and bureaucratic workplace culture being created, resulting in employees feeling that they are not being heard. In addition, communicating formally often takes more time than informal communication methods, sometimes leaving employees frustrated (Beauvais, 2019: 112). Employees may also feel like they cannot speak freely and openly about any concerns they may have when using this method of communication, which may lead them to feel dissatisfied (Beauvais, 2019: 112).

7.4.2 Informal channels of communication

Informal communication occurs when the exchange does not follow predefined formal channels. Instead, it moves freely in all directions, which may, in some cases, cause it to be difficult to identify the original source. This kind of channel is often referred to as 'grapevine' communication.

An example of informal communication is when employees talk to one another about work, personal issues or practical matters. As such, this type of communication can serve to satisfy social and relational needs, as well as practical and work-related needs; for example, people may talk about their plans for the weekend or discuss the content of a new policy. These multidirectional informal exchanges facilitate engagement, encourage collaboration and strengthen relationships.

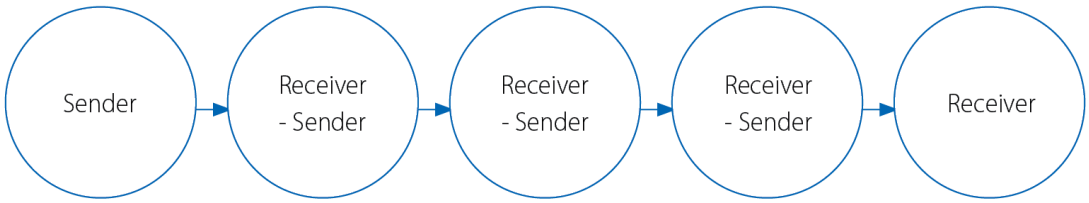
Nieman and Bennett (2010: 269) discuss the principle of 'management by wandering around' (MBWA), highlighting that this informal communication technique gives subordinates an opportunity to approach and talk to superiors when they see them. It also allows superiors to gather information or pick up problems outside of the formal channels.

Sometimes, managers use informal channels to convey information, in order to gauge the staff's reactions (Van Staden et al., 2007: 22). For example, management may circulate a rumour of possible retrenchment, in the hope that employees work more productively to keep their jobs.
There are four types of informal communication (Newstrom and Davis, 1997: 75–76):

1. Single-strand chain
2. Cluster chain
3. Probability chain
4. Gossip chain

Single-strand chain

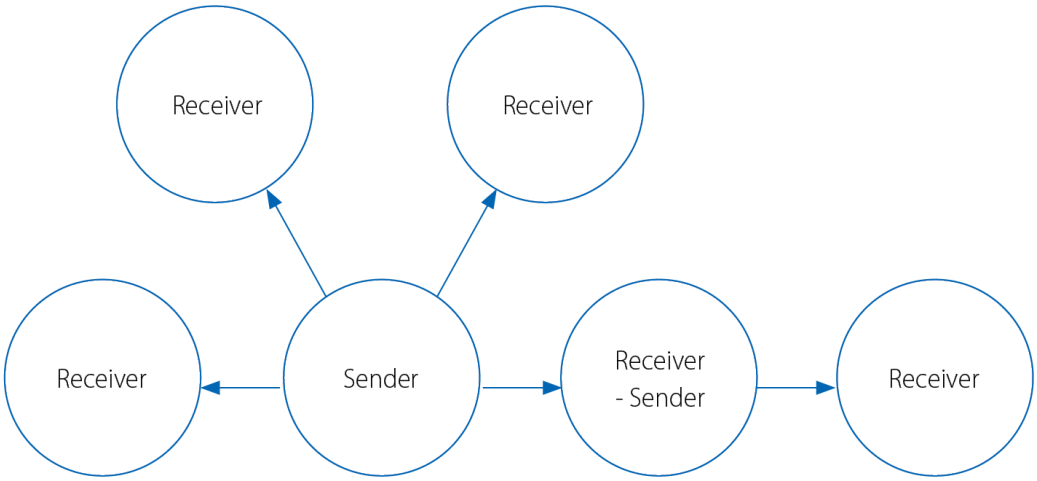
A single-strand chain means that one person sends a message to another person, who then passes it on to the next person, and so on.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Newstrom and Davis, 1997: 75–76)Figure 7.9: Single-strand chain

Cluster chain

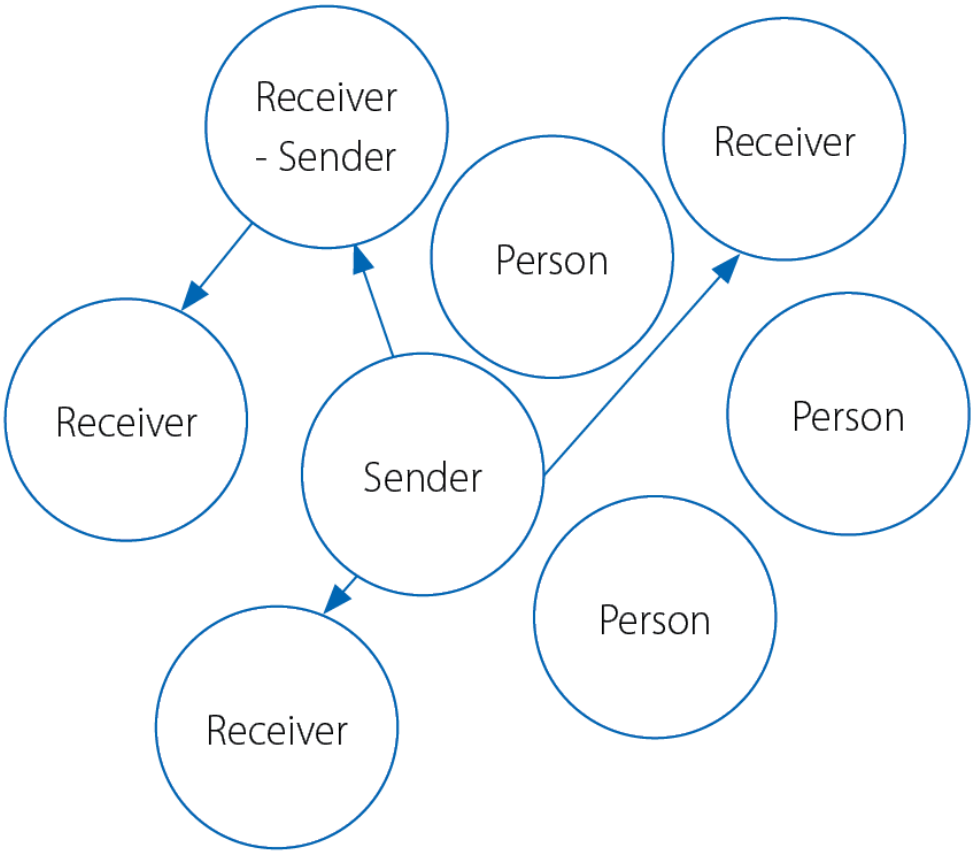
The key to this type of informal communication is *trust* –in other words, the sender will only convey the message to people whom they perceive to be trustworthy. These people, in turn, circulate the message to those whom *they* trust.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Newstrom and Davis, 1997: 75–76)Figure 7.10: Cluster chain

Probability chain

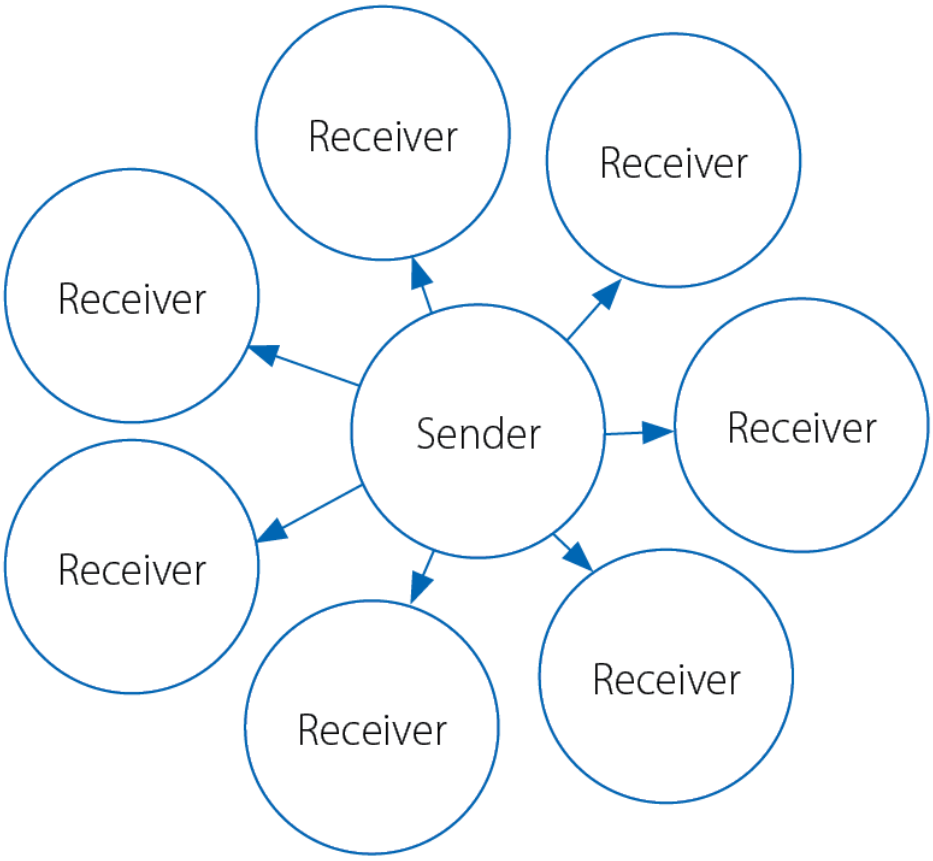
This form of communication is *random*. In other words, it usually occurs spontaneously, when there is an opportunity for an exchange. For example, when you are standing in a queue, the person in front of you or behind you may strike up a conversation. The content of the conversation may or may not be passed along to other receivers.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Newstrom and Davis, 1997: 75–76)Figure 7.11: Probability chain

Gossip chain

With this type of communication, one sender circulates a message to many receivers. This tends to be a casual, spontaneous and uncontrolled kind of conversation, and often involves information about other people (which may possibly be untrue, unconfirmed or unsubstantiated). For example, a receptionist may tell the sales representatives that the sales manager has been fired.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Newstrom and Davis, 1997: 75–76)Figure 7.12: Gossip chain

7.4.2.1 Advantages

Informal modes of communication in the workplace can have both advantages and disadvantages. Informal communication, or communication 'through the grapevine', can create a united force – it can easily bring employees within a company together. Furthermore, this mode of communication is helpful when a message needs to be passed on quickly, and can often lead to idea creation among staff members; for example, a simple chat over lunch with your employees may lead to the sharing of ideas, which could potentially lead to solutions to problems etc. Informal communication can also lead to developing good personal relations among staff members (Chaturvedi and Chaturvedi, 2011: 36).

Informal communication provides easy access to information from a number of sources, fulfils a social or practical need in employees, encourages engagement and collaboration between people, and can often provide superiors with valuable insights that they otherwise would not have received. It has also been shown to assist with detecting problems in the organisation quicker, as well as contribute to a more open and cooperative organisational culture. In addition, informal communication has been shown to boost morale, and it can often supplement formal communication channels, making communication more balanced (Van Staden et al., 2007: 22).

7.4.2.2 Disadvantages

In contrast, disadvantages of informal communication include that it can lead to rumours being spread easily, which can be disastrous for the people whom the rumour is about, especially if it is untrue (i.e. if the information is based on evidence that is not solid). Moreover, this could upset the parties involved in cases where they simply do not want this information spread.

Another disadvantage is that informal communication can only be used to communicate about certain types of matters or issues, and those matters generally fall under the non-functional category (e.g. issues pertaining to staff relations).

Yet another important disadvantage to be aware of is that the interpretation of a message can easily change as it is passed through the grapevine, or via an informal mode of communication. This means that misinterpretations of a message can lead to a message becoming distorted or untrue to some

degree. Therefore, caution is needed when making use of informal communication (Chaturvedi and Chaturvedi, 2011: 36–37).

7.5 Organisational structures and lines of communication

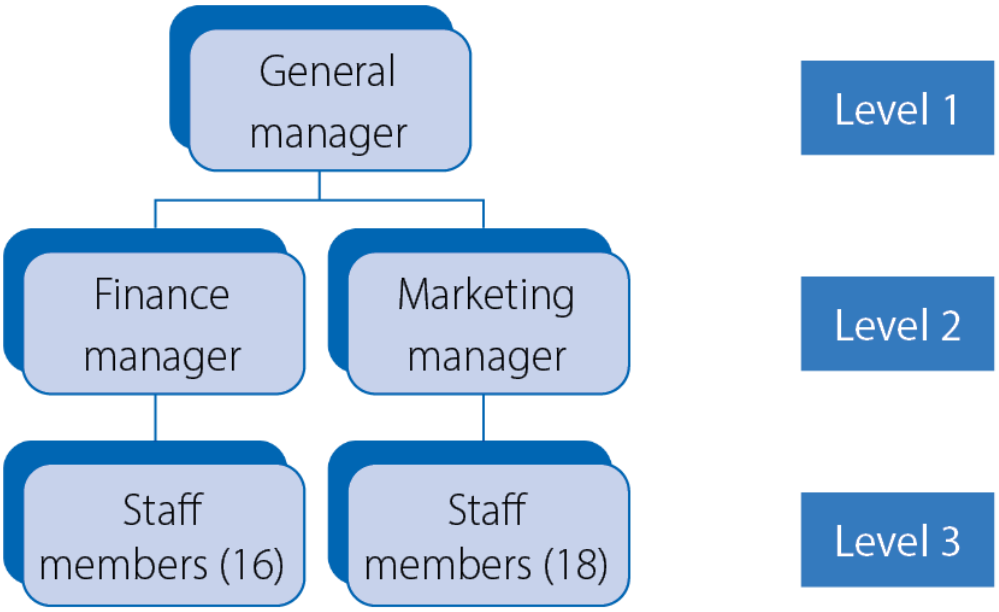
The organisational structure is, to a large extent, dependent on the size of the organisation, as well as on its internal culture. It is usually represented in the form of a chart (or 'organogram') that shows the different levels within the organisation. Generally, an organisational structure can be classified either as *flat*, or as *hierarchical* or *tall*.

7.5.1 Flat structure communication lines

A flat organisational structure has fewer managerial levels; the following figure shows three levels. This has become a preferred organisational structure, and many companies 'de-level' their structures in order to improve communication and cut costs.

In a flat structure, communication and decision-making processes will be faster, and arguably more efficient, because there are fewer levels. This also gives subordinates a greater opportunity to participate, give input and provide feedback.

A flat structure often results in a wide span of control, where one manager will have many subordinates. This places a lot of pressure on the manager, and necessitates that they have strong coordination and communication skills. Similarly, employees need to take more responsibility and have a greater sense of accountability, as they will not be micromanaged (i.e. monitored closely).



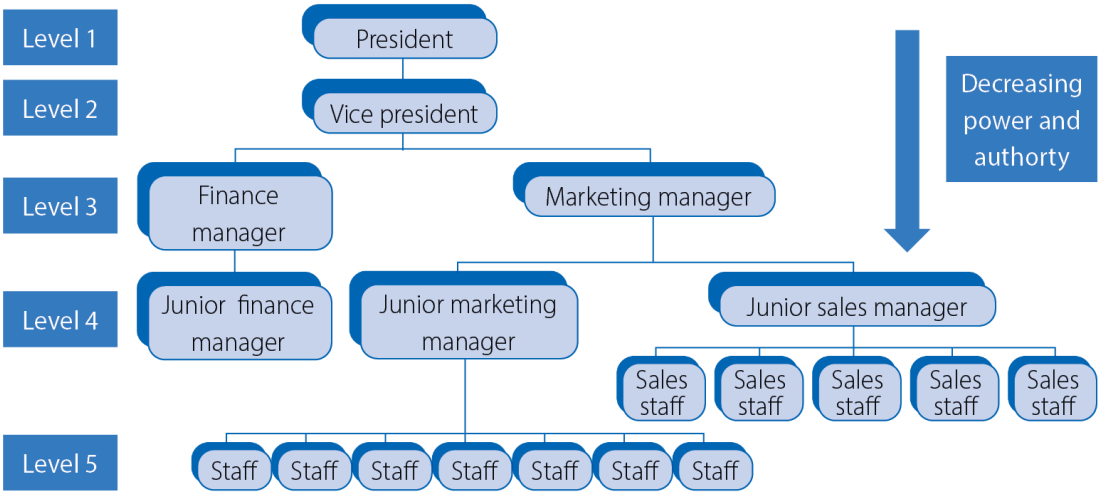
(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019)Figure 7.14: Chart displaying a flat organisational structure

7.5.2 Hierarchical structure communication lines

The word 'hierarchy' means that things are arranged according to rank (*Oxford Dictionaries* 4, n.d.). A hierarchical organisational structure is one in which the highest authority is positioned at the top, while the lowest-ranked members are at the bottom. Accordingly, the degree of power or authority decreases as the line moves from top to bottom, as illustrated in the following figure.

Another term for a hierarchical structure is a *tall* structure, as there are many managerial levels. The following figure depicts a tall structure with five levels. This means that the lines of communication are long, which can slow down the flow of communication. As such, there is greater potential for the message to be lost or distorted (Fielding, 2003: 31). However, it also ensures that the chain of command is clear, structured and formal.

The *span of control* refers to the number of subordinates reporting to a superior (Smit et al., 2014: 221). This span can be either *narrow* or *wide*. A *narrow span of control* means that each manager has a small number of employees under their authority. As a result, the employees can be closely supervised, and the superior can offer constant guidance and support. For example, in the following figure, the finance manager has a narrow span of control, as only the junior finance manager reports to them. In contrast, the junior marketing manager and junior sales manager have a wide span of control, as they each have numerous staff members within their reporting line. It is important to note that the wider the span of control, the more difficult the communication becomes.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Fielding, 2003: 31; and Smit et al., 2014: 221)Figure 7.15: Chart displaying a hierarchical or tall organisational structure

7.6 Effective verbal communication in our working relationships

Throughout this unit, the importance of good organisational communication has been emphasised. This section will specifically discuss the importance of verbal communication such as speaking and effective listening. We will also touch on how these skills can be improved.

7.6.1 Speaking

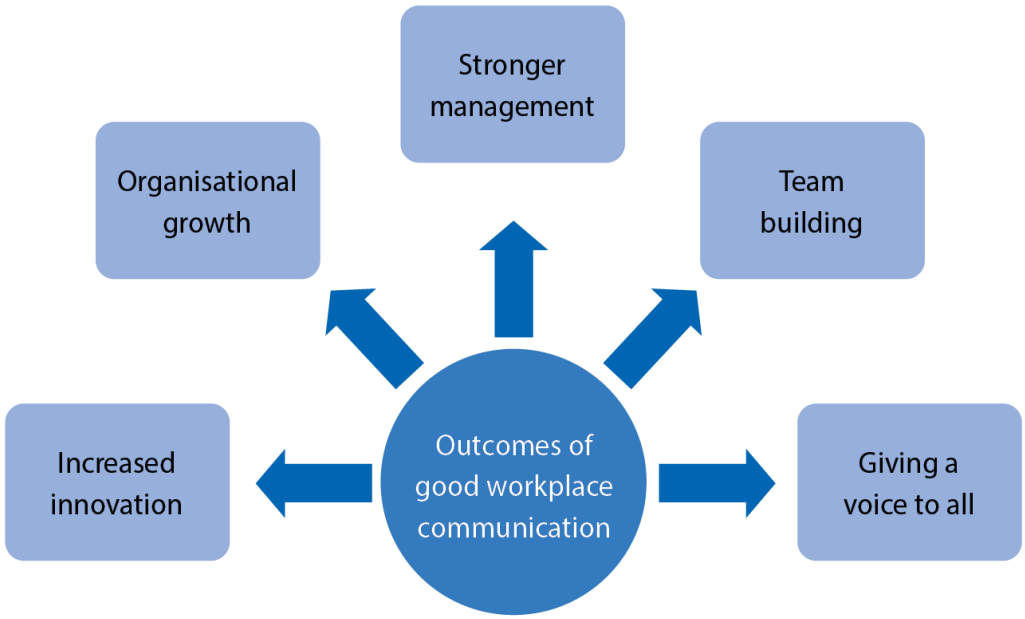
Possessing effective verbal communication skills is something that is considered to be highly desirable by employers worldwide. Furthermore, being able to communicate one's point in a clear and concise way is something that is highly sought after in leaders, as well as something that is essential in employees who deal a lot with customers directly.

Being effective in terms of speaking is not only necessary when communicating with fellow colleagues, but also when public speaking is required – whether this be in the presence of a group of colleagues or external stakeholders. Both of these will now be discussed in greater detail.

Communicating with colleagues

Communicating with colleagues in terms of verbally speaking to them takes place constantly, and across all levels of the organisation. Harness (2018) states that good communication between employees enables the organisation to be more effective, efficient and productive in terms of how it operates. When employees communicate with one another and explain clearly what each individual's role is, particularly when working on a group task, it eliminates any unnecessary repetition of tasks and can assist with identifying any potential problems. Harness (2018) states that organisations with employees who are able to communicate well, in terms of how they actually speak to one another, outperform competitors in terms of their productivity and performance, and have reduced overall conflict.

Let's take a look at five outcomes of good communication within an organisation (*Michael Page*, n.d.)



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Michael Page, n.d.)Figure 7.16: The outcomes of good workplace communication

When employees are given the opportunity to express themselves frequently and in a very open-minded, non-judgemental manner, they are more likely to do so. If they feel that their ideas will be respected rather than ridiculed, they are more likely to speak up, thereby promoting innovation. Often, employees may have incredible insights into what is happening around them within the workplace, as well as ways in which to improve operations. When the opportunity to express this openly is provided, the organisation may experience increased organisational innovation and creativity as a result (*Michael Page*, n.d.).

When communication is improved, both internally and externally, it often results in greater organisational growth. Since the foundation of building good relationships (both with employees and with external stakeholders) is effective communication, it makes logical sense that the better communication is within an organisation, the more opportunity there is for organisational growth (*Michael Page*, n.d.).

When management are effective in how they communicate with their employees, they can manage their teams better. As a result of improved communication, management will naturally be better at building relationships, delegation, managing conflict and motivating employees (*Michael Page*, n.d.).

Good communication can result in greater team building: where individuals know one another better and are more comfortable with one another, they will work better together. As a result of this, employees may demonstrate increased morale and greater satisfaction at work (*Michael Page*, n.d.).

Finally, good communication has been shown to increase employee satisfaction, as it gives a voice to all. Where communication is open, transparent and inclusive, employees will feel like they are being heard, and that they are involved in important decisions in the organisation (*Michael Page*, n.d.).

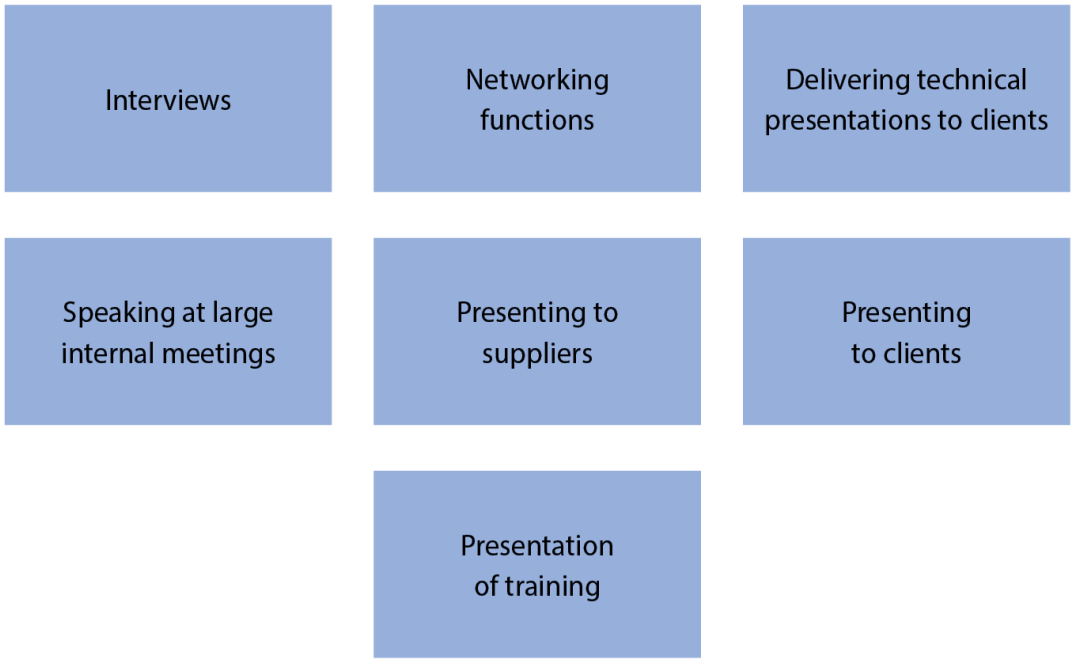
Importance of good public speaking

Although public speaking is something that will mainly be done by the leaders within an organisation, it is still a very important area to consider. For a leader, good public speaking can mean the difference between inspired employees who respect their leader, and uninspired employees who do not.

Morgan (2011) highlights that poor presentations can often present lost opportunities, in the sense that it is time-consuming and expensive to get a group of people together – whether these are the organisation's own employees or external parties. A strong presentation, on the other hand, has the ability to inspire people and get them on board with an idea – failing to do so is merely wasting time they could have otherwise spent doing work.

Poorly executed presentations can actually be detrimental for the organisation; it can cause employees to lose faith in their leaders, or deter potential investors in the organisation. In contrast, a well-executed presentation has the power to turn around a grim situation, and inspire employees

to get back onto the right track. It can also repair damaged relationships or change a negative perception (Morgan, 2011).
There are a number of reasons for someone to have to speak publicly. Let's take a closer look at these reasons in the figure that follows.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from McLean, 2014)Figure 7.17: Reasons for public speaking

7.6.2 Listening

While being a good speaker is essential to being a good communicator, listening is equally as important. Only by truly listening to what others say, can one respond in the right way and facilitate an effective flow of communication.

Being a good listener at work

As we have seen, the communication process consists of a sender, who encodes a message, and a receiver, to whom the message is transmitted. It is the sender's responsibility to analyse the receiver, and to construct the message in a way that the receiver will understand. The sender should also prepare the listener to receive the message. With spoken/oral communication, it is the receiver's responsibility to listen to the message, and to respond appropriately. Effective communication cannot take place unless both parties are committed to, and engaged in, this process.
Importantly, there is a difference between *hearing* and *listening*. *Hearing* is a physiological, passive process, in which sound waves are detected by sensory receptors in the ear (Cleary, 2014: 63). It is not necessarily a conscious event. *Listening*, on the other hand, is an activity that is learned, and is therefore an active and motivated mental process (Krizan et al., 2011: 433).
Lee and Hatesohl (1993) have provided the following statistics related to listening:

- We spend over 40 per cent of our day listening.
- We speak at an average rate of 125 words per minute, but we can think four times faster than this. This means that we tend to formulate opinions and answers while someone is talking to us. As such, it is difficult to listen to someone with our full attention, as we are focused on our own thoughts as well (Skinner et al., 2004: 91).
- We tend to remember very little. Immediately after listening to a ten-minute oral presentation, the average listener has heard, understood and retained 50 per cent of what was said. After two days, this drops to 25 per cent.
- Listening declines with age. Children tend to listen more carefully than teenagers and adults.

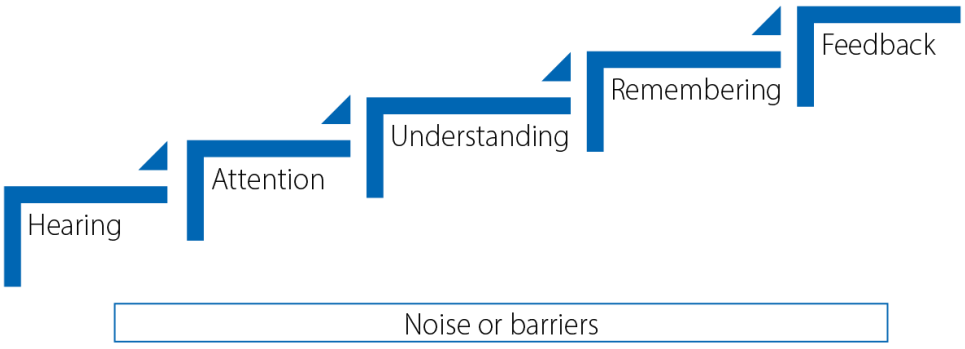
Active listening skills

The term 'active listening' tells us that this type of listening is not passive – it requires concentration. The steps involved in the active listening process will be outlined in the section that follows.

Active listening steps

The active listening process consists of the following five steps (Cleary, 2014: 64–65; and Evans et al., 2004: 104):

1. *Hearing:* Sound waves stimulate the sensory receptors of the ear, thereby allowing the message to be heard and received. This is an automatic physical response, rather than a voluntary one.
2. *Attention:* The brain screens and filters information according to what it wants to give attention to. This is called 'selective perception'. For example, you will involuntarily take notice of a sudden loud noise, as it will grab your attention. Active listening, in contrast, is a voluntary process, whereby you decide to give attention to the sender (i.e. the speaker) and their message. This mental activity requires conscious effort and a proactive attitude.
3. *Understanding:* After receiving a message – whether verbal or non-verbal – we need to make sense of its meaning. We first decode or interpret it, and then evaluate it. Evaluation entails deciding whether the message is important and relevant, and whether it consists of opinions or facts. The processes of decoding and evaluating the message are based on our perception and frame of reference. As a receiver, we are responsible for determining the purpose of the message, as well as trying to understand the sender's intended meaning (Krizan et al., 2011: 435).
4. *Remembering:* After receiving, interpreting and evaluating the message, we store it in our memory so that we can recall it at a later stage, if needed. However, what is remembered may be quite different from what was originally received (i.e. heard).
5. *Feedback:* This refers to a verbal and/or non-verbal response, which serves to show the sender whether the message has been received, as well as how it has been received. The response may be a nod of the head, a question, a paraphrased version of the message, or a simple acknowledgement of receipt. This helps the sender to determine the degree of common understanding. As such, the response will indicate whether the message was correctly received, or whether it requires clarification. If the receiver fails to respond or provide feedback, the sender will not know how to proceed; likewise, the receiver will not know whether they have interpreted the message correctly or not.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Cleary, 2014: 64–65; and Evans et al., 2004: 104)Figure 7.18: The active listening process

Paying attention

As highlighted in the previous section, active listening is about giving the sender your undivided attention. Therefore, paying attention involves focusing on the content of the message and its meaning, as well as on the accompanying non-verbal cues.

Acknowledging the speaker

Active listening also requires the receiver to display the appropriate reactions. If the receiver is critical or shows a lack of interest, the speaker will become frustrated and may discontinue the communication process. Depending on what is appropriate to the situation, the receiver should display behaviour that will indicate to the speaker that they are interested and engaged; for example, by maintaining eye contact, nodding, smiling, acknowledging the speaker's points, asking questions and so on. This ultimately shows the speaker that they are listening attentively.

Checking for understanding

Both the sender and receiver are responsible for checking their own understanding, as well as each other's. This can be done by using the techniques of clarifying, paraphrasing or summarising, in order to determine whether the message content has been interpreted correctly:

- *Clarifying:* The sender can ask the receiver questions, to ensure that the message has been understood clearly and correctly. The receiver can also ask questions if they are uncertain about any aspect of the communication, so that the sender can respond with a clearer explanation and provide them with the appropriate information.
- *Paraphrasing:* Paraphrasing means that you repeat the message in your own words, without adding any information. This helps both the sender and the receiver to ensure that the message has been internalised correctly.
- *Summarising:* Similarly, summarising means that you repeat a shortened version of the message, usually by highlighting only the most important points or the core aspect of the message.

When checking for understanding, the sender can request that the receiver repeat the message; alternatively, the receiver can voluntarily respond with a summary or paraphrased version. In this way, both parties help one another to identify problem areas and correct any misunderstandings.

Providing a constructive response

Constructive feedback is not criticism; it is supportive communication. It is based on facts and observations, rather than on personal feelings or judgements. As such, the end result of constructive feedback is improved communication and strengthened relationships.

Tips for active listening

The following table lists some tips for active listening.

Do	**Do not**
• Stop talking – it is important to remain silent, in order to really listen to someone when they are speaking • Give your undivided attention to the speaker • Be physically and mentally ready to listen • Concentrate on what is being said • Make sure that you have the time to listen • Maintain good eye contact (if culturally appropriate) • Avoid distractions • Pay attention to body language • Listen 'between the lines' • Take note of the speaker's feelings and attitude • Try to stay objective and neutral • Focus on the speaker rather than thinking about what you will say next • Turn off your 'internal dialogue' • Use non-verbal cues to indicate that you are paying attention to the speaker • Show interest, and politely encourage the speaker • Wait your turn before responding • Make an effort to understand what the speaker is really saying • Ask questions to clarify meaning if you do not understand • Paraphrase or summarise the information to check your understanding	• Do not prematurely judge the subject matter, or decide that it is too difficult or uninteresting • Do not distract the speaker • Do not criticise the speaker's delivery of the message; rather, focus on the content and its intended meaning • Do not jump to conclusions or 'read into' what is being said • Do not interrupt – a pause (even a long one) does not always mean that the speaker has finished talking • Do not dominate the conversation or give unsolicited advice • Do not talk over the other person • Do not pretend to understand

• Give the speaker appropriate feedback • Try to remember important details	

(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Van Staden et al., 2007: 40–41; Skinner et al., 2004: 86; and Evans et al., 2004: 106–109)

Table 7.2: Tips for active listening

7.7 Effective non-verbal communication in our working relationships

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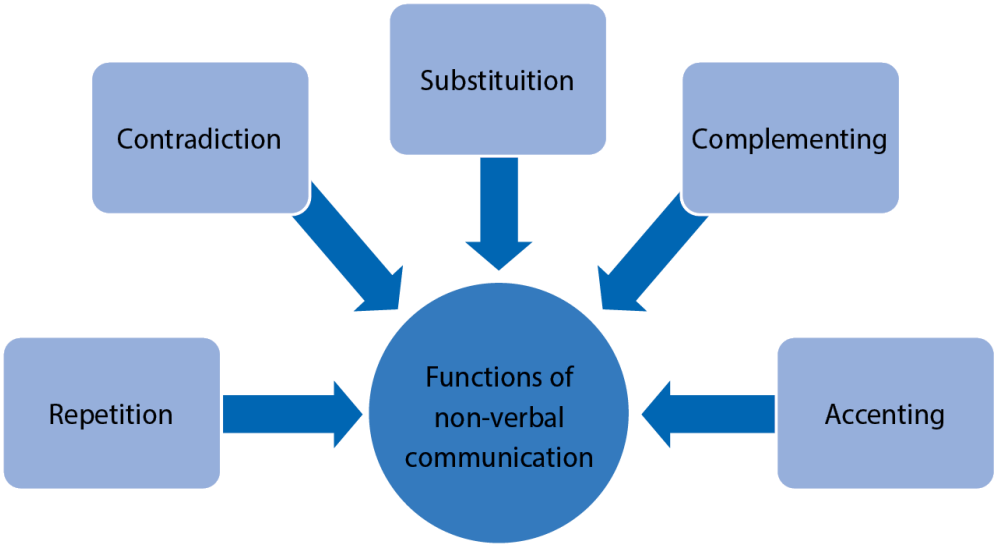
We have already discussed non-verbal communication in detail; however, this section will elaborate on the importance of effective non-verbal communication specifically between employees. Remember, non-verbal communication is that which is completely unspoken, such as body language, appearance, signs or documents.

Non-verbal communication is used to convey emotions in their purest form, such as happiness, anger, sadness, interest, curiosity, anxiety, embarrassment, pleasure or hope. Interpreting these emotions, however, can often be complicated.

For example, Francesco and Gold (2005: 77) highlight how, across different cultures, there are different norms surrounding proxemics, which involves the use of space between people when communicating. Some cultures, such as South Americans, have a high level of physical contact, and will often hug and kiss someone – even in the business setting. This is viewed as normal within their culture. Asians and North Americans, on the other hand, would view this as inappropriate within a business context, reserving this only for very close friends and family.

This example highlights how different cultures have different generally accepted forms of non-verbal communication. In South Africa, due to the rainbow nation that we are, there are bound to be relatively significant differences across cultures regarding non-verbal communication, which could potentially be misunderstood.

Businesstopia (n.d.) highlights five main functions of non-verbal communication, as illustrated in the following figure.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Businesstopia, n.d.)Figure 7.19: Functions of non-verbal communication

Non-verbal communication often repeats or aligns with what you are saying verbally. For example, if you are angry, your body language will often align with this, and show your anger and annoyance. However, occasionally, non-verbal communication can be contradictory in that it can express something completely different to what is being said (*Businesstopia*, n.d.); for example, asking someone whether they are feeling okay and they say yes, but then burst into tears. This clearly communicates that the person is upset, and aids you in knowing what the next thing to do or say should be. It is unlikely that you would walk away from a person who says they are fine but is sitting crying at their desk. At the very least, you would ask whether you could help, or refer them to somebody who can.

From time to time, non-verbal communication may be a *substitute* for verbal communication. For example, a person's silence could communicate a lot more than if they spoke. It may indicate disagreement, or that they are upset or unhappy with what has been said. These feelings can actually be more strongly conveyed through their silence than if they had spoken (Businesstopia, n.d.).
Often, non-verbal communication plays a complementary role of what a person says; for example, a person who says they are in pain, and is wincing. In this scenario, the pain is being communicated both verbally and non-verbally (*Businesstopia*, n.d.).
Non-verbal communication plays a very important role in accenting (emphasising) certain spoken points in a conversation. For example, if a person is angry, they may bang their fist on the table while speaking to demonstrate this anger. This may emphasise the main part of a story that is angering them (*Businesstopia*, n.d.).
Let's consider some suggestions on how to improve non-verbal communication skills (Cherry, 2019):

- *Pay close attention to non-verbal cues:* Closely observe people's non-verbal cues, such as gestures, posture, eye contact and tone of voice. You will quickly learn how to respond to these cues.
- *Be aware of incongruent behaviours:* Occasionally, it will be evident that someone's words and non-verbal behaviour do not align. In such an instance, pay more attention to the non-verbal communication rather than the verbal communication – the non-verbal cues are often communicating the truth more so than the verbal cues.
- *Monitor your tone of voice when talking:* When speaking to someone, ensure that you carefully manage your tone of voice. This can be particularly useful when trying to demonstrate enthusiasm, or when you disagree with someone (in this case, it would be important to adopt a calm, non-sarcastic tone of voice).
- *Use appropriate eye contact:* Too little eye contact may come across as if you are hiding something, whereas too much may come across as intimidating.
- *Ask questions if you are unsure:* If you are confused by someone's non-verbal behaviour, do not be afraid to ask questions. This can be done by asking leading questions such as, 'So what you are trying to say is …'
- *Use non-verbal cues to make communication more meaningful:* More than simply focusing on your verbal communication, consider what impression you wish to make. For example, you may want to come across as confident in a presentation. This can be done by using non-verbal communication to communicate confidence to your audience.
- *Look at signals holistically:* In truly understanding non-verbal communication, it is better to base your understanding of this off a group of non-verbal cues rather than just one. This will ensure that you are reading the cues correctly.
- *Consider the context:* Different contexts will require different types of communication and different levels of formality. You should strive to use non-verbal communication that is appropriate for the setting you find yourself in. For example, the cues you use among your colleagues will be different to the ones you use when you are talking to your manager.
- *Signals can be misread:* Some say that a firm handshake is a sign of a strong personality, while a weak handshake indicates a weaker personality. However, there is no real evidence to back this claim up; therefore, it is important to bear in mind that some non-verbal cues can be misread.
- *Practice makes perfect:* Some people are naturals when it comes to reading non-verbal cues, whereas others may need to actively concentrate and try to improve their understanding of non-verbal cues.

7.8 Effective written communication in our working relationships

Not all communication that takes place in the organisation will be verbal or non-verbal – it can also be in the form of written communication. This section will elaborate on the importance of good written communication for working relationships, as well as how it can be improved.

Importance of effective written communication

With the growing presence of technology, and email being something that we use on a daily basis in the workplace – both in dealing with fellow colleagues and external parties – good writing skills are now more important than ever before (Aamodt, 2010). Written communication may also include memos, letters or instant messaging (Robbins and Judge, 2014).

Being able to communicate well with colleagues or external parties, such as suppliers or customers, involves more than merely speaking face-to-face; it also involves effective written communication. Often, in written communication, misunderstandings can occur, as there is no context or tone of voice accompanying the written communication. This can result in the wrong message being conveyed, and may cause potential conflict.

Poor writing skills may create the impression that either an individual did not pay attention to what they were writing, or worse, that the person is unprofessional and incompetent. It is for this very reason that good writing skills are absolutely essential in this day and age.

Business World (2017) notes that being a good writer increases your credibility. For example, imagine that you receive an email from a service provider, and that this email is poorly written, with odd abbreviations and misspelled words, and makes no sense. Straightaway, this may put you off and cause you to think that, maybe, this service provider is not trustworthy, and that the quality of service they would provide may match their 'sloppy' email.

Good business writing conveys good common courtesy, which will be well received by colleagues and clients alike. Good writing has also been shown to assist with good record keeping, which is an essential business skill (*Business World*, 2017).

Whenever written communication is the chosen medium for communication, the following should be considered (Cameron, 2018; and Iyer, 2017):

- *Whether the message that is about to be communicated is appropriate for written communication:* While some information is best said face-to-face, other information is better presented through written communication; for example, quick business emails, or sending large amounts of information in spreadsheets.
- *Word choice:* This considers whether the words chosen convey the message in a clear and simple manner. Language should not be too complex, and the level of formality should be considered. Unless emailing between colleagues (which can be very informal), emails should always be professional and succinct, especially when responding to a boss or any clients.
- *Punctuation:* It is important to examine a piece of written communication once it is complete, in order to check for any punctuation or grammatical errors. This will ensure professionalism, and will minimise any potential misunderstandings.
- *Writing style:* It is imperative that the correct writing style is used. For example, the writing style used when creating a brochure that promotes the business, compared to writing a business email to your boss or a potential client, may be very different.
- *Length:* When a piece of written communication is too lengthy, the main point may get lost. Therefore, it is vital that there is no rambling or excessive padding added to written communication; instead, it should be kept clear, concise and to the point.
- *Ensuring the overall message is clearly communicated:* It is important to check whether the aim of the email has been successfully communicated. Read it back to yourself a few times before sending it, to ensure that the main message you wish to communicate comes across clearly.

Improving your written communication skills

The following tips should be taken into consideration when trying to improve written communication skills (Cameron, 2018):

- *Think before you write:* Before writing any form of correspondence, give some thought to what it is you are wanting to say, as well as the best way to communicate this. Ensure that the main point of the written communication remains the focus.
- *Keep it simple:* Avoid using jargon, and avoid trying to sound smart. Get to the point in a simple and concise way.
- *Ensure your communication is not too 'wordy':* Do not use unnecessary ramble, and avoid using multi-word phrases such as 'end result' rather than just 'result'.
- *Reduce adjectives and adverbs:* In the interests of keeping written communication short and to the point, be specific and do not use unnecessary adjectives.
- *Write more and read more:* By writing more often, your skills will naturally improve. Furthermore, reading more will naturally improve your grammar and vocabulary.
- *Always know your audience:* Be mindful of who it is you are writing to, and ensure that your tone and style of writing matches this.
- *Never send your first draft:* Always reread an important letter or email you have written before sending it. The first draft is never perfect.

- *Edit and proofread:* Proofread your piece before sending it off anywhere, and ensure that you edit any mistakes that you find.

FAST FORWARD: Non-verbal communication in cyberspace

Marco works in a graphic design and marketing agency, called Dream Designs, and has been there for seven years. Overall, he finds the working environment to be fairly relaxed and informal; however, it is very clear that there is a certain level of respect and formality that is expected when addressing the 'big bosses' within the company. Marco, being the fun-loving and outgoing person he is, has made great friends with all of his colleagues. He is well known for being the 'office clown', who is always sending a joke or meme around the office using email or Slack – the newly introduced platform to communicate in their workplace.

Slack is a form of instant messaging that can be used by employees to communicate with one another, and gives them the option to create separate channels for different conversations. This allows for the easy separation of those working on various projects, as well as formal and informal conversations. Generally, employees do not message the 'big bosses' using Slack, but instead, draft a more formal email if they have a query.

A new group of interns have just started out at Dream Designs, and Marco is assigned one intern for whom he is responsible. Marco is known for being a great mentor, and is particularly skilled at explaining how to perform technical tasks.

Marco's new intern, Leslie, stumbles across a great idea, which she wishes to pitch to the 'big bosses'. Using Slack, she sends the following message, before running it by Marco:

Hi guys! Leslie here! I have SO many ideas that I'd love to pitch to you – my brain is honestly just bursting with all the suggestions I have. Can we make a plan to meet up sometime soon? Maybe even grab a beer together to discuss my ideas??? Let me know!

7.9 Summary

In order for a message to travel from one person to another successfully, it is necessary to understand the basics of communication, and to put them into practice. Communication is ultimately a process that consists of various elements. As we have seen, these elements include the message, encoding the message, sending the message, the channel through which the message travels, receiving the message, decoding the message and responding to the message.

However, it is important to remember that the communication process is not always a smooth one – there may be certain barriers to overcome when delivering and receiving a message. These barriers may stem from organisational, physical, physiological, psychological, personal, linguistic and/or cultural causes.

This unit has also highlighted the importance of maintaining effective lines of communication. Hierarchical structure communication lines result in longer lines of communication, whereas flat structure communication lines enable messages to be sent quickly, via a shorter line of communication. Additionally, staff members need to consider whether the message requires a formal or informal channel of communication.

Each channel should be appropriate to the message being sent, as well as to the person receiving the message. In the workplace, active listening can play a significant role in improving communication among staff members, as it ensures that the recipient not only hears the message, but also understands it.

Finally, by acknowledging the person you are communicating with, as well as clarifying the message and providing constructive feedback, you will be able to communicate more effectively in the workplace. The importance of non-verbal communication and written communication in working relationships was also discussed.

Chapter 8

8.1 Introduction

Konrad has just started his new job at an auditing firm, where he works with a group of 29 other article clerks. The group is getting to know one another and settling into their new job. Since this is Konrad's first audit, he is a little nervous. What makes matters worse is that he encounters a

manager from his firm who is abrupt in the way that he communicates – he can be very culturally insensitive, often talks down to women and, in general, demonstrates poor skills in managing employees. Most of the team seem to dislike this manager and try to avoid working with him. Konrad feels like this may negatively impact his performance on the job, and the team's performance as a whole, as this manager seems to be destructive to the team's morale. This scenario demonstrates the importance of political correctness, being culturally sensitive, and the value of emotional and social intelligence, which are among the key focuses of this unit.

In the previous unit, we explored the basics of communication at work. In this unit, we will discuss the various aspects of sensitive communication that will facilitate respect for others at work, while paying particular attention to individuals from marginalised or minority backgrounds.

After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- define political correctness;
- explain how to be politically correct in the workplace, with emphasis on gender-related scenarios;
- define the terms 'culture' and 'subculture';
- appraise the culturally diverse South African workplace;
- highlight barriers to effective intercultural communication;
- discuss the characteristics of good intercultural communicators;
- define emotional intelligence, social intelligence, virtual intelligence and artificial intelligence;
- examine emotional intelligence as a crucial aspect of success; and
- discuss virtual intelligence applications.

8.2 Key terms and definitions

The following key terms and definitions are applicable to this unit:

- *Artificial intelligence (AI):* These are devices or entities that are able to make decisions by using their own reasoning, thereby operating in a similar way to which a person would.
- *Culture:* Culture refers to the literature, journalism, film, art, music, dance and social attitudes shared by a particular group of people, which shape their values and behaviour.
- *Emotional correctness:* This is when an individual responds emotionally correctly to a situation that could have been otherwise negative.
- *Emotional intelligence (EI):* This is a form of intelligence that involves the effective management of one's own emotions, as well as the thorough understanding of others' emotions.
- *Human nature:* This runs deeper than culture, and is something that is inherited and universal within all people.
- *Intercultural communication:* This type of communication is the purposeful interaction between two people of different cultures, whereby they attempt to develop a mutual understanding.
- *Politically correct communication:* This involves communicating with colleagues in a friendly, non-judgemental and sensitive manner that will not cause any offence.
- *Social intelligence (SI):* Social intelligence entails having a thorough understanding of the best ways in which to deal with people.
- *Subculture:* Subcultures are smaller groups of people within a broader culture who develop their own set of rules and norms.
- *Virtual intelligence (VI):* These are devices that are programmed to produce outputs based on the inputs formulated by a user.

8.3 Politically correct workplace communication

By now, you should have a good understanding of how to communicate with others in the workplace. For example, you should know how to decode what someone is saying when they use business jargon, and you should know how to decide on the appropriate tone to use when speaking to your employer. Ultimately, no matter who a person is talking to, a key aspect of the communication process includes *sensitivity*. A productive way to think about sensitive communication is to approach it through the concept of respect, as sensitivity begins with an awareness of others and an acceptance of their ways of life.

Perhaps, the most basic expression of sensitive communication can be seen in the commonly used saying, 'Think before you speak', which reminds people to first consider how their words will affect others, before saying them out loud. This section discusses how one can avoid uncomfortable situations with co-workers and management, by practising good communication skills that take into account gender, race, culture and emotions. These areas all have a relationship to political correctness, and must be studied thoroughly if someone is to thrive in the workplace.

8.3.1 What is politically correct communication?

Political correctness has a long history, spanning from the early 20th century to the present day. The earliest expressions of political correctness are evident in the Chinese Cultural Revolution of the 1930s – an event that essentially forced the Chinese people to think and act as revolutionaries. According to Hughes (2010: 5), political correctness 'first emerged in the diktats of Mao Tse-Tung, then chairman of the Chinese Soviet Republic'. *Oxford Dictionaries* 1 (n.d.) defines 'diktat' as an 'order or decree imposed by someone in power without popular consent'. This form of political correctness was seen as a threat to freedom of speech: such a decree (i.e. order of law) would control what people are allowed to say, and would lay out the consequences if people refuse to conform to this control. In the Chinese Soviet Republic, these consequences entailed pledging allegiance to the communist revolution, and to Mao Tse-Tung himself, or receiving capital punishment for speaking out against the revolution and being deemed a counter-revolutionary.

The complicated history of political correctness can present challenges to the modern understanding of the concept, because the concept itself no longer refers to manipulation and control, like it used to in the past. Instead, the modern use of the term has positive implications for respect and equality between people from different backgrounds.

This unit explores a particular kind of political correctness that arose from the protests and conversations held at various American universities in the 1980s. This form of political correctness specifically deals with the way people talk to and treat each other, particularly when focusing on minority groups and historically disadvantaged people. This formulation of political correctness does not force anybody to do anything, but rather, suggests that some uses of language and ways of acting toward others can be harmful. Based on this approach, such harmful acts and uses of language should be avoided.

Being politically correct means that a person relies on a specific set of ideas that shape how they treat others in person, and more generally, how they approach the history and current challenges that marginalised and disadvantaged people face. Political correctness is often mistaken to be a belief system in itself; however, it does not support a 'specific ideology, although it focuses on certain inequalities and disadvantaged people in society and on correcting prejudicial attitudes, more especially on the demeaning words which express them' (Hughes, 2010: 7). Hughes argues that political correctness is not tied to one single ideology or belief system, but rather, addresses the way people express their underlying attitudes toward others. When looked at in this way, political correctness is seen as an element of language, even if it does not necessarily change a person's underlying value system. It can therefore be referred to as a *mindful use of language* that helps to avoid discriminatory or aggravating terms.

Political correctness is not only concerned with how people speak about and to one another; it can also be seen in other parts of society as an *attitude toward actions*. In an attempt to define the boundaries of political correctness, it is often easier to express what people think is politically *incorrect*. In other words, it is easier to identify what are unacceptable things to say and do, rather than identify what people *should* say and do. Hughes (2010: 11) offers a list of commonly discussed issues where political correctness is, and is not, at stake. These issues are outlined in the following table.

Inappropriate activity	**Politically correct**
Using ethnic slurs	✗
Religious swearing	✓
Sexual swearing	?
Paedophilia	✓

Rape	✗
Chauvinism	✗
Sexism	✗
Homophobia	✗
Pornography	?
Blasphemy	✓
Racism	✗
Domestic violence	?
Cruelty to animals	✗
Smoking cigarettes	✗
Smoking cannabis	✓
Wearing fur	✗
Eating veal	✗
Eating beef	✓

(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Hughes, 2010: 11)
Table 8.1: Common issues in political correctness

From this list, it can be seen that using ethnic slurs is considered politically incorrect, but religious swearing is not. This is because, although religious swearing (e.g. 'God damn it' or 'go to hell') may be considered impolite, or even harmful in some contexts, it is not directed at a person specifically; rather, it is used to express a general feeling. In other words, it does not bring up the background of the people involved in a specific religion in order to have its desired effect. However, discriminating against someone based on their ethnicity or religion is considered politically incorrect (e.g. ethnic slurs, anti-Semitism, and anti-Islam or anti-Christian attitudes), because it has the potential to reinforce any historical oppression that people may have experienced as a result of their ethnicity or faith. This can cause real harm to people who form part of certain ethnic and religious groups, and would be a very insensitive thing to do.

Note that, in the table, sexual swearing, pornography and domestic violence are indicated with question marks. This is because gender-related issues do not always find their source in politically incorrect actions (e.g. discrimination against women). It is possible for sexual swearing to be politically incorrect when it is directed toward someone for the purpose of discriminating against them; however, it is also possible to find sexual swearing in a neutral context. Likewise, domestic violence can occur due to a partner having an untreated anger problem, rather than the partner holding sexist views.

Due to South Africa's unique history, there is a firm legal basis for using politically correct communication within the workplace. The inequalities that arose from colonisation and segregation during apartheid are still very prevalent today. However, the South African government has written strong protective measures into its law and constitution in order to address these issues. The Constitution of the Republic of South Africa, 1996 states that 'the State may not unfairly discriminate directly or indirectly against anyone on one or more grounds, including race, gender, sex, pregnancy, marital status, ethnic or social origin, colour, sexual orientation, age, disability, religion, conscience, belief, culture, language and birth'. The strength of this document lies in its ability to provide everybody with the same protection against prejudice and discrimination. The Constitution also states that 'no person may unfairly discriminate directly or indirectly against anyone on one or more grounds in terms of subsection (3). National legislation must be enacted to prevent or prohibit unfair

discrimination'. This means that a person is protected by law against anyone who is discriminating against them for any of the aforementioned reasons. It also means that all people have the responsibility to uphold and respect this law of non-discrimination.
The term 'political correctness' also has a relationship with censorship, as some people believe that being politically correct is another way of limiting freedom of speech. These people believe that making any word taboo, no matter what its history, is an attempt to control or manage people's thoughts. Despite the opposition to political correctness, it is still necessary to use it in the workplace in order to avoid unnecessary harm and conflict, because it concerns itself with 'offensive language, prejudiced attitudes, and insulting behaviour towards the marginalised' (Hughes, 2010: 8). It is therefore important to practise political correctness, as it is a form of showing respect toward others, especially those who have been treated unfairly throughout history.

8.3.2 Being politically correct at work: Gender in the South African workplace

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Regardless of the industry, it is almost certain that an employee will encounter both male and female co-workers with whom they will have to communicate on a daily basis. It is also interesting to note that 51 per cent of South Africa's population is female, which makes women the majority gender by a slight margin (Statistics South Africa [a], 2016: 16). This section discusses the central gender-related concerns that affect women, men and non-binary individuals (i.e. people who do not wish to be categorised as strictly male or female) within the workplace.

Sexual harassment

The Employment Equity Act Notice 1357 of 2005 describes sexual harassment as 'unwelcome conduct of a sexual nature' that can be divided into three broad categories: *physical, verbal* and *non-verbal*. Sexual harassment can also refer to discrimination on the grounds of sex, gender and sexual orientation, which is prohibited by the Employment Equity Act 55 of 1988 (which was updated in 2005). This Act essentially entails that it is never acceptable for someone to initiate unwanted sexual conduct toward anyone else. We will now discuss the three broad categories of sexual harassment that can occur within the workplace.

Physical

This type of harassment involves the actual touching of the body, which ranges from any type of unwanted physical contact to rape.
In South Africa, there exist cases of 'correctional rape', which should also be noted when considering what constitutes sexual harassment and discrimination. Correctional rape is an act 'in which men rape lesbians in what they see as an attempt to "correct" their sexual orientation' (Fihlani, 2011). However, this is not an exclusively female issue, as 'gay men and transwomen (i.e. people who have or are in the process of having their sex changed from male to female) have also become targets of corrective rape' (Louw, 2014). In 2003, a study was conducted by the University of South Africa Centre for Applied Psychology (UCAP) and the OUT LGBT Well-being organisation that indicates that the rates of correctional rape against gay men are nearly identical to those of lesbian women (Louw, 2014).

Verbal

This type of harassment involves someone making unwelcome remarks of a sexual nature, including suggestions or innuendos that allude to sex. This can also include sexual swearing and name calling, or asking someone for sexual favours. In addition, using demeaning, sexualised names for others in the workplace constitutes sexual harassment.
Calling anyone demeaning names that relate to sexual activities is considered politically incorrect. These statements insinuate that people have a responsibility to act conservatively with their bodies, and that those who do not act this way should be disrespected. This is, very clearly, a harmful and discriminatory view.

Non-verbal

This type of harassment can include everything from exposing somebody to nudity, to sending explicit pictures or links to explicit websites, to using rude gestures.
Although women have historically been the primary victims of sexual harassment in the workplace, there are now widespread occurrences of sexual harassment committed against all genders and sexual orientations. One particular global statistic, from a study conducted by the World Health Organization (WHO), reveals that Africa has the highest average prevalence of sexual harassment inflicted by non-partner relationships, as shown in the following table (World Health Organization, 2013: 19).

WHO region	Prevalence (%)	95% CI (%)
Africa	11.9	8.5 to 15.3
Americas	10.7	7.0 to 14.44
Eastern Mediterranean	-	-
Europe	5.2	0.8 to 9.7
South-east Asia	4.9	0.9 to 8.9
Western Pacific	6.8	1.6 to 12.0
High income	12.6	8.9 to 16.2
CI = Confidence interval		

(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from World Health Organization, 2013: 19)
Table 8.2: Lifetime prevalence of non-partner sexual violence by WHO region

While these statistics suggest that sexual harassment may be more prevalent in low-income countries within Africa (at 11.9 per cent), compared to European countries (at 5.2 per cent), there have been recent reports that contradict these statistics. These reports indicate that European countries have similarly high rates of sexual assault and harassment against women. For instance, the European Union Agency for Fundamental Rights (FRA) found that in Europe, '18% of women said they had been the victims of stalking since the age of 15, and 55% said they had been sexually harassed, often in the workplace' (Bell, 2014). This change in the number of women affected by sexual crimes in Europe, from one study to the next, reveals how difficult it is to accurately record statistics regarding sexual harassment in general.

It is difficult to rely on such statistics, as 'sexual offences are of a sensitive nature' and, therefore, may be potentially 'undercounted and underreported' (Statistics South Africa [b], 2016: 10). Reporting sexual harassment or sexual assault can be daunting, and can result in negative social consequences; in South Africa alone, only an estimated 63 per cent of all sexual offences are reported to the police (Statistics South Africa [b], 2016: 10). Since incidents of this nature are so sensitive that they are often not reported at all, it is makes sense that the statistics we can access reflect a far lower account than the *actual* number of people who experience sexual harassment.

It is important to be aware of the fact that perception plays a significant role in determining the prevalence of sexual harassment. This is because 'unwanted contact' is a subjective experience, and it may vary from person to person. Statistics regarding the difference in male and female perceptions of sexual harassment show that 'males will have different perceptions of what behaviour constitutes sexual harassment than females regardless of their country of residence' (Fiedler and Blanco, 2006: 283). The subjectivity of the experience makes it even more difficult to provide an accurate portrayal of the occurrences of sexual harassment in the workplace.

The wage gap

In South Africa, 'women earn 15 per cent less than their male counterparts' (Scheepers, 2015), with some recent statistics citing up to a 30 per cent difference in some fields (*Mywage.co.za*, n.d.). This means that for every R 1 that a male employee earns, the equivalent pay for a female employee will be, at the most, R 0.85 (Makgoba, 2016). This occurs despite the fact that, in total, working women have 1.3 per cent more degree qualifications and 2.8 per cent more diplomas than that of working men (Scheepers, 2015; and Department of Women, 2015). Although this wage gap is not supposed to be apparent in South Africa, due to our strong constitution that aims to protect everybody from discrimination, it is often difficult to ensure that these rights are upheld at all times.

Nevertheless, when we compare South Africa's statistics to other global statistics, it is clear that our government and businesses have worked very hard to address the wage gap. A study conducted by Blau and Kahn (2007) in the United States analysed 48 years of recorded data that tracked and compared the percentage of earnings women received, compared to the earnings received by men who do the same work, at the same level.

These authors found that, as of the year 2000, the annual earnings of a female employee in the United States was standing at only 75 per cent of their male counterparts. The weekly wages were

slightly higher, at just under 80 per cent of male earnings. This implies that there is a further five per cent difference in the pay gap for 'other earnings', such as bonuses or incentive programmes (which would inflate the annual earnings). Slightly less promising statistics have been found in Australia during this same period, where 'a female CEO typically earns two-thirds of the salary earned by a male equivalent, and even in female-dominated human resources roles, the pay gap is still 43%' (Field, 2008). Clearly, the gender-related wage gap is a worldwide issue that is very much in need of fixing. However, it is worth keeping in mind that current trends of equal treatment in the workplace appear to be slowly closing this gap.

The wage gap is actually part of a larger problem that is commonly referred to as the 'glass ceiling'. This phenomenon is essentially 'an unacknowledged barrier to advancement in a profession, especially affecting women and members of minorities' (*Oxford Dictionaries* 2, n.d.). A glass ceiling can be created by upholding very strict criteria for promotion (e.g. an age requirement, experience requirement or very specific qualifications), but it can also arise from a generally oppressive structure of a business owned by a male majority. This phenomenon is referred to as a glass ceiling because it prevents a person from moving forward, while at the same time, allowing that person to see where their potential could lead if the ceiling did not exist.

Understanding feminism

When learning about the oppression of women throughout history or in the present day, one will often come across the term 'feminism'. This word has taken on various meanings in politics, art and literature, but its basic principle consists of 'the advocacy of women's rights on the ground of the equality of the sexes' (*Oxford Dictionaries* 3, n.d.). The equality of the sexes is one of the core issues upheld by the South African Constitution, which states that no person may be discriminated against due to their being either male or female. Protecting women from sexual violence and harassment in the South African workplace forms a particularly large part of this issue, especially since 'more than half of these matters are not reported' (*Herald LIVE*, 2014). It is essential that the workplace be made a safer and more respectful environment for all employees, especially for those who have been the victims of harassment in the past. A key way of doing this would be to eliminate sexism within the workplace.

Let's consider an example of office humour, in order to illustrate a form of sexism in the workplace. If someone in your office is making insensitive jokes, and is trying to get others to go along with them, you may find yourself in a situation where you feel very uncomfortable and do not know what to do. One response could be to 'declare pointedly that it is not funny, precisely because its message is offensive. To laugh at it, we may feel, would amount to endorsing its message, so we refuse to laugh' (Walton and Tanner, 1994: 30). However, Walton and Tanner (1994) go on to explain that we should think about jokes in a slightly different way: although they may contain very offensive content, jokes often ask us to imagine a fictional situation that does not exist in the real world. In this way, no joke would be crossing the line due to its content, because jokes are, by nature, not serious or to be taken literally. However, one should ask whether there is more at stake in this example than whether offensive jokes are real or not.

Ford (2016) argues that sexist and racist jokes, in particular, seem to have two possible effects on an audience. Firstly, if a person hearing the joke is not prejudiced to begin with, they will not become racist or sexist just by hearing the joke, which makes the long-lasting effects minimal. On the other hand, people who already hold sexist or racist views could, in fact, feel validated in their beliefs, and be encouraged to make stronger agreements with these ideas (Ford, 2016). Based on this information, it is perhaps the lasting negative effect of discriminatory jokes that one should be aware of, as the content of these jokes has been seen to strengthen discriminatory attitudes. Clearly, even in something as seemingly harmless as a joke, emotional consequences can be at stake.

For more information regarding feminism, you can watch the TED Talk by Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie, an award-winning author from Nigeria, who has spoken widely about the need for feminism to address the issues of gender discrimination. In this video, she provides a succinct explanation of why feminism is an issue that we should all be concerned with, no matter who we are or where we come from. The video can be found at the following link:

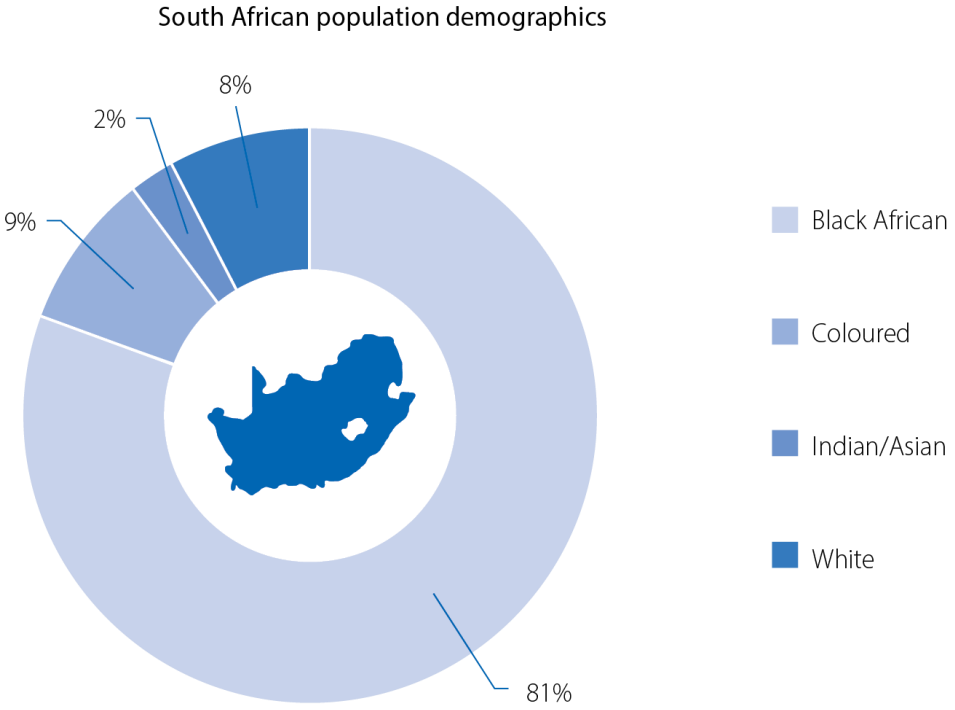
www.youtube.com/watch?v=hg3umXU_qWc

Promoting feminism also means promoting opportunities for women in business, as well as in other areas where they have previously experienced discrimination. If one encounters a woman in the workplace who calls herself a feminist, it is appropriate to ask her what this word means to her

personally; however, it is not appropriate to continually bring this topic up in conversation, or to attribute all of her other values to the fact that she has called herself a feminist.
D'Arms and Jacobson (2000: 16) argue that 'the benefits of gender equality should be bluntly stated: women's progress is society's progress'. In other words, when women's rights and opportunities are uplifted within the workplace, everyone in the country will benefit. Being aware of the issues that women face in the workplace will also allow employees to empathise with their fellow female colleagues who may be having a difficult time. Furthermore, it will prevent someone from overstepping the mark where sensitive subjects are concerned.

8.3.3 Being politically correct at work: Race in the South African workplace

The South African workplace is dynamic, and within it, you will come into contact with people from many different backgrounds, and possibly from all parts of the world. The South African Community Survey (Statistics South Africa [a], 2016) measures the number of people who belong to various different groups; for example, the province in which people live, their age groups and the racial groups to which they belong. South Africa currently recognises four broad racial groups, and allows people to select a general category called 'Other', which accounts for any racial identity that does not fit into these core groups.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Statistics South Africa [a], 2016: 18)Figure 8.1: South African population demographics
The majority racial group in South Africa is black African, which makes up 80 per cent of the total population of the country. In the Employment Equity Act, 'black' also refers to those who belong to the Indian, Asian and coloured racial groups, as these groups were also discriminated against during apartheid. This is what is meant by 'black individuals' in any legal economic documents or laws; however, these groups' racial and cultural identities are, for the most part, distinct and unique.
One concept that must be considered when discussing racial identity is something called 'race-thinking'. This involves using any of the following three false assumptions regarding race (Barzun, 1965: 12–14):

1. People are sorted into different 'unchanging natural types', and we can distinguish between these types by the colour of people's skin.
2. People act according to their physical features, and their actions can be attributed to their race.
3. An individual's personality traits are linked to their racial heritage only, and not to other factors in their lives.

Let's unpack why these three assumptions are not rational, and why race-thinking should be avoided.

Firstly, skin colour cannot place people into an unchangeable natural category or type, because it is only an indicator of a specific chemical that the body produces, called 'melanin'. A wide range of skin tones exist according to the differing amounts of this colour-producing chemical found in a person's body. However, regardless of the amount of melanin people have in their bodies, all human beings should be treated with equal respect. This first point also works to address the second and third type of race-thinking, as the colour of a person's skin does not influence the actions they choose to take in their life, nor does it relate to their inherent personality traits. There is no evidence that skin colour affects a person's decision-making capabilities, or that choosing to do (or not to do) certain activities can be linked to the colour of a person's skin. The same can be said for personality traits, which are derived from a combination of genetic, psychological, social and environmental factors. By inaccurately reducing the origins of a person's personality to the colour of their skin, the complexity of a human being's psychological processes is entirely lost.

Race-thinking can be understood as an act or attitude that is centred on the self, or on the group a person belongs to, as 'the psychological literature on stereotyping persuasively suggests that inter-group cognition is inherently biased' (Downing and Husband, 2005: 6). People should therefore aim to avoid this bias, by thinking of differences between themselves and others as simply that – differences. These are not indicative of worse qualities or better qualities, but simply, different ones.

Black Economic Empowerment (BEE) / Broad-Based Black Economic Empowerment (B-BBEE)

In 2003, the South African government created policies to specifically aim to address the inequalities caused by apartheid. These policies are Black Economic Empowerment (BEE) and Broad-Based Black Economic Empowerment (B-BBEE), which focus on increasing business ownership and career opportunities for black individuals. It is vital to respect and understand these initiatives, because even after ten years of B-BBEE, only three per cent of the South African economy is owned by black people (*eNCA*, 2015). When looking at the Johannesburg Stock Exchange (JSE), it is all the more striking to notice that twice as much stock is owned by white investors compared to black investors, despite South Africa having a black majority population (*BusinessTech*, 2015).

It should be clear that although the South African Constitution and legal system promotes the upliftment of black individuals, the country has not yet seen a drastic enough shift in its economic structure. On a smaller, but no less important scale, race continues to play a significant role in who gets hired, promoted or held back. As Mkhondo (2016) states, 'The reality of business life in our country is that racism in the workplace and marketplace is being pushed under the same rug that many pulled over affirmative action when it was introduced after the end of legalised apartheid'.

It is crucial that employers seek to create a safe and respectful environment that acknowledges the racial differences of their employees, and that they do not discriminate against or favour certain groups. When cases of racism come to light, they should be dealt with professionally, in the manner outlined by the Commission for Conciliation, Mediation and Arbitration (CCMA), as well as that of national law.

Working together

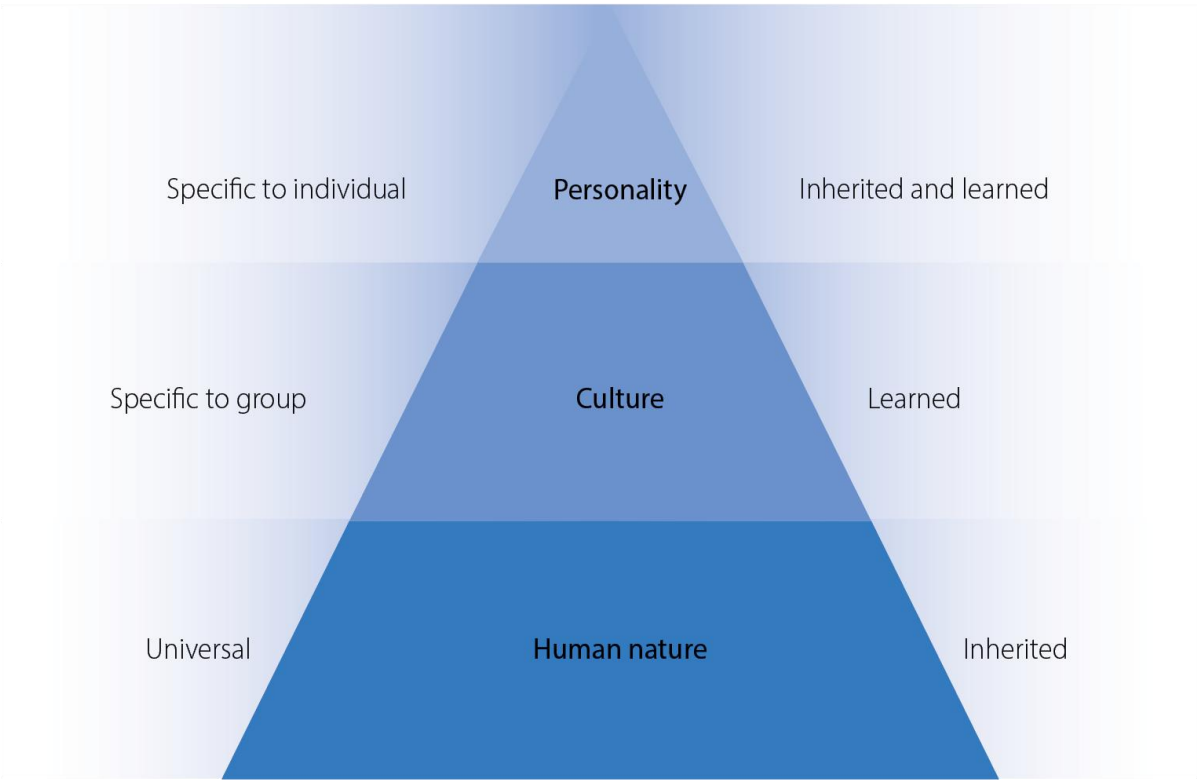
When conducting a recent poll of 2 291 people in South Africa, the South African Institute of Race Relations (2017) found that 'an overwhelming majority (84%) agree that the different races need each other and that there should be full opportunities for people of all colours'. This positive attitude is encouraging, especially when considering the future of unity in South Africa, and South Africans' ability to work together and move forward from the past.

8.4 Sensitive intercultural communication in the South African workplace

When you come into contact with another person who has a different way of life to your own, it is important that you know how to speak to them, without purposefully offending them. A person's attitude toward cultural differences will indicate to others whether or not they are approachable and easy to talk to, and this, in itself, will often determine the success of their workplace relationships.

8.4.1 What is culture?

Culture is a 'slippery' term that does not have a simple definition. According to Halle and Weyher (2005: 208), culture tends to be defined in terms of the literature, journalism, film, television, art, architecture, music and dance of a particular group of people, as well as their broader attitudes toward social attitudes, and political and religious beliefs.
When assessing the formation of culture, it is important to consider how individuals mentally relate to different aspects of their existence. Hofstede (2001) explains that mental programming consists of three basic levels, as illustrated in the following diagram.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Hofstede, 2001: 6)Figure 8.2: The three levels of human mental programming
As depicted, the universal quality that everyone shares is human nature, which is an inherited trait. In this context, 'inherited' means that people are born with their human nature, and nobody can take it away from them. The South African Constitution protects this basic human nature, but it also to protects people from being discriminated against based on the culture they are raised into. Culture also plays a significant role in a person's mental life and processes; however, instead of a person inheriting a culture genetically from their parents, they *learn* and *acquire* culture from their family and, on a larger scale, from their communities. The way in which people communicate with their bodies is also linked to culture, as 'nonverbal behaviour and gestures cannot be easily separated from a person's culture and socialisation' (Ntuli, 2012: 24).
There are five important points that must be taken into account when looking at culture (Samovar et al., 2012: 12–13):

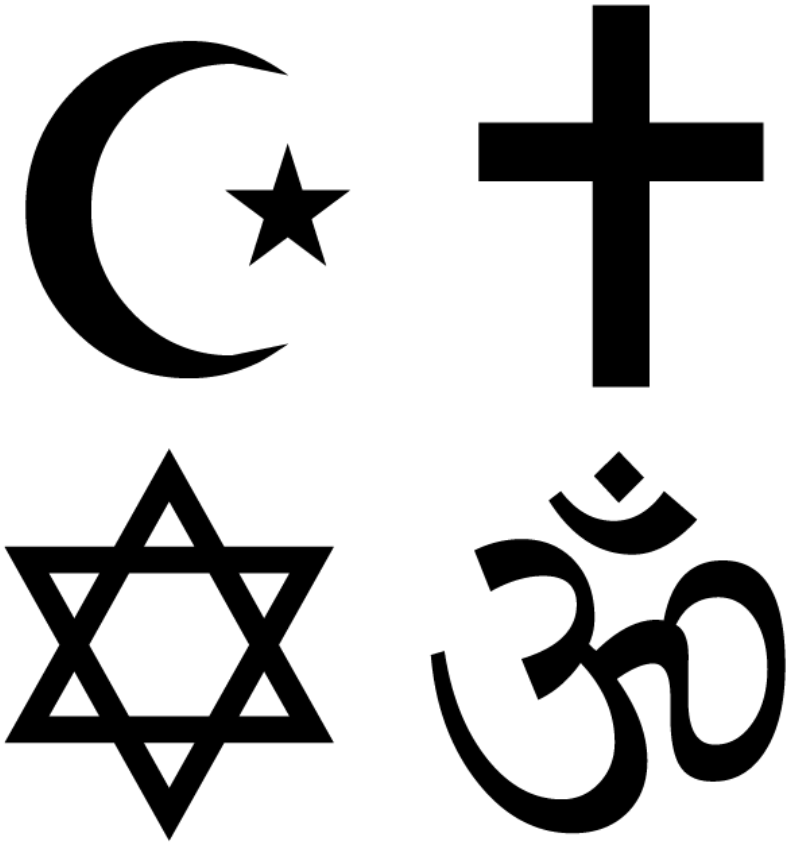
1. Culture is learned
2. Culture is transmitted intergenerationally
3. Culture is symbolic
4. Culture is dynamic
5. Culture is ethnocentric

Culture is learned
Everything that a person's parents and families teach them is linked to culture – whether it be the way the way they speak, the utensils they use for eating, or even the types of celebrations they hold together. If they were born into a different family with a different way of living, they would essentially have grown up in a completely different culture.
Culture is transmitted intergenerationally
Traditions and ways of life are often passed down from one generation to another without many changes; culture is therefore mostly replicated from one generation to the next. However, the

lasting integrity of cultures does not imply that culture is unchanging (as will be discussed in the section on cultural dynamics).

Culture is symbolic

Meaning is conveyed through symbols or images that can be particular to each culture. The most recognisable of these symbols are, perhaps, the religious ones that have spanned centuries, and are still prevalent today.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; and Wikimedia Commons, 2006)Figure 8.3: Cultural symbols

Culture is dynamic

With changes in the world's technology, sociology and other areas, it is natural that cultural practices will adapt accordingly. However, culture does not simply shift and become altered from one medium to another; for example, by replacing religious meetings at a church or a mosque with online chat rooms. Some practices will remain as they were, and others will slowly take on new expressions through the new modes of communication, while simultaneously attempting to retain the original practice's authenticity and essence.

Culture is ethnocentric

One possible outcome of strong cultural ties is the idea of *ethnocentrism*, which is the opinion that one's own culture is superior to that of others. Although cultural pride is a very positive thing that should be promoted, ethnocentrism can be detrimental.

8.4.2 What are subcultures?

Cultures constitute large groups of people with unique traditions and ways of life. Within these larger groups, smaller groups of people who adhere to even more specific practices and beliefs can also be formed. As an example, the larger African culture in South Africa is split into many different subcultures, such as the Xhosa, Zulu, Pedi, Tsonga, Swazi, Sotho, Tswana, Venda and Ndebele people. Although these subcultures are all African, they have different beliefs and cultural practices that are specific to each group. This is part of the reason why it is inappropriate to make sweeping

statements about what a certain culture does or does not believe, as 'not all members share a common, uniformly diffused evaluative horizon. On the contrary, different subcultures or "communities of value" subscribe to different, and at times incompatible, horizons of value' (Fraser, 2005: 451). One must account for the fact that subcultures hold different values, and that these may even cause conflict at times. Individual changes in attitude and expression of cultural beliefs can also be different, which means that two people who belong to the same culture, or even the same subculture, may not see eye to eye.

Within cultures, there are also generational subcultures, as each new generation of any given culture will differ slightly (or in some cases, drastically) from the generation that came before. This can be seen in the differences between baby boomers and their predecessors, Generation X. Baby boomers, who were born between 1946 and 1964, are 'viewed as consensus seekers who are competitive micromanagers and possess [only] a moderate level of disrespect for authority' (Moss, 2014: 55). On the other hand, people born between 1965 and 1981, who fall into the Generation X group, are 'considered so-called "latchkey kids" who grew up with financial, family and societal insecurity, rapid change, great diversity and a lack of solid traditions' (Moss, 2014: 55), and therefore have a greater disrespect for authority. This drastic difference in a small number of years has the potential to recontextualise the culture of each generation into a unique subculture.

It is also possible to be part of more than one culture at a time. For example, someone could be Xhosa by birth, but also form part of the Christian community, because they have joined a Christian church. Subcultures can also originate from art and music movements, which have their own particular way of seeing the world. There are emerging modern subcultures that have a core theme, rather than a parent culture, at their centre. For example, the 'izikhothane' subculture in Soweto, Johannesburg, comes from a Zulu word meaning 'to boast' (House of York, 2014). People in this subculture will often buy very expensive clothing, as well as luxurious food and drinks, that they would not typically be able to afford, in order to show off their status; it is even common for these people to travel to rich neighbourhoods and burn their clothing and other items, to prove that they do not need them (*House of York*, 2014).

Another example has been made popular by the band Die Antwoord, who typify the 'zef' culture. People prescribing to the zef culture 'are the ones wearing crocs, a crop top (including men) and showing off a mullet cut to perfection' (*House of York*, 2014). In other words, zef is about passing off a certain mismatched look that could be considered common, or not particularly classy. According to Fourie (2010), it is 'like wearing high heels with a tracksuit'.

Other subcultures include the 'smarteez' and 'Afropolitans'. Smarteez are similar to the izikhothane subculture, in that they are largely present in Soweto and use fashion as a means of expressing their subculture. Smarteez comprises a group of young fashion designers who dress in bright, eccentric clothing in order to draw attention to the fact that they are 'born to be free' (*House of York*, 2014). Afropolitans, on the other hand, are described as 'a new generation of African; the creative, politically aware, multicultural African emigrant with roots firmly on the African continent and bodies and minds in the world' (Mugo, 2015). Mugo (2015) continues to describe the Afropolitan subculture as a particular state of mind of Africans who prefer to balance themselves across two or more identities, cultures, locations and languages.

8.4.3 Cultural diversity in the South African workplace

Businesses are required to account for the different needs of their employees, especially where their cultural and social history is concerned. This can include making special provision for people who need to take days off from work to celebrate a religious holiday, allowing them to wear clothing in line with their religious beliefs (as long as this does not violate the standards of the workplace), or allowing them to spend time away for a funeral or wedding etc. Attempting to understand South African history will enable people to appreciate the cultural diversity of the South African workplace.

> The nation has been in a political and social time warp, only recently emerging from the agendas of colonialism, white domination, and racial separation to deal with the issues of democracy, national identity, affirmative action, and various forms of empowerment in a multicultural society. (Hughes, 2010: 8)

Even the teaching of apartheid in South African schools is an exercise in cultural diversity, as 'multicultural perspectives have led to a new and more inclusive "history from below" that attends to the experiences of ordinary people as well as prominent leaders' (Schwartz et al., 2005: 255). Appreciating cultural diversity is about understanding cultures other than your own, as well as about

recognising the features that define subcultures arising from geographic, generational and ideological differences.

8.4.4 What is intercultural communication?

In some ways, intercultural communication is no different from any other form of communication, as it is also 'considered to be purposeful—to persuade, inform, or entertain', and these objectives are achieved through 'interacting with someone' (Samovar et al., 2012: 9). When a person discusses the differences between themselves and those of another culture, they have a purposeful interaction, whereby they intend for the other person to understand them clearly. This often involves finding common ground, thereby enhancing mutual understanding, which may require people to simplify the way they explain themselves. Simplification and clarity can be enhanced by effectively applying the communication process.

In the previous unit, the following six functions of the process of communication were discussed (Samovar et al., 2012: 9–10):

1. *Sender:* The person who creates the message to be sent, including its meaning
2. *Channel:* The means of delivery, whether by speech, video, writing etc.
3. *Receiver(s):* The person who receives the message, and then decodes it in order to determine its meaning
4. *Feedback:* The function where the receiver responds and tests the meaning that the sender has provided
5. *Environment:* The context or background to the message, both of which can change the message's meaning
6. *Noise:* The element of interruption and distraction, which can interfere with the exchange of meaning

Every communicative act involves these six aspects, and successful communication involves an accurate exchange of meaning within context, including as little noise as possible.

8.4.5 Aspects of intercultural communication

In order to be a good intercultural communicator in the workplace, the following additional aspects of communication should be applied.

Appropriateness

This aspect refers to maintaining an overall acceptable attitude when communicating cross-culturally. Here, the aim is to adjust the way in which you communicate, in order to cover as many bases (i.e. cultures) as possible – the intention is to make your communication as clear and inoffensive as possible. This can be achieved by using unambiguous language – i.e. words that do not have more than one meaning or are often used sarcastically. Generally, the best intercultural communicators are open and positive about speaking to others, and they try their best to remain respectful throughout each interaction. Some of the things that should be avoided when speaking to others have already been discussed (i.e. race-thinking and generalisations); however, it is also advisable to avoid using slang and any other words that may make it more difficult to achieve mutual understanding.

Effectiveness

This is a measure of how well a person has achieved the goal of their communication, and how their message has been received by the other person, when comparing it to their original intentions. For example, let's imagine that someone intends to communicate their congratulations to a friend for their marriage – does this interaction result in both parties understanding the intention and message being conveyed? Remember, a person's facial expressions, tone of voice and body language all contribute to the effectiveness of their communication.

Verbal communication

Here, you should consider what sort of effect your use of language has on others; this can range from the tone of voice being used, to the choice of words, and even the pronunciation of certain words. In most cases, a person should aim to maintain a positive tone (unless, of course, they are speaking about a sad or serious subject) and keep their voice at a regular volume. This will indicate that they are easy to talk to and are comfortable in someone else's presence. If a person uses a harsh and loud tone when talking, it is likely that other people will find it difficult to talk to them or, at the very least, may consider the person to be rude.

Non-verbal communication

Not only do a person's words convey meaning to others, but so do the various other non-verbal cues they give off with their body. Standing up straight and looking at the person with whom you are talking is an essential start, as you may otherwise come across as condescending or awkward, which would prohibit mutual understanding. In addition, keeping your body relaxed and leaving your arms uncrossed will present a calm and receptive attitude toward others.

Avoiding ethnocentrism

Ethnocentrism refers to when people think their own culture is the best approach to life, and that everyone else should act according to the terms of their culture. This belief can often end up causing conflict. When talking to people from other cultures and subcultures, you should avoid using your own culture as a fixed standard of measurement. It is important to aim to learn as much as possible from others, as this will prevent you from making unfounded judgements about other cultures. No one culture is better or more valuable than another; therefore, trying to compare them on the basis of value is not a helpful activity.

8.4.6 Barriers to intercultural communication

At times, a person may find it difficult to understand someone else, or to get others to understand them. Miscommunication and misunderstandings can result from barriers in the communication process. The following are examples of communication barriers that can cause problems when conversing with people from other cultures.

Language proficiency

There are 11 official languages in South Africa: Ndebele, Northern Sotho (Pedi), Sotho, Swazi, Tsonga, Tswana, Venda, Xhosa, Zulu, English and Afrikaans. Due to this diversity of languages, it can often be difficult for people in South Africa to communicate effectively with one another. Most workplaces will therefore consist of an English language environment, in an attempt to find common ground; however, it is important to note that people's level of English proficiency will differ, and that this can easily cause miscommunication between co-workers. Certain jobs may also require employees to be bilingual (i.e. the ability to speak two languages proficiently), which may be difficult for people who have only received a formal education in one language (most likely in their mother tongue).

Body language

Traditional African cultures consider some uses of body language to be disrespectful; for example, 'beckoning to someone, pointing at someone with one finger, looking someone straight in the eye, passing things, especially food, with the left hand and so on' (Ntuli, 2012: 22). If a person is unaware that certain actions are considered rude according to another culture, it is possible that they could upset others without even knowing it. Other examples of body language that are considered rude in some African cultures include crossing your arms, standing with your hands in your pockets during a conversation, and slouching in your chair when being spoken to (Ntuli, 2012: 23).

Social etiquette

Although social etiquette may seem similar to body language, it is more centred on acting appropriately when spending time with others within a specific social context. It involves specific actions; for example, the appropriate time to begin eating when sitting at a group meal; whether a person should hold a door open for someone else; or whether a person should raise their hand and wait to be addressed, before speaking about something. Social etiquette is not the same across cultures; however, it is important to be aware of a specific context's social etiquette. This is because some of these values may be very important to the other people involved, and not abiding to them may be considered offensive.

8.4.7 Being a sensitive intercultural communicator at work

A person does not need to do extensive research on every culture in order to be a sensitive intercultural communicator; rather, they simply need to be open-minded and patient when speaking with people from different cultures. These basic principles should be applied when coming into contact with someone who acts differently to the general behaviour you are accustomed to.

For example, imagine that you meet an Italian person for the first time during a work conference, and they immediately move in to kiss your cheek as a greeting. If you are not aware that this is considered normal behaviour in Italian culture, you may likely feel that a kiss on the cheek is too intimate or, perhaps, even invasive. In such a situation, you would need to be open-minded and patient with the person who has made you feel uncomfortable, as it is likely that they are unaware of your discomfort. There are also other appropriate ways to address this situation; for example, you can inform this person about your own cultural practices, and why you would prefer them to greet

you differently; or, you could politely ask questions about their culture, in order to understand the history behind the tradition that has confused you.

Making others aware of one's culture

Highlighting the difference between yourself and another person can be a significant part of getting to know them, as long as this is done in a respectful way. If a person happens to offend another by doing something unexpected (e.g. eating with their hands instead of utensils during lunchtime), they could take the chance to explain that, in their culture, it is traditional for people to eat with their hands rather than a knife and fork. However, it is important to note that no one is obligated to share details of their culture with anyone. In other words, people have every right to stay clear of such conversations if they consider them to be unpleasant. In such cases, a person could merely say, 'This is simply the way I like to do things.' If a person *does* choose to share information regarding their cultural practices with others, it is advisable to frame these beliefs and actions as 'a different way of doing things', rather than 'the right way to do things'.

Asking questions about other cultures

There is absolutely nothing wrong with trying to learn more about someone else's culture. Asking other people questions is a healthy way to increase your own understanding, as well as to become more sensitive to someone else's way of life. As long as these questions are appropriate and genuine, it is unlikely that people will take offence to them. You can also encourage others to share their cultural background and traditions, and then thank them when they take the time to do so. Since people are not obligated to share such details, when they choose to do so, it is polite to pay attention and try to remember what was said. Moreover, you could decide to change your behaviour based upon this new information; for example, if someone mentions that it is considered rude to give them a handshake rather than a hug as a form of greeting, you could make a point of changing your actions in order to show respect toward their culture (provided you are comfortable doing so).

When asking such questions, it is important to remember not to attribute everything a person does to their culture, as this can also be considered a form of race-thinking (i.e. where one does not account for the fact that people still have individual personalities and can make their own choices, regardless of their race). For example, it is not acceptable to ask whether the amount of sugar someone puts in their coffee or the way they drive is due to their culture – these are examples of personal preferences, and not something necessarily related to culture. These kinds of questions are commonly expressed by asking, 'Is that an X thing?', where X is replaced with either a cultural or racial identity. However, such questions and statements most often come across as discriminatory. A better question to ask would be, 'Why is it that you do X?', as you are then then giving the other person a chance to explain whether their actions are part of their culture, or merely an expression of their individual personality.

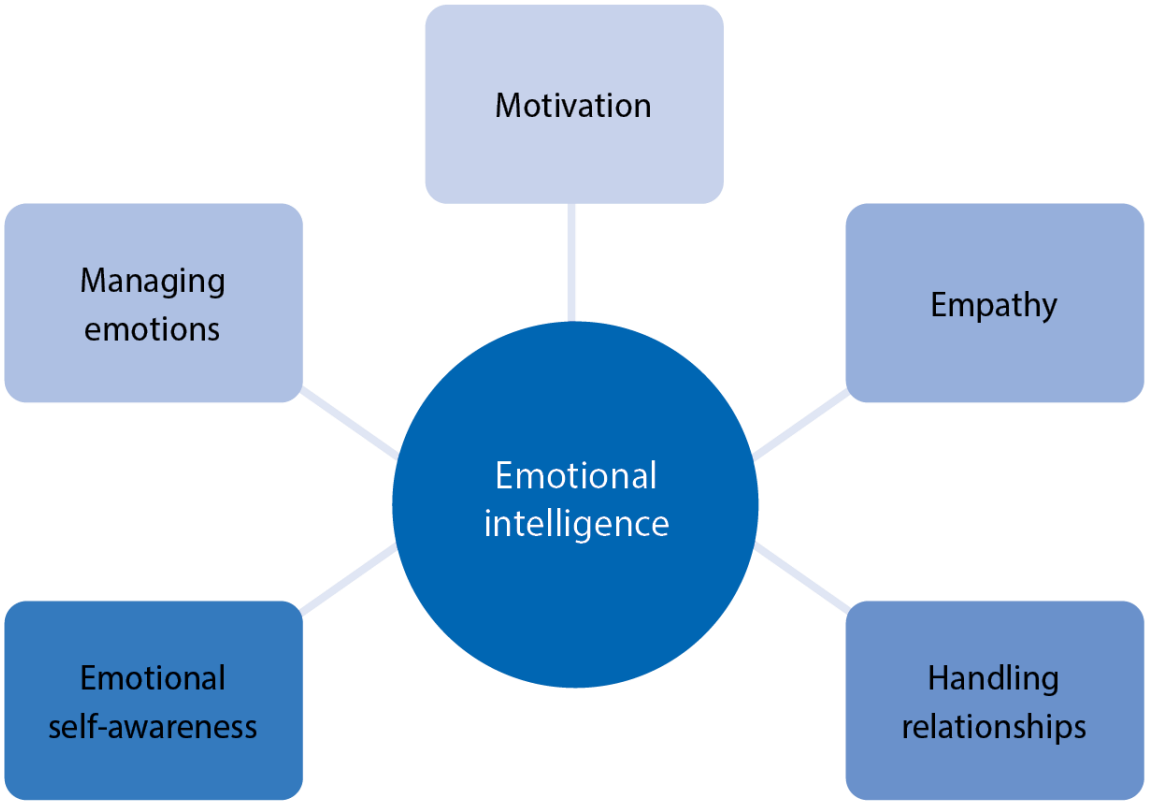
8.5 Intelligences at work

In the current workplace, traditional intelligence measures, such as memory, reasoning, logic and general mental ability, are not enough to ensure a successful career. Instead, emotional intelligence (EQ), social intelligence (SI), virtual intelligence (VI) and artificial intelligence (AI) are becoming increasingly important. Each of these will be discussed in greater detail in the sections to follow.

8.5.1 Emotional intelligence

The ability to tell what other people are feeling, and to change our own state of mind accordingly, is essentially the role of our EQ. It includes the ability to 'accurately perceive emotions, to access and generate emotions so as to assist thought, to understand emotions and emotional knowledge, and to reflectively regulate emotions so as to promote emotional and intellectual growth' (Mayer et al., 2004: 197). EQ is not about being a mind reader, and you are certainly not expected to pick up on every subtle change in someone else's emotions. However, having strong EQ means that you are conscious of your tone of voice when you are engaged in conversation, that you pay attention while others are speaking, and that you reflect on how you are bringing your point across.

While the first academically accepted model of EQ was developed by Mayer and Salovey (1997), it is the work of Goleman (1995) that is the most well-known and commonly accepted model. This model is illustrated in the following figure.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Goleman, 1995: 43)Figure 8.4: Components of emotional intelligence

Emotional self-awareness

Emotional self-awareness involves having a level of self-understanding and insight into why you feel the way you do (Goleman, 1995: 43). Caruso et al. (2002) highlight that self-awareness occurs when we are aware of the full range of our emotions, even those that may be unpleasant, and when we are able to differentiate whether or not an emotion is typical of our usual behaviour. It also includes the knowledge of what we are currently feeling and why we may feel that particular way, as well as an understanding of the impact that these emotions may have on others. Sadri (2012) states that self-awareness includes the management of emotions when necessary; for example, calming down quickly after being angry. Put simply, self-awareness is being conscious of our moods and being able to manage them effectively (Goleman, 1995: 47).

Managing emotions

Emotional management can only take place once you have self-awareness. This is because you can only go on to address your feelings once you are aware of them. For example, if you are given feedback that you do not like, you may feel personally hurt, and your emotional reaction may be to throw a tantrum and shout at the person who you believe is criticising you. This is considered to be poor emotional management, and would only worsen the situation. An alternative response could be to take a step back from your emotions, and to ask yourself how you would like to react to such a situation. An element of this is being effective at self-soothing, which means that you find healthy and constructive ways to comfort yourself and manage your emotions (Goleman, 1995: 43). In other words, you do not allow your emotions to control your decisions, as this can lead you into situations that could negatively affect you in the long run. Goleman (1995: 60–70) discusses how managing emotions may involve controlling your anger, managing anxiety and managing melancholy so that you do not become depressed.

Motivation

The broad definition of motivation is that it is the process that accounts for the intensity, direction and persistence we have in achieving a goal (Robbins and Judge, 2014: 123). If a person has low intensity, no clear direction and gives up quickly, then we would say that they have very little motivation. Persistence also refers to how determined an individual is, how focused on their goal they may be, and not giving up if things go wrong. However, in the context of EQ, motivation involves

channelling neutral or negative emotions into more positive ones, for the purpose of reaching a goal. It involves using your emotion to reach the state of 'flow' in which you can achieve remarkable things and be optimally productive (Goleman, 1995: 43). This includes the ability to use emotion in order to redirect attention to important events, to generate emotions that best facilitate decision-making, and to harness different emotions so as to encourage different approaches to decision-making (Caruso et al., 2002). For example, a positive mood may lead to an individual feeling creative and inspired, whereas a negative mood may lead to them to refusing to perform tasks that they usually enjoy.

Empathy

Empathy branches off from self-awareness, in the sense that if you cannot understand your own emotions, you may not be able to understand the emotions of others. It entails being able to pick up on subtle social cues from others, such as the words they use, and knowing the best way to handle that individual. It can also involve comforting or consoling another person who appears to be in distress. Sadri (2012) notes that empathy not only includes the interpretation of subtle cues, but also includes the interpretation of facial expressions. This can extend as far as reading human behaviour and judging whether or not facial expressions are sincere. Furthermore, it involves having the discernment required to deal with others.

Handling relationships

This final component of EQ involves managing the emotions of others. Handling relationships requires us to have a strong set of social skills, and to demonstrate a high level of social competence (Goleman, 1995: 43). This includes the ability to understand complex emotions, as well as 'emotional chains' (Caruso et al., 2002). Emotional chains exist when emotions pass from one stage to another; for example, when individuals experience grief, they may experience different phases of emotion, such as anger or denial. An individual who is effective at handling relationships will understand the various phases that a person in mourning will go through. Sadri (2012) states that this dimension of EQ may also involve assessing how a person should react to the emotions of others.

Another important consideration in EQ is that of emotional correctness, which is not necessarily a separate component in the make-up of EQ. Rather, it is a type of reaction that can we can train ourselves to have when faced with emotionally evocative confrontations.

Emotional correctness

Emotional correctness refers to when we respond appropriately to situations that involve negative feelings. It also entails knowing how to frame our speech in an attempt to avoid causing negative emotions in others. According to Kohn (2013), emotional correctness lies in 'the tone, the feeling, how we say what we say, [and] the respect and compassion we show one another'. Emotional correctness is therefore not about the *appropriateness* of your opinions or beliefs; rather, it is about the appropriate *expression* of those opinions or beliefs, and the way in which you listen to others when they express their opinions or beliefs in turn.

Most of the communication between co-workers will not be related to race, gender or culture. Rather, people will discuss a range of different issues and topics, each consisting of a different context. For those conversations that do not have clear guidelines, it can be more complicated to determine how to react when people get upset about something that has been said or done. Being 'emotionally correct' therefore involves detecting and knowing when certain actions or emotional reactions are appropriate, as well as maintaining a respectful attitude toward others during times of disagreement or conflict.

No matter where a person comes from, or how they are raised in their family or culture, the ability to feel strong emotions is a universal experience that all humans share. Some of the core emotions experienced cross-culturally include 'amusement, anger, contempt, disgust, envy, fear, grief, guilt, hope, jealousy, joy, lust, pity, pride, regret, and shame' (D'Arms and Jacobson, 2000: 68). It is important to note that people from different cultures do not differ in their ability to *feel* various emotions, but rather, differ only in their *approach* to emotions.

According to Lazarus (1991), a culture's approach to emotions may differ in the following four ways:

1. The way they perceive emotions
2. The way they express emotions
3. How emotions affect their social awareness
4. How they process different emotions through ritualisation

Ritualisation comprises the process of creating patterns of behaviour that continue to last, even when their original function falls away. One example of ritualised behaviour would be the giving of gifts on someone's birthday. Since acts of ritualisation involve using the body to express how a

person feels, it can also be seen as a form of body language. Consequently, it can easily become a barrier to intercultural communication.

Another important aspect of EQ is a person's ability to manage their emotions when they get out of control. This happens most often when serious disagreements take place, or when a person feels disrespected. Although the natural response would be to get angry in these instances, the more appropriate thing to do would be to talk about the differences creating the conflict, in an attempt to gain a deeper understanding of all those involved. In cases where a person feels that legitimate discrimination is occurring, they may approach their management with an official complaint, or go through the appropriate procedures in order to report the issue to the CCMA.

Being emotionally intelligent in the workplace

When conversations cause negative emotions within the workplace, it is everyone's responsibility to be emotionally mature and practise emotional correctness. This approach is similar to the one of political correctness, as emotional correctness involves using appropriate and respectful ways of dealing with difficult situations. It is likely that a person will not get along with everybody they work with; in such cases, they can practise applying the following key points.

Continue to respect others

Although you may disagree with someone else's ideas or views, you can still like, or at least respect, them as a person. The reverse of this is also true: you can agree with another's ideas and views, and not particularly like them as a person. In this sense, it is important to separate individuals from their viewpoints, and to realise that people are always worthy of respect. You should therefore refrain from making generalised statements about people due to their actions, and try to not allow your emotions to take over during conversations. In this way, a person can respectfully disagree with someone, without resorting to mocking the other person's position or attempting to convince others to make fun of them accordingly.

Listen to other points of view

It is always good practice to take the time to understand what other people are saying, as misunderstandings may cause unnecessary negative reactions. One way in which to do this is to ask someone to clarify what they are saying, in order to ensure that you understand where the other person is coming from. You can also ask someone to repeat what was said to them in their own words, which will help to determine what was understood and what was not. In this way, listening effectively will help both sides to change how they are expressing their ideas, in an attempt to aid mutual understanding.

Practise empathy

Empathy is the act of putting yourself in another person's shoes, in order to imagine how the other person may be feeling. By approaching the issue or conflict from another angle, or from the other person's perspective, you may come to understand other people better. This, in turn, may aid conflict resolution. However, in cases where there are intercultural barriers prohibiting understanding, it will be necessary for people to explain their feelings and viewpoints.

Identify any biases

Everyone has particular biases, which is to say, everyone cares more about certain things than others. For example, someone may be biased about using Samsung rather than Nokia phones. Other, more serious biases include avoiding people because they belong to a certain group, or using stereotypes and generalisations about other people, and so on. When a person admits their bias, even if only privately, it can help them to become more emotionally honest and emotionally correct in conversations with others.

Handling emotional incidents

When a particular incident occurs that puts a person in an embarrassing or compromising position with their colleagues, there are a few things they can do to try to resolve the issue (Sills, 2008: 63):

- *Acknowledge it:* When a person simply admits that they have reacted incorrectly, it can go a long way to regaining the respect and trust of their co-workers. An acknowledgement can be as simple as, 'I know I overreacted,' or they could explain why they believe the disagreement happened in the first place. This will show others that they have the ability to reflect on their emotions, and that they are able to determine when they have crossed the line.
- *Apologise:* It is likely that an incorrect emotional response will upset other people, so a person should apologise if they caused others discomfort in this respect. A person can say, 'I am sorry that I reacted that way,' which may possibly require no further discussion.

Apologies also acknowledge the emotional incident in a way that allows others to see that the person has considered them and their emotions – this is a sign of emotional intelligence.

- *Spin it:* Attributing a person's emotional response and outburst to something that does not relate to the incident is one way of spinning the situation in order to make it seem as if the person has not, in actual fact, become upset by their co-workers. A person can say something like, 'Having the flu really makes me grumpy; have you noticed?' This would show other people that the person is not completely ignoring the situation, but that they were, perhaps, not fully in control of their actions either.
- *Cover it up:* If a person does not want to address the issue head-on, they can make reference to it through other means, in an attempt to cover it up. One way of doing this is to say something to the effect of, 'I am so excited about this project that sometimes I just want to jump up and shout!' This will make light of the event in a way that lets other people know that the person is aware of their emotional outburst, but that they do not see it in a negative way.
- *Ignore it:* The last way a person could approach an emotional incident is to ignore that it has happened and try to move on. This relies on the EQ of others – they have to be able to see and respect that the person is, perhaps, embarrassed or not interested in bringing it up. This can be interpreted as a form of denial or a sign of pride, in that the person is ignoring the situation because they cannot bring themselves to admit their mistake.

The last two points (i.e. to ignore or cover up an emotional incident) are not the most effective ways of resolving a problem. However, they do provide an alternative means of defusing a difficult situation if nothing else seems to be working.

In conclusion, emotional correctness is a way of managing relationships by trying to react appropriately to any given situation. The better a person's emotional correctness, the higher a person's chances of maintaining good relationships in the office.

8.5.1.1 Emotional intelligence as a crucial aspect of success

Goleman (1995: 36) argues that as much as 80 per cent of an individual's success can be attributed to EQ, with only 20 per cent resulting from their IQ. Previously, it was assumed that people with higher IQs were naturally more intelligent, that they were able to perform work that is more complex or sophisticated, and that they had better memories, better logic and more sound reasoning. Although we may think that someone who has a high IQ would be fit to be in the position of a manager, this has proven to be wrong time and time again.

While IQ is necessary for an individual to be able to acquire and use certain skills, EQ has proven to be far more important in positions of management. This is because people who have a higher EQ are able to relate well to others, pick up on subtle cues in conversation and form good relationships with colleagues. In general, those with a higher EQ will be more likely to understand the people they are working with. This means that they are more prepared to adjust their behaviour according to what is expected from them.

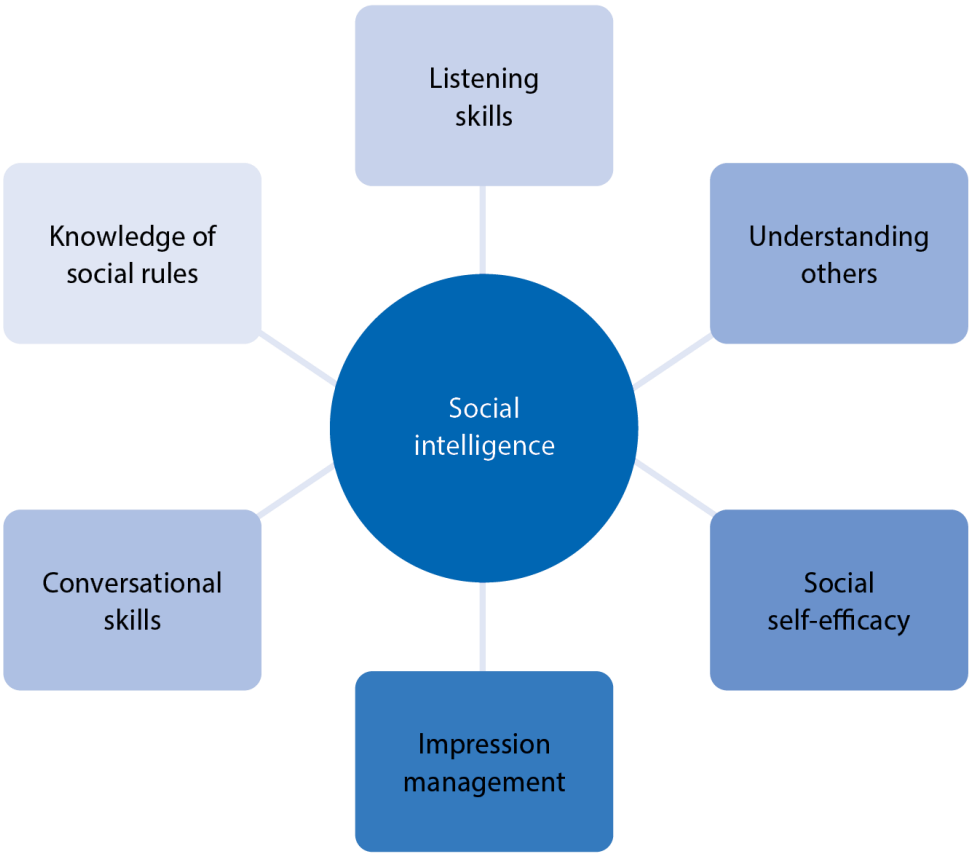
For example, imagine that you have two managers to report to. One is a very formal, older manager who likes to be addressed by his title, Mr. Bakker, rather than on a first-name basis. He likes being kept in the loop consistently when you are working, and has no interest in becoming friends with you. The other manager, Phatiswa, is younger, less formal and prefers to deal with you on a first-name basis. She likes to casually joke around a lot, and is clearly interested in building a relationship with you, to the point that she would even like you to join social meetings with her after work. This manager does not want step-by-step feedback of what you are doing, but rather, prefers you to come to her only when an issue arises.

EQ will help you to pick up on the correct ways in which to interact with these different managers. When you interact with people in a way that makes them feel comfortable, they will feel that the interaction is more genuine. When they feel that you are genuine with them, they are more likely to consider you favourably regarding performance reviews, promotions or increases. This is a simple illustration of how EQ can contribute to your success within the workplace.

8.5.2 Social intelligence

A broader view of our interactions involves the concept of SI (Goleman, 2006: 5). SI refers to our understanding of how to deal with other people, based on our previous successes and failures in social settings (Riggio and Reichard, 2008). This concept could also be referred to as tact, common sense or street smarts. Goleman (2006: 11) highlights the importance of good social interactions by stating that they can have a long-lasting impact on the way in which a person is able to form personal

connections throughout their life. The author also notes that SI emphasises that we all have a need to connect with other people – we struggle to exist without some form of social contact. However, in order to ensure that interactions between people lead to positive outcomes, a good rapport (connection) should be established. This can be done through displaying appropriate body language, reading the facial expressions and body language of others carefully, and timing when you bring up different topics (Goleman, 2006: 33). Goleman (2006: 52–53) notes that people with higher levels of SI are those who show compassion in the correct scenarios and are deemed to be altruistic (selfless) in their behaviour. Riggio and Reichard (2008) simplify the concept of SI and includes the following six key components.



(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Riggio and Reichard, 2008)Figure 8.5: Components of social intelligence

Conversational skills

Simply put, people with good conversational skills are those who know how to 'work the room'. They can talk to anyone about anything, and have no trouble striking up easy and natural conservation with each person they come into contact with. They are also typically able to understand how a conversation is flowing, and how to adjust themselves or the topic accordingly. Such a person will demonstrate great tact and be appropriate in what they say to others.

Knowledge of social rules

People who have high SI have a good understanding of how different roles require different social rules or norms, otherwise known as *etiquette*. For example, they understand that they would not typically hug their boss when arriving at work every day; however, they may do this in their group of friends. Appropriate topics of conversation, and whether to interject into a conversation that is already happening, are other considerations that knowledge of social rules will allow you to understand. As a result of this, people who have good knowledge of social rules may come across as socially wise or sophisticated.

Listening skills

In order to have a high level of SI, it is necessary to be an effective listener. Many people in social situations simply wait for a gap where they can speak again, rather than actually listening to what the other person is saying. As evidence shows, truly listening will result in more intelligent

responses, and often, this can lead to people feeling like they have a better connection with someone.

Understanding others

Often, those with high SI can be found merely watching or listening to others. They will do this in order to gather more information surrounding the context within which they find themselves. Furthermore, they will attempt to read what others are feeling or thinking based on their body language and what they are saying. This helps them to better understand what makes others tick.

Social self-efficacy

The concept of social self-efficacy means that someone is able to handle themselves socially and be comfortable in any situation that is presented. For example, the role you play at work, with your friends, and at home with your family may be vastly different. However, if you have a high level of SI, you will feel confident in managing all of these roles, and will have a firm understanding of how to switch between them with ease.

Impression management

This is the process of attempting to manage the image you portray to others. A person with a good level of SI will ensure that they come across in the way they intend to, but at the same time, will ensure that the impression they give is not fake or insincere – the impression should still reflect who they really are. This is thought to be the most complex element of SI, as we need to balance our outward presence with our authentic personality.

The forms of intelligence within the workplace have moved past the strict limits of social interactions between people and, due to revolutionary technology, now also include virtual and artificial intelligence. These forms of intelligence will be discussed in the sections that follow.

8.5.3 Virtual intelligence

Mills (2018) states that VI is something that has been around and used for many years – it is actually something that we use as often as every day. One example of this type of intelligence is a cell phone, which can perform a number of tasks for us at the push of a few buttons. Devices that rely on VI may often seem intelligent, but in actual fact, they are simply very scientifically advanced. In other words, these devices take inputs and calculate an output as a response; however, they cannot decide to act on their own. Any device that is virtually intelligent is not able to make a decision without direct input from a person at some point in the process (Mills, 2018).

8.5.3.1 Virtual intelligence applications

There are a number of applications that are used both in business and in everyday life. For example, Google Maps provides navigation instructions by reading out directions as the driver heads toward their destination. Waze, which is very similar to Google Maps, also provides the driver with directions. Both of these apps can provide information regarding roadworks or traffic jams.

Many people also make use of the Fitbit or Garmin app, which an individual uses to track their health by counting the number of steps walked in a day, the distance of a running exercise, or the number of calories burned during an exercise session. Apple's built-in assistant, Siri, and Amazon's Alexa are examples of virtual assistants that are able to search for information when asked questions, make phone calls when instructed to do so, and send messages to other people.

8.5.4 Artificial intelligence

AI involves machines that are able to use their own reasoning in order to make decisions – this is the direction that business aims to head in (Mills, 2018). Rather than working on a simple input/output system like VI, AI has the ability to learn, consider different variables and make decisions based on multiple sets of data. It is believed that, in the future, important elements like manufacturing and transportation will become completely reliant on AI. Cheung (2019) provides examples of five companies that are already making use of AI in the workplace, as discussed in the following table.

Company	Use of AI
Deloitte	This company has teamed up with a consulting agency to develop machine-learning technology that is used to scan thousands of complex documents and extract relevant information for analysis.

Niles	Niles makes use of an add-on to the Slack messaging platform that records conversations, so that it can keep learning. Slack is used for messaging between colleagues and is split into relevant channels.
AISense	This is an AI start-up that records conversations and makes them searchable. The company is in the process of creating an app that can make, as well as transcribe, calls.
SAP CoPilot	This is a virtual assistant that assists with tasks such as purchasing contracts and working in collaboration with employees.
WalkMe	This app provides those in the medical profession with assistance and training on how to use a particular system, and provides personalised tips on how to improve.

(Source: EDGE Learning Media (Pty) Ltd, 2019; adapted from Cheung, 2019)
Table 8.3: Practical applications of AI in the workplace
The core difference between VI and AI is that VI is unable to make decisions, while AI can.
FAST FORWARD: Social intelligence – Future forecasts
Kaylin is a bookkeeper who works for Nozzby, a UK-based company; however, her job is unconventional, as she does all of her work online, from the comfort of her own home in Cape Town. Nozzby is a business consulting agency that provides all and any business needs to its clients around the world, using outsourced employees to broaden the reach of its services.
Kaylin never feels like she is at a disadvantage working from home rather than in a traditional office, because she has easy access to the accounting information she needs in order to manage the Nozzby accounts she is responsible for. Furthermore, she works flexible hours, finds the work interesting, and has the opportunity to talk to many other colleagues who work from all over the world.
However, recently, Kaylin feels like she has been having a misunderstanding with one of the on-site managers of Nozzby. Often, when she submits a query, she gets a response that comes across as abrupt and rude, and as if the on-site manager is annoyed by Kaylin's email. Not sure what else to do, Kaylin asks her manager whether there is anything she can do differently, or anything that will make things more convenient for him, to which she receives yet another abrupt response.
Kaylin decides that, perhaps, she is taking it personally and misreading the tone of the manager's emails. She therefore asks to have a Skype meeting in order to discuss some financials. The Skype meeting is a great success, and Kaylin comes to see that the manager is actually very friendly and easy to talk to – contrary to the abrupt tone of his emails.
Kaylin soon realises that, perhaps, SI for the digital age is different, and she thinks about how she will need to find the best way to communicate with colleagues who work remotely. She realises that something like an email should not always be taken at face value, as there is not always an obvious tone, and there are no facial expressions included in an email. This is a classic example of how SI – in the traditional sense – could become challenging as more and more jobs become online-based.

8.6 Summary

This unit has covered political correctness, intercultural communication and emotional correctness. By discussing these three concepts, you will have learned about the history and challenges we all face in the workplace and, most importantly, how to approach them so that no harm is inflicted on others. Let's review some of the major points that have been covered in each of these three sections.
Political correctness is a way of thinking that seeks to use the most appropriate and respectful means of language and action to communicate with others. It can be defined as avoiding 'offensive language, prejudiced attitudes, and insulting behavior towards the marginalized' (Hughes, 2010: 8). This unit dealt specifically with political correctness in its relation to gender and race, and emphasised a few key points that one should remember regarding political correctness in each context. For gender, the key issues include sexual harassment (i.e. physical, verbal and non-verbal), the wage gap and feminism. For race, the key issues include race-thinking, employment equity and black economic empowerment (BEE).
Effective intercultural communication refers to the act of successfully communicating across different and unique cultures and subcultures. At its core, it is similar to any other form of communication, as intercultural communication can be 'considered to be purposeful—to persuade,

inform, or entertain' and to achieve these objectives by 'interacting with someone' (Samovar et al., 2012: 9). Applying certain techniques effectively will ensure successful and respectful intercultural communication; these techniques include appropriateness, effectiveness, verbal communication and non-verbal communication, and avoiding ethnocentrism. Barriers to intercultural communication should also be noted, which can include differences in language proficiency, body language and social etiquette. Lastly, this unit elaborated on various forms of intelligence in the workplace, including emotional intelligence, social intelligence, virtual intelligence and artificial intelligence.